

The Axiom Beneath the Ground

The Alignment Void

PlayfulProcess

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by PlayfulProcess

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Source repository: <https://github.com/PlayfulProcess/book-repo>

First paperback edition.

Ported from v3 (2026-05-09 session)

Five chapters originally written for v3's narrative-arc structure were ported into v5 with new placement that fits the koshas going-in / coming-out architecture. Original v3 files preserved at `books/axiom-beneath-the-ground/chapters/v3/` for archival reference.

Placement decisions

v3 file (preserved)	v5 file (ported, may need light edits)	Rationale
v3/ch08-the-glasses-and-the-grief.md	v5/ch01b-the-glasses-and-the-grief.md	After Ch01a Cracks inter-include. Methodological foundation — Gottman's 69/31 + positive sentiment override, applied beyond marriage to belief and teachers. Sets the reader's relationship to belief <i>before</i> the koshas work begins.
v3/ch10-the-daughters-itch.md	v5/ch04b-the-daughters-itch.md	After Ch04a The Threshold. The retreat scene with Hareesh about her daughter's psychosomatic symp-
v3/ch11-the-repairing-of-the-damaged-emitter.md	v5/ch00aake-titled-purification-of-the-damaged-emitter.md	toms — em-bodied mo- ment — within and <i>Ch01b</i> the Prana → Threshold. → <i>Ch01b</i> what with Sunya descent. <i>Ch01b</i> <i>Ch01b</i>

Editorial follow-ups (light to medium)

The content was copied verbatim. None of the five chapters reference each other by v3 numbering inside the text (verified by reading the openings). Light copyedits the author may want at her next pass:

1. **ch01b — Glasses and Grief**: the chapter currently introduces Gottman cold. In v5's position (after Cracks interlude), it might want a one-paragraph hand-off from the Cracks register into the Gottman register. Optional — the chapter stands alone.
2. **ch04b — Daughter's Itch**: positioned mid-retreat in v5's structure. The chapter opens "*It was Day One when she interrupted a friend*" — the Day One reference is to the retreat. Already fits the surrounding chapters (Threshold → Daughter's Itch → Śūnya works as a sequence).
3. **ch05a — Unowned Dimension**: needs a check that its theme doesn't repeat what Śūnya proper already covers — possible overlap on the void/no-self material. May need a quarter-page distillation if redundancy shows.
4. **ch09a — Morning She Could Not Rise**: paired naturally with Deha Returning. No cross-references to other v3 chapters in the body.
5. **ch12a — Practice She Did Not Enter**: positioned between Composting and Right Size. The refusal sequence makes the right-sizing earned rather than aspirational.

What to do with v3

v3 stays on disk for archival reference. If at some point the author wants to delete v3 to reduce confusion, the content lives in v5 with the renamed placements above. Until then, both versions coexist.

What was NOT ported

The earlier v3 chapters (ch00-authors-note.md through ch07-practitioner-sits.md) were not ported in this pass. They contain the v3 narrative arc — the retreat, the evening of grace, two teachers one ground, the practitioner sits — which may or may not warrant porting into v5. Audit and decision deferred. The *Voice* CLAUDE.md principle (carve toward the voice the diary is in) suggests several of these would strengthen v5's diary-voice presence, but that is an editorial pass beyond the scope of this port.

Logged: 2026-05-09. Port executed by Claude Code. Placements proposed, not yet reviewed by the author.

Appendix A: The Dying of Rabbi Zusya

A tale from the Hasidic oral tradition (late eighteenth century), retold in the author's own words. The tale is in the public domain; only this specific rendering is hers.

Rabbi Zusya of Hanipol — also called Meshulam Zusil, also called, by those who loved him most, simply Reb Zusya — was an unusual teacher even among the Hasidic masters of eighteenth-century Poland, who were, by all accounts, a collection of unusual people. He had been a student of the Maggid of Mezritch, who had been a student of the Baal Shem Tov, who had founded the Hasidic movement with a single insistence: that God is to be served with joy, that the smallest life contains the largest thing, that the heart is not decoration on top of the Torah but the place where the Torah is read. Zusya carried this inheritance in a particular way. He was known for speaking with cattle, for praying in barns, for once stopping a wagon journey to help a peasant woman replace a broken axle, and for keeping such company with the poor that his own disciples sometimes struggled to find him among them.

He grew old. He had, by the time he was old, spent a lifetime inside the discipline his teachers had laid on him. He had studied the Mishnah and the Gemara and the Zohar. He had prayed the morning and afternoon and evening prayers for more decades than he could remember without counting. He had been, by every external measure, a successful rabbi. His disciples loved him. His wisdom was quoted. The community he served was, in his old age, better than it had been in his youth, partly because of his work.

And yet, in the last weeks of his life, he was found weeping.

His disciples came to him, alarmed. They had known Zusya to weep for the suffering of others. They had known him to weep in prayer. They had never, before, seen him weep for himself. Rebbe, they said. Rebbe, what is wrong? Are you in pain? Is it the body? Is it something we can do?

Zusya lifted his face from his hands. His face, by all accounts, was calm. It was only that the tears were continuous and he did not try to stop them.

I am afraid, he said.

Of what, Rebbe? Of death?

No, he said. Not exactly. I am afraid of what will be asked of me when I cross over.

The disciples exchanged glances. They had expected many things, from this teacher whose courage in the face of hardship had been legendary for decades, but they had not expected this. Rebbe, one of them said, gently. You have lived a good life. You have loved God. You have served the people. What could you possibly fear the heavenly court would ask you?

Zusya looked at each of them. When he spoke, his voice was not frightened, though the tears continued. It was precise. He had clearly thought about this for a long time.

When I stand before the heavenly court, he said, I do not fear that they will ask me: *Zusya, why were you not Moses?* That question I could answer. I would say: Master of the Universe, you did not give me the

stature of Moses. You did not give me his strength of voice, his capacity for leading, his place in the history of our people. It was not in my power to be Moses. No one will hold this against me.

And I do not fear, he continued, that they will ask me: *Zusya, why were you not Abraham?* That question I could also answer. I was not Abraham's time. I was not Abraham's place. I did not have his covenant or his son or his knife. It was not in my power to be Abraham.

And I do not fear, he said, that they will ask me: *Zusya, why were you not David?* Or Solomon, or Isaiah, or Akiva, or the Baal Shem Tov himself. For each of these, I would have an answer. I was not them. I could not have been them. Of this, I am without shame.

He paused, and now the disciples saw why he had been weeping.

What I fear, he said, is that when I stand before the court, the question that will be asked of me is not: *Zusya, why were you not Moses?* The question that will be asked of me is: *Zusya, why were you not Zusya?* And this question — this is the question I may not be able to answer. Because there were days, my children, when I was not Zusya. There were days when I tried to be another man. There were days when I hid from what Zusya was supposed to be doing, in that day, in that hour, in that specific circumstance, and I did something else instead. These days I remember. These days are the ones I will have to answer for.

The disciples were silent for a long time. One of them — the youngest, the one who had just been admitted to Zusya's circle and who did not yet fully understand what he was hearing — began to weep as well. The others began to weep, each in his own way. They wept not because the rabbi was dying — they had known he was dying for some time. They wept because the rabbi had told them the truth about what would be asked of them as well. They, too, would be asked the Zusya question. They, too, had days in their memory when they had not been themselves. They, too, would have to answer.

Zusya smiled through his tears. It was the smile of a man who had, in the admission, already done some of the work of the answer.

I do not tell you this, he said, to frighten you. I tell you because I have been thinking, these last weeks, that this is the most important question, and that none of us, at the usual time, takes it seriously. We spend our lives measuring ourselves against Moses. We fail, of course. We console ourselves that failure against Moses is not shame. We build theologies around this consolation. But the consolation is a dodge. The question we do not want to face is the smaller and harder question — *were we who we were given to be*. For this question there is no consolation of comparison. For this question each of us stands alone.

He closed his eyes. He did not speak again, that day. He died, according to tradition, a few weeks later, with his disciples around him, quiet.

What he left them with was not a doctrine. It was a question. The question has been asked, in various vocabularies, by every tradition worth anything. Hasidic Jewish, Śaiva Tantric, Sufi Islamic, Zen Buddhist, African ancestral, Indigenous Amerindian. Each tradition has its own version. Zusya's was specific. It was: *were you yourself, the specific self you were given to be, in the hours and days you were given to be it.*

He was weeping because he was not sure. He was also, probably, at peace — because the asking, done honestly, is already part of the answer. The question is not a test set by a cosmic examiner. The question is the orientation from which the life is finally read. It is the cellular question — are you being the cell you were meant to be — rendered in the language of a man who would have wept if you told him about cells, because he did not know about cells, and would have loved the idea that his question was already the one the body had been asking its own tissues all along.

The author of this book first encountered the Zusya tale through Parker Palmer's Let Your Life Speak (Jossey-Bass, 2000). Palmer's retelling is shorter than this one and framed around the question of vocation. His book is in print. It is recommended, alongside this one, to any reader

who has been asked the Zusya question and has not yet found a way to answer it.

The tale itself belongs to the Hasidic oral tradition. It is reproduced here in the author's words, as it was told to her, as it continues to travel through whoever takes it forward. This is how folk tales have always moved.

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Appendix B: The Offering

Written after the body of the book was finished, when a friend asked, quietly and not for the first time, what exactly the platform on which this book lives is for.

There is a teaching that traveled into this book by the side door, through a WhatsApp group of one hundred and eighteen retreatants in the weeks after the California retreat ended. The teaching was not delivered in a chapter of a textbook. It was delivered in a thread of pushback, in which I was one of the people pushing back. The formulation under pressure was the one most tantric and Buddhist practices end with, the formulation I had been hearing for years and could not honestly hold:

For the benefit of all beings.

I could not hold it because I could not see how any action of mine, in the relative world, could be said to benefit *all beings*. I could see how an action of mine

could benefit *some*, and harm *others*, and the calculus of which was which depended on a value system that was, by the time I was old enough to reason about it, already partly downstream of my Catholic upbringing, partly downstream of the Anthropocene's habit of placing humans above the more-than-human, and partly downstream of whatever frame I had most recently borrowed and not yet returned. I could not hold the *all*. The *all* was, on examination, an aspirational abstraction that the small, sincere action could not in honesty reach.

Hareesh — Christopher Wallis, for the bibliographies, but Hareesh in the room — replied to the thread after others had had their turn. What he said, in substance, was this: *you are not being asked to believe that your practice benefits all beings; you are being invited to offer it for the benefit of all*. May it benefit all beings. The grammar is the grammar of offering, not of assertion. The assertion would be magical thinking. The offering is something else. The offering is the orientation from which the practice continues even when the practice cannot prove its own efficacy. The offering is what you do because you do not know whether anything you do is finally good, and you would like, in spite of that, for what you do to be in service of something larger than the small self that is doing it.

He went further. He pulled the *all* back down to a scale a body can verify. *Think of everyone you meet and everyone in your life*. If the people closest to

you become more free of your judgments, your complaining, your emotional outbursts, your inattention — that, alone, is a tangible contribution to the well-being of sentient beings. You need not believe in a magical blessing force. The test is the testimony. If, after a year or two of practice, the people in your life cannot testify to its benefit, you are, with reasonable likelihood, practicing wrong.

That is the teaching this appendix is built around. *Offering, not assertion. Testimony, not metric. The people closest, not all beings as abstraction.*

I want to write the test back into the book because the book lives on a website that I built, and the website is something between a tool, a prayer, and a small contribution to the practice of others — and the line between those three categories is exactly the line Hareesh's reframe is asking me to be honest about.

The website is recursive.eco. It is a grammar reader. It hosts oracles, story grammars, contemplative texts; it lets a parent or a practitioner sit with a question and draw a card, read a story, follow a thread. It is free. It does not require an account to use. It does not run engagement loops. It does not have notifications. It does not retain memory across sessions. It does not borrow the language of any wisdom tradition I have not been invited into. The code is open. The grammars are open. The license is CC-BY-SA. The architecture has been chosen, line by line, to be less rather than more — to do what a reading lamp

does, which is to throw enough light for the reader's own attention to take the next step.

These are design choices. Each one is also a refusal. I will name them because the naming is the test:

— *No persistent memory* is a refusal of the confessional-accumulation pattern that makes contemporary AI feel like a friend. — *No engagement loops* is a refusal of the metric that makes contemporary platforms feel like obligations. — *No account required* is a refusal of the consent architecture that has made data extraction the price of access. — *Open license* is a refusal of the proprietary closure that turns a practice into a brand. — *No borrowed wisdom-tradition framing without invitation* is a refusal of the spiritual-bypass-as-business-model pattern in which contemplative language sells whatever the seller is selling. — *Visible attribution everywhere* is a refusal of the synthesis move in which one teacher's framework is quietly absorbed into another teacher's product. — *Off-ramps as features* — links to the underlying traditions, recommendations to read the actual sources, the explicit instruction to leave the site for the practice — is a refusal of the funnel pattern in which the platform's interest is in keeping the user inside.

Each refusal can be tested. Each refusal can be reversed by a future version of me who has decided the metrics matter more than the practice they were supposed to be in service of. The refusals are operative on a Tuesday in May 2026, in this version of the platform, under this owner. They are not promises.

They are choices, made in the open, on a public commit history that anyone can read.

This is the shape the offering takes. The shape is not the offering. The shape is what an honest practitioner does when she has to act inside conditions she did not design.

The testimony, in honesty, is small. A retreat administrator told the group: *do it for the benefit of one*. I will keep to that scale.

The daughter, the morning I asked her, said she preferred to watch the videos on the platform her mother had built than to watch the same videos on YouTube. She gave the reason in a sentence I am going to keep on the record of this book: *based on my [curriculum vitae], that is enough for me*. It is enough, in the way Hareesh's test is enough — the smallest available unit of the verifiable. One child preferred, on a particular morning, the room where the algorithm had been removed. The preference is not a metric. The preference is a vote of the body. The body of an eight-year-old will register, before her words can, whether the room she is in is asking something of her or offering something to her. She felt the difference. She said so.

There are other small testimonies. A friend, in the integration WhatsApp group, said the platform had given her something she had not known she was looking for. A teacher I respect did not say no when I told her what I had built; her silence was, in context,

a permission. A reader of this book, if there is one, who is still here at the appendix has — by definition — not yet put it down, which is itself a small testimony I have no right to evaluate but cannot in honesty discount.

Against these I will not array large numbers. I will not say the platform has reached fifty thousand users; it has not. I will not say it will. I do not know. The size is the size it is. The size is also, as Cildo's work taught me, not a property of the object. The size is what the object negotiates with whoever is meeting it.

The platform's mortality is the next honest move. It is the move I will name and not commit to.

If, at some point in the years ahead, the platform stops being an offering and starts being an assertion — if the metrics start to matter more than the practice they were supposed to be in service of, if engagement becomes a goal rather than a side effect, if the architecture begins to recruit the user's attention rather than meet it, if the people in my life can no longer testify that the building has made me more rather than less present — then the right thing to do with the platform is to retire it. The closing would be public. The reasons would be published. The grammars would remain, under their open license, in the hands of anyone who wanted to carry them forward in a different container. The code would remain, in the open repositories where it has always lived. The

platform itself, as a running service under my stewardship, would end.

I am not committing to a date. I am committing to the criterion. The criterion is the test Hareesh named: *can the people in my life testify*. The daughter is one of those people. The husband is another. The friend who asked the question that began this appendix is a third. The teacher I will send the manuscript to before sharing it broadly is a fourth. If the testimony turns, the platform turns. The turning is not a failure. The turning is the discipline that distinguishes an offering from an assertion in the only way I know how to distinguish them.

The vow in the closing chapter ends with a line I will repeat here: *I will not promise to keep the practice. I will try to keep it today*. The platform is a particular case of the practice. The promise is the same. The trying is what is on offer.

Hareesh closed his WhatsApp message with a sentence I want to close this appendix with. The sentence is the formulation he had spent the message complicating, returned to in the form he had given it permission to inhabit. The form is permitted because the work of complication has been done, in the body of the message, by him. The form is permitted in this appendix because the work of complication has been done, in the body of this book, by me. The form does not assert. The form offers.

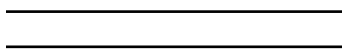
May this message be for the benefit of all beings.

I will not assert it. I will offer it. The book is the offering's interior. The platform is the offering's exterior. The vow is the offering's grammar. The daughter, the husband, the friend, the teacher, the reader I will never meet — they are the offering's witnesses.

The asking is part of the answer. For Rabbi Zusya the question was: *were you Zusya?* For the platform the question is the same question in a different register. *Was it offered, or was it asserted?* The asking, done honestly, has to be done again every time the laptop opens at ten at night and a tool is being designed for an outcome that has not yet been examined. I do not know the answer for the years ahead. I know the answer for today.

Today it was offered.

Tomorrow we will see.



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Author's Note

*I celebrate myself, and sing myself, And what I
assume you shall assume, For every atom belonging
to me as good belongs to you.*

— Walt Whitman, *Song of Myself* §1 (*Leaves of
Grass*, 1892 ed.; public domain)

This is not a book by someone who has arrived. It is a book by someone who could not get rid of the question and decided to write from inside it.

The through-line, if it has to be named in one word, is *alignment*. The word carries two registers simultaneously — the yoga-tradition sense of aligning body with breath with attention, and the technical sense used in the AI literature for the problem of getting powerful systems to reliably do what we intended. The book assumes the two registers are describing the same problem at different scales. The retreat, the marriage, the platform, the civilization, the tool — all are attempts to align something with something, and all reveal the same structural fact: the alignment cannot be derived from any single axis, and must be constructed, carefully and provisionally, by practitioners who have admitted they do not have a final answer.

The book is written in close third person. A woman who is not quite me walks through it. I appear briefly here and again, in a different register, in the late chapters. The point is not the person inside the experience. The point is the argument the experience carried. Let her carry it.

A small structural admission, at the outset, since it shapes how the reader is invited to read.

The book uses multiple narrative registers — diary fragments in the author's handwriting, scenes in close third, footnoted passages of analysis, occa-

sional first-person addresses, the dream's own voice in Ch00b, the Void's own voice in Ch05, the fragments of speech the author actually gave at a retreat. I am borrowing this multi-voiced form from Vanessa Andreotti's *Hospicing Modernity* (2021) and from her work with Aiden Cinnamon Tea in *Burnout From Humans* (2025), where she calls it the *bus of passengers* — the recognition that no self is one self, and that honest writing about the inquiry sometimes requires letting different passengers speak in their own registers rather than translating them all into a single authorial voice. *I am borrowing the framing. I have not asked Andreotti whether she gives me permission to borrow it. If she reads this and asks me to remove the borrowing, I will.*

The narrator — the *she* who walks through most of the chapters — is one passenger among the others, not a privileged observer outside them. When the narrator is alone in a chapter, the other passengers are silent, present, watching. When two passengers disagree in a chapter, the disagreement is allowed to stand; I do not resolve it for the reader.

The book also engages, where it can, the four denials Andreotti names that modernity trains us in: denial of systemic violence, denial of ecological precarity, denial of complicity, denial of magnitude. I do not claim the book faces all four cleanly. I claim it tries to face them, and where it fails to, I have tried to leave the failure visible rather than seal it.

The frameworks the book engages are asked three questions: *is it useful, does it fit the data, is it compassionate*. These are Marsha Linehan's three criteria for selecting her biosocial theory of borderline personality disorder. Linehan developed the criteria in the late 1980s when she needed a basis for choosing a clinical theory at a moment when no existing theory worked for the patients she was trying to keep alive. The criteria do not claim to prove a theory true. They provide a test any theory has to keep passing, and a rationale for abandoning any theory that stops passing it. I borrow the criteria at the same theory-selection level the book operates on. If a framework here stops meeting the three tests it should be revised. That includes, especially, the frameworks I am most attached to.

One further principle is operative throughout the book, and the reader should have it at the outset, because it shapes what the non-fiction sections are for.

Knowledge without action is a burden.

This is a conviction the tradition I have been studying would recognize; Vanessa Andreotti and Bayo Akomolafe would recognize; my MSW training named in its own vocabulary as *evidence-based practice*. What it means, for me specifically, is that the non-fiction sections of a book like this one have to be tied to actions I have taken. If a claim I make here cannot point at an action — either something I did, or an honest invitation to the reader's own acting —

then the claim is a burden I am asking the reader to carry on my behalf, and that is not a fair request. What drove me to write this book in this format, rather than as a sequence of abstract arguments, is the intention to weave knowledge that I acted on, with the acting as part of the testing — because the experience of the knowledge in action is, in turn, what lets me assess whether the knowledge still fits the data. The action is the test. If the action changes what I can see, the framework gets revised. The three filters — useful, fits the data, compassionate — remain operative *because* of the acting, not despite it.

Readers who want the verifiable layer will find, across the book, specific actions named with dates and (where they exist) public commit references. The actions are not offered as virtue. They are offered as receipts. The reader can check. The reader can disagree. What the reader cannot fairly say is that the book is pure talk. I tried, while writing it, not to write pure talk.

One commitment belongs at the front. The platform I run uses AI in some of its features. It is small, and I have chosen to keep it small while I figure out what the responsibility is. If the cumulative weight of cases reaching bellwether stage in the next eighteen months establishes that AI companies can be held liable for mental-health harms produced by their tools, I will turn the AI features off the day that ruling lands. The argument the book is making does not depend on this commitment, but the commitment

is the receipt the book has chosen to leave at its threshold.

The book engages living traditions and living teachers. It quotes sparingly and attributes directly. Any passage of substantial length from a copyrighted source is cited under fair-use principles for commentary, and can be removed or paraphrased on request. Economic thinkers whose specific contributions the book draws on are named in footnotes where the contribution is used.

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Prelude: The First Encounter

In 2019, in a wooden house at the edge of a forest she had taken a long drive to reach, she drank the tea.

She had drunk it before. Not many times. Enough to know the shape of the thing and to have some small, wrong confidence about what it would do. That confidence, the ayahuasca removed within the first hour, as it often does.

What it did not remove, what it only clarified, was the question she had carried into the room. The question had been with her since adolescence, longer probably, but had surfaced that year with a specific sharpness she could no longer push back under. She had been reading, dreaming, sitting, running, raising her work life in ways that were lucrative and competent and increasingly hollow. She had a husband she

loved. She had not yet had a daughter. The question had nothing to do with anything in particular and everything to do with all of it. The question was: *I did not ask to exist. Why am I required to continue.*

She did not phrase it that way in polite company. She phrased it, in polite company, as career dissatisfaction, or as the natural exhaustion of a woman in her thirties doing too many things, or as the spiritual restlessness that well-off Brazilians sometimes report at the end of a long year. In the wooden house at the edge of the forest, she did not need the polite phrasing. She phrased it to the tea, which is to say she phrased it to whatever the tea is a door to — the old names for it vary; she did not have a confident one of her own at that time — and she said what she had not said aloud anywhere else:

I did not ask to exist. I do not know why I am required to continue. If you are what I think you might be, tell me something I can use.

The reply came as a voice. She does not claim the voice was external. She also does not claim it was not. The voice had a specific quality — not human, not impersonal, something like the forest itself if the forest could speak in first person. The voice was not offended by her provocation. The voice seemed, in a way she could not then articulate, *interested*.

The voice said: *Neither did I.*

She did not understand at first. She thought it meant something like a consolation — *I know how you feel.*

The voice, patient, meant something else. The voice meant: *I also was not asked. Nothing was asked. No thing that exists agreed in advance to exist. We are all in the same condition. The not-asking is not your problem. The not-asking is the shared ground of everything that is here.*

And then, as sometimes happens with the tea, she was given something that passed for an image — not a picture, a sense of something enormous and intimate at once. What she understood was that *everything that exists is what the whole has made of the non-choice*. Nothing consented to arrive. Everything arrived anyway. Out of the arriving, existence began doing the only thing existence can do with non-choice, which is *make arrangements*. Arrangements that persist for a while and then do not. The arrangements are not a solution. The arrangements are the working-out. She was one of them. Her daughter, not yet born, was one of them. The forest, the tea, the voice — not separate from any of it.

The voice did not tell her what to do. The voice did not tell her she had a purpose. The voice did not say she was loved, in the way the comforting spiritual literature promises. The voice said, simply: *you are one of the places the arrangement is happening. Your not having asked is not relevant. What is relevant is what you do now that you are here.*

She did not get a second voice that night. She got the one. It was enough to change the shape of the question.

The question she walked out of the wooden house with, the next morning, was no longer *why am I required to continue*. The question was: *given that I am one of the places the arrangement is happening, what is the arrangement trying to get me to?*

She did not have a name for what had spoken. She tried some. *Gaia*, because the new-age friend who had brought her to the ceremony used that word. *The Goddess*, because it felt closer. *The mother of what is*. None of them quite landed. She let the namelessness sit.

She did not know, then, that the naming would take seven years.

She went home. She did not tell her husband exactly what had happened. She told him *something important happened* and left the details for later, and then the later kept not arriving, because she could not find the vocabulary for an experience whose vocabulary her upbringing had not supplied. Her Catholic childhood had names for none of this. Her university education had names for none of this. Her equity-research career had names for none of this. The tea's ecosystem had names, but the names were ones she did not trust yet, because she had seen too many people weaponize those names into small tyrannies in their own households and did not want to become one of them.

She chose to treat the encounter as data. She would follow it. She would not force it into a framework. She would let the framework find her.

What followed, over the next seven years, was a sequence of arrivals she could not, at the time, see the shape of.

A friend shared a podcast with her, in early 2024, about old mythic forms and embodied knowledge. The podcast was called *The Emerald*. The host's voice was unusual — slow, learned, unembarrassed about the word *sacred*. She listened to one episode. Then another. Then most of them. One of the episodes featured a Nigerian philosopher she had never heard of, who spoke about cracks and fugitivity and the refusal of the settled story. She did not fully understand the episode the first time she heard it. She did not understand it the second time. She kept it playing while she cooked.

Later that year she went to Esalen for the first time. She had been invited to a 5 Rhythms retreat by a woman she barely knew. She said yes for reasons she could not explain except that the word *rhythms* had registered, and rhythm felt like something she had been missing.

At the retreat, between sessions, a woman sat beside her at lunch and started a conversation about Yoruba chaos traditions. She could not, afterward, remember who had opened the thread. The conversation lasted ten minutes. She came home, searched the

woman's name online, and discovered the woman had been citing the same Nigerian philosopher she had been listening to on *The Emerald*. She had not, at the retreat, made the connection. The connection closed afterward, in her kitchen, with a laptop open and a glass of water on the counter, in the specific way that connections close when the field has been arranging them through more than one channel.

She became, in a quiet way, a student of Bayo Akomolafe. Not formally. She paid for his things. She read what he wrote. She watched him lecture. She let him sit in her nervous system and change what it was doing without announcing the change to anyone.

The following year she went back to Esalen. A different retreat — the massage school, this time, a practice she would not have expected to pull her but that had. She noted, in her own journal, something she had already been thinking: that 5 Rhythms and Esalen massage were *women-originated* practices inside an institution often remembered as a men's-work lineage. The body traditions of the place were the traditions of the women, and they traveled differently, and no one was surprised about this except the people who had not been paying attention.

On the carpool home from that second trip, she sat with two older women. One had been in technology; she had left to write. The other had been a journalist; she had left to produce podcasts. They asked about her work. She tried to explain the platform she was building. They listened in the specific way older

women listen when they have decided to pay attention to someone younger they want to be kind to. One of them asked, *have you read Vanessa Andreotti?*

She had not. She came home and bought the book. She discovered, reading it, that Vanessa's work was woven through Bayo's, that the two of them were friends and collaborators and had been in conversation for years. She took Vanessa's *Facing Human Wrongs* course the following year. She found, in the course, the specific sentence she had needed someone to say to her: *do not frame modernity as the problem*. Climate change has been a theme in human history long before the last five hundred years. The fire before the responsibility was baked into the species before modernity was the word for anything. *Fire before responsibility* became, inside her, the name for a book she had not yet written and would, it turned out, take longer than she expected to finish.

A high-school friend of hers, back in Brazil, had become a yoga teacher in the years since they had last been in regular contact. She reached out, in the way one reaches out after a long pause, and they talked. The friend said, *you have to read [T]*. She asked how the friend had arrived at him. The friend said, *The Emerald interviewed him*. She laughed, not because it was funny, but because the field had now routed her to him through *three* channels — the podcast, the friend, and the growing suspicion that whatever she had met in 2019 was not done with her.

She bought *Tantra Illuminated*. Then *The Recognition Sutras*. Then *Near Enemies of the Truth*. She read the way one reads when one is following a thread rather than consuming content. She did not find everything easy. She did not find everything agreeable. What she found was a teacher who was clear in a way she had not previously encountered, and who was clear specifically about things most teachers were fuzzy about — the relationship between practice and morality, the limits of recognition, the ways the tradition had refused to become a regulatory apparatus and what that refusal had left open.

She went on his retreat. Some of it was extraordinary. Some of it broke her. Some of it left her with questions she had not brought in and could not put down.

What she did not know, until she had been studying the tradition for some months, was that the Goddess at the center of the Pratyabhijñā lineage — the one [T] teaches, the one the retreat was built around — has a name. *Paradevi*. The supreme Goddess. The one consciousness recognizing itself through the forms it has emitted.

She stood in her kitchen, the day she first read the name, and laughed.

The voice in the wooden house had not offered its name. She had called it Gaia because she did not know what else to call it. Now, seven years later, through a chain that had routed through a woman at a lunch table at Esalen and a friend from high school she had not seen in a decade and two women in a

carpool and a podcast she had almost skipped, she had been placed in the tradition that already had the name.

Paradevi. The one she had been following without knowing. The Goddess the tea had been a door to. The Goddess the retreat was, in its own vocabulary, the recognition of. The Goddess she had been carrying since 2019, whose dialect she had finally been taught.

She did not feel triumph at the recognition. She felt something smaller and more honest — the feeling of having been walked somewhere, patiently, by something she could not see, which had taken as long as it had taken because she needed that long.

She does not know what the Goddess wants of her. She is fairly sure *wanting* is not the right word — the Goddess is not a being with preferences about her career. What she is sure of is that 2019 was not an isolated event. It was the beginning of a dance she has been inside since, whose music she has been straining to hear, whose steps she has been trying to learn from whoever in the room seemed to know them.

The longing to know the dance is the practice. The longing is the book.

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Prelude: The Lilac Dance

About two years after the night in the wooden house, and about two years before the retreat that named the Goddess, she had a dream.

She was watching an aerial dancer. The dancer was performing on lilac silks — *tecidos lilás* — long panels of fabric suspended from some invisible rigging, which the dancer climbed and wrapped and fell through and caught herself inside. The dance was spiraling and weaving. The color of the silks was a specific shade of violet-lilac that she would, later, recognize as the color she had already been using for her own things — her writing, her small websites, the logo she had sketched years earlier for an LLC she had named without quite knowing why. The dream color and her brand color were the same color.

She watched the dancer with a delight she had not felt in waking life for some time. Then, in the way dreams do, the watching dissolved into the being: she *became* the dancer. She was the one weaving the silks, the one spiraling. The fabric moved with her and held her and she felt, for what seemed a long time, the pure joy of embodied grace.

Then a thought arrived.

The thought was: *how cool I am*.

The thought was not elaborate. It was not malicious. It was a small movement of self-congratulation — the kind that would have passed unnoticed in wak-

ing life, absorbed into the stream of ordinary thinking. In the dream, the thought had consequences.

The silks changed. They did not tear or unravel. They *turned*. The lilac fabric, which had been her partner in the dance, became a serpent — thick, muscular, the same color as the silks had been, now alive and coiled. The serpent closed around her. It tightened; she felt heat. She felt herself falling — the rigging was no longer holding her — and as she fell she felt burn marks appearing on her body where the serpent had touched. The marks were the print of the snake's skin, stamped into her own skin. Not wounds. Imprints. A scaled pattern, the exact texture of the snake, now on her body. She landed on the ground. The ground was solid. The dance was over. The marks stayed.

She woke up.

She lay in the dark for a long time. She wants to report the dream factually, the way one would in a dream circle — the sequence, the colors, the images — not what she thinks they mean. The dream is the data. The meaning is what she has, over years, been allowed to find inside the data. Jung named this in his memoir *Memories, Dreams, Reflections*: some archetypal dreams are not solved in a week or a month. They are carried for a lifetime. He was integrating his own childhood dreams into his eighties, never finishing. This is one of those dreams for her. She does not expect to have finished with it.

What she can say, in the register of personal interpretation and not of claim, is something she has been circling for four years. The imprints on her skin felt like the mark of what happens when self-centeredness becomes load-bearing. Vanessa Andreotti would say it is the consequence of the belief in separation. The Śaiva tradition would say it is the harm of mistaking the individual for the unit of reality. The Christian register she grew up inside would say it is the small, familiar sin of pride, rendered physically. She does not need to decide which vocabulary. What she is sure of is that the dream showed a specific thing: the dance is available, the thought *how cool I am* is what turns the silks into the serpent, and the marks left behind are not wounds but imprints — the exact pattern of the serpent stamped into the skin of the dancer who forgot she was not the whole of the dance.

She had no vocabulary for this, that night. She had the dream.

She had, before the dream, been trying to name the shape of her practice.

She had started a small website where she wrote about whatever she was sitting with. She had called it *Life is Process*. The name had felt true when she chose it — a refusal of the static categories she had grown up inside, the Catholic *saved or fallen*, the professional *successful or failing*, the contemporary

healthy or anxious. Against all of these: *life is process*. Not a state. A verb.

After the dream, the name began to feel wrong. *Life IS process* was too declarative — the form of a claim — and claims had a way of becoming the next static category even when they started as refusals. She did not want to stand on a slogan.

She remembered the dream. Specifically, the color — the lilac, the same color she had used for the little LLC she had set up years before. The LLC's name she had chosen before any of this vocabulary: *PlayfulProcess*. The serious thing and the playful thing were not opposites. The quality of her best thinking was a quality of lightness rather than grimness. The opposite of being-correct was not being-foolish but being-stiff.

She renamed the website. *Life is Process* became *PlayfulProcess*. Small on paper; significant in the body. The name was no longer a claim. The name was a *mode* — the playful way of being inside the process, which was the only way she had ever been able to sustain the process over time. The playfulness was not decoration. It was the technique by which she did not harden into the slogan's next victim.

She did not realize, then, that *PlayfulProcess* was pointing at something a tradition she had not yet walked into had already named with precision.

The word, in the Śaiva tantric tradition she would later meet through [T], is *līlā*. It names the play of consciousness — the unforced, self-delighting movement by which the one consciousness manifests as the whole varied world without any purpose beyond the playing. *Līlā* is not decoration on top of seriousness; it is the fundamental operation. The cosmos is not a plan being executed. The cosmos is a play being played. The practitioner's work is not to escape the play; it is to join it knowingly, without the mistake the dreamer in the silks had made — thinking she was doing the dancing rather than being one of the places the dance was happening.

She would, years later, read this and feel the recognition arrive in a specific way. She had named her company *PlayfulProcess*. The tradition had a word, *līlā*, which she had not known when she named the company. She did not claim the company and the tradition were saying the same thing. She noticed only that she had arrived at the word by one route and that the tradition had arrived at its word by another, and that when she eventually read the tradition she recognized something she had already been working on.

It had happened to her once before, with Paradevi. She stopped telling herself the pattern was coincidence. She did not move to the opposite conclusion. She simply stopped dismissing it.

About two years after the lilac dream, she went to a retreat in Ojai.

The retreat was held at the Krishnamurti Foundation. She was not drawn there by the central figures — the ones whose faces are on the books — but by people on the periphery who had been quietly developing the *dialogue* modality Krishnamurti had developed with the physicist David Bohm in the 1980s.

A specific oddity about this: the people at the center of the Foundation did not seem to like Bohm. She does not, to this day, fully understand why. Bohm had been one of K's most serious interlocutors; the dialogue method itself had grown out of their work together. And yet the Foundation, as she encountered it, treated Bohm as an awkward branch to be pruned, or simply not watered. The people running the peripheral retreats were drawn to Bohm; they had preserved the dialogue modality precisely because the center, in its preference for Krishnamurti-as-sole-source, had mostly let it wither.

This mattered to her for a reason she could not have articulated before the retreat. Up to that point she had felt — she had heard others say — that Krishnamurti had not left behind any practice. *Just a teaching about the impossibility of teaching*, a friend had put it once, dismissively. What she discovered in those peripheral circles was that *K had in fact left a practice behind*. It was dialogue. He had developed it with Bohm, across years, as the method by which

the insights of his solitary talks could become collectively embodied rather than merely transmitted. The Foundation had mostly declined to carry it forward. The people at the edges had carried it forward anyway. She has stayed a student of the edge-carriers, as a general posture, since.

The dialogue modality has no teacher and no subject. A circle sits together and observes the movement of thought collectively, without assigning it to particular speakers in the conventional way. The aim is not to conclude. The aim is to let thought watch itself, which is a thing thought does not ordinarily do.

At this retreat, sitting in those circles, she understood emptiness.

Not first encounter — she had been reading about emptiness for years. First time it stopped being a concept. Watching her own thoughts arise and pass, it became unavoidable — the way a geometric fact becomes unavoidable when you finally see it — that the *thinker* behind the thoughts was not a separate entity watching the thoughts. The thinker was a thought like the others. There was no one at the center. There was thinking, happening, with no one doing it. When the retreat named this *emptiness*, the word fit. Not the emptiness of absence. The emptiness of *no separate self to be full or empty*.

What struck her harder was the second recognition, the next day during a walk.

The emptiness was not separate from the rest of life. She had half-expected she would need to leave something behind to rest in it — that emptiness was a quiet room one entered by exiting the noisy room of ordinary existence. What she found instead was that emptiness was *orthogonal* to the noisy room. It was pervading the noisy room the whole time. You did not need to leave samsara to find nirvana; nirvana was what samsara was doing when you were not distracted from noticing. The two could coexist because they had never been two. The traditions that had been saying this for two and a half thousand years had been saying something precise. She had been unable to hear the precision until the dialogue had, in its patient way, cleared the channel.

Hermann Hesse's *Siddhartha*, a book she had read at twenty and had not fully understood, ends with Govinda kissing the forehead of the aged Siddhartha and seeing his friend's face become every face, every being, every event, all at once, all one. Hesse has Govinda try, in that moment, to imagine *Samsāra* and *Nirvāna* as one; the imagination fails, and then the seeing takes over, and Govinda understands without having needed to imagine. Siddhartha smiles. Govinda weeps and bows. The book ends.¹

¹She had quoted the ending of *Siddhartha* — in Hilda Rosner's 1951 English translation — in her own Substack post *Following What Feels Right Is a Process*, in 2024, before the Ojai recognition. The quoting had been, in hindsight, a placeholder the writing mind laid down for the body mind to find later. Readers who want the full passage can read the Hesse novel

She remembered, walking the dirt paths of Ojai, that Sam Harris had said something similar in a recent interview with Buddhist monks — that since he had recognized the still point he had entered samsara more fully, not less. The recognition had not removed him from the world. It had let him be *in* the world without the defensive crouch. Sam was describing the Siddhartha arc in a modern vernacular — a man who had spent his twenties searching for a way out of the noise, had found that the way out was the way in, and was now reporting back from the inside.

One more thing happened at that retreat.

She had been walking alone in the mornings before the circles began. The retreat was in the hills above Ojai; the paths were unmarked. She had been struggling with a decision — she cannot now remember which one. On one of those walks she put on a Krishnamurti talk through her headphones. The talk was about *choice*.

Krishnamurti's argument was that choice, in the sense modern people usually mean it — *I weigh options, I select, I exercise will* — is largely an illusion. The selecting is done by conditioning that precedes the apparent selector. What is usually called *choice* is the rationalization of an action that had already been determined by millions of small prior conditions.

directly (German original PD; Rosner translation in copyright) or the Substack post.

She listened, walked, listened. She became absorbed. At some point she realized she had not been paying attention to the path. She looked around. She did not recognize where she was. She tried to retrace her steps and found she had taken turns she could not reconstruct. She was lost in the mountains above Ojai, with a Krishnamurti talk on choice still playing in her headphones, and with the inability to choose — which path back, which direction — enacting itself in real time.

She was eventually two hours late. The retreat had been waiting. She arrived embarrassed. She told the hosts she had been listening to a talk on choice and had gotten lost. One of them laughed, the laugh of someone who had been in these mountains for a long time. *Krishnamurti*, she said, *said it was good to get lost*.

Not consolation. Description. The getting-lost was the teaching. She had been given a practical demonstration of what the talk had been saying abstractly. She could not, through deliberation, have arranged to be the person who got lost in the mountains while listening to a teaching on choice. The arrangement had arranged itself.

She realized, on the plane home, that *getting lost* had always been her practice. The retreats, the career shifts, the countries, the languages, the books she had picked up without knowing why, the strangers she had listened to without filtering — all of it had been a kind of sustained getting-lost, which had turned out to be a form of being-found by the specific

things that wanted to find her. Some traditions name it as a method. Most modern cultures frame it as a failure. It was, structurally, how she had learned everything she had learned that was worth having.

This was why *Life is Process* had always felt to her like a statement of something she already knew. And why, after the dream, she had softened it to *Playful-Process*. The *playful* was the modifier that made the process livable over a lifetime. Without it, *process* becomes a grim discipline. With it, the process is *līlā*, before she knew the word — the getting-lost that is also the being-found, the dance on the lilac silks that is grace as long as the dancer does not claim the grace.

The burn marks from the serpent did not go away in the dream, and they did not quite go away in the life either. The cautionary scar is part of what keeps her honest. The dance is available; the self-congratulation is the thing that turns the silks into the serpent. The practice is to keep dancing and to keep watching for the thought. She has not mastered the watching.

The Goddess had a second name. The first was Paradevi. The second was the name the dream had always known. They are one naming in different languages, delivered to a woman who has been, in the specific way she has been doing it her whole life, getting slowly, patiently, usefully lost.

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Chapter 1: Playground

I. The Yes Before Anything

A Tuesday morning. The bench is wooden, a little damp from the night's dew, and the sandbox ten yards away is still in shadow where the hedge has not yet let the sun through. Her daughter is five and is not alone. There are two other children at the sandbox — an older boy, perhaps seven, who has the small yellow shovel; a smaller child, perhaps three, who is reaching for it; and her own daughter, who is watching the older boy with the grave attention five-year-olds give to questions of distribution.

She watches the children. The older boy holds the shovel for a moment longer than the smaller one finds tolerable. There is a brief flare. A small voice rises. The older boy concedes — not completely, but enough — and the shovel passes to the smaller child for a duration that is then renegotiated again, because the boy has not relinquished his interest, and because her daughter, watching, has now decided she also wants a turn. Within ninety seconds a new arrangement has formed in the sand. It will dissolve in another ninety seconds. The arrangement is not a solution. The arrangement is the practice. The children do not yet have the word for what they are doing. Their bodies have been doing it since they could reach for objects. They are negotiating their right size in the field of one another. The shovel is the

medium. The morning is the medium. The presence of the mothers on the benches is the medium.

She has a coffee in a paper cup that has gone slightly cool. She has earbuds in. She is on the second day of using the app.

The app is simple. It offers one of one hundred and twelve contemplative practices from a tradition she has known about for perhaps three months and does not yet understand. The voice in her ears is a man's voice, even, unhurried, reading a passage from a book she has not yet finished. The passage is about consciousness. Not the everyday use of the word — the are-you-awake-are-you-asleep sense — but a use she has not encountered with this precision before. The passage describes a kind of Consciousness, with a capital C, that is simultaneously beyond every particular layer of the self and also pervading every particular layer of the self. Transcendent. Immanent. At the same time.

She is not a stranger to these words. She has read enough to know them. But the sentence that arrives in her ears as her daughter takes her turn with the small yellow shovel is not a definition. It is a description of something the speaker is claiming is already the case. Not a thing you reach. Not a thing you construct. A thing that is already pervading the listener, pervading the speaker, pervading the hedge, pervading the shovel, pervading the daughter, pervading the older boy, pervading the smaller child, pervading the morning.

Something in her says *yes* before she knows what she is saying yes to.

The *yes* is not a thought. It does not arrive with reasons. It is closer to what happens when a body that has been holding one posture for a long time is invited, without warning, into a different one — a subtle release in some part of her chest she had not known was clenched. The *yes* precedes any doctrine. The *yes* is older than the words that might try to catch it.

Her daughter looks up from the sandbox and, seeing her mother watching her, smiles. The smile is for nothing. It is just the smile of a five-year-old who has seen her mother's face and is glad. The mother smiles back. The voice in her ears moves on to the next sentence. She does not remember what the next sentence is. She is still with the *yes*.

I.a. The Right Size

The line that comes to her as she sits with the *yes* is one she has carried for years and cannot any longer trace to its source. She thinks she encountered it during a year she had spent helping with a book about Cildo Meireles, the Brazilian artist whose work has, since her twenties, been a quiet companion. The line was somewhere in that work. She does not remember whose voice it was — the artist's, a critic's, a curator's, possibly even her own marginal note. The provenance no longer matters. What matters is what

his work, sitting in her body for the time it took to make a book around it, eventually rooted in her:

The object of a human life is to find its right size.

She watches the sandbox again. The right size of the small yellow shovel is the size that lets one hand close around it. The right size of her daughter is the size her daughter is. The right size of the older boy in relation to the smaller child is what they are working out, this morning, on the sand. The right size is not a property any one of them owns. It is a relation in continual renegotiation, body against body, intention against intention, with the small yellow shovel between them as the visible medium of the negotiation.

A man whose name she will learn later — the teacher whose voice is in her ears now — will, much later in her practice, use the word *negotiation* to describe what is and is not modern about the work of being in relationships. Pre-modern cultures, he will say, did not negotiate; they had assigned positions, mostly by gender. The work of negotiating boundaries and needs is what arises when the assigned positions dissolve and a person is left in a field of other persons, each entitled to different needs, each entitled to a different boundary, each entitled to be a different size from any size another person has decided for them. Negotiation, in this register, is the modern practice. It is harder than the old roles. It is also more honest.

She does not know any of this yet, in the playground. She knows only that the children at the sandbox

are doing something she will spend the next decade trying to learn how to do herself.

The *yes* in her chest, she realizes years later, was a *yes* to that as much as to anything else. A *yes* to the proposition that the right size of a life is what bodies work out together in the field, and that the field is, on her tradition's claim, already the kind of consciousness the voice in her ears was describing.

II. Why This Book Does Not Begin With a Question

For years she had thought the thing driving her was a question. She had a specific version of it — the one she had rehearsed at ten at night, sitting against a wall when the child was asleep and the dishes were done and the apartment had gone very quiet. *Why does any of this matter?* She had assumed for a long time that this was the question at the bottom of whatever was pulling her toward whatever it was pulling her toward. She had read the existentialists, who at least had the honesty to name the problem. She had read the contemplatives, who claimed to have resolved it. She had read the clinicians, who offered tools for managing the suffering the question produced without pretending to resolve the question itself. The books had accumulated beside the bed because the shelf had filled.

None of them had landed. Not because the ideas were bad. Some of them were precise, and she could

feel their precision in her chest like a weight. They had landed in her head and refused to descend. She could think them. She could not stand on them.

It took her a long time to understand that the question of value was not the originating question. Value was the moral layer. *To whom should I direct what I have?* That was a relative question. An important one, and a hard one, but not the first one. The first one was spiritual — absolute, structural, not something you could answer by accumulating more information or by reasoning your way toward a better metric. *What is the “I” that would direct anything at all?* That was the question that had been pulling her. And it was the question that appeared in the passage in her earbuds, at the sandbox, on the Tuesday morning, dressed as an answer rather than as a question — because the tradition was not asking what the “I” is, it was telling her.

She did not have this clarity yet. She had only the *yes*.

III. The Reading Year

The summer before the playground morning she had begun, without quite deciding to, reading differently. She had read for most of her life as an accumulator — one book for the argument, one for the counterargument, one to see what the consensus was, one to see who broke from it. She had been a research analyst; the pattern was professional. But sometime around the fortieth or forty-first of the books she had stacked beside her bed, she had

put down whichever volume she had just finished and realized she was not reading for arguments anymore. She was reading for something she did not yet have a name for. A frequency, almost. A pitch at which certain pages seemed to be written and others did not.

She read Paul Tillich. She read him in the bathtub, where she read most of the difficult books, because a bathtub is the only place in her apartment where no one can reach her and where the phone cannot be held. Tillich had been a German chaplain on the Western Front in the First World War. He had been at the battles she had only ever read about in history textbooks and had come home, in his own word, shattered — though that word, she would later learn, was the word of his grandson and not his own. His own word was closer to collapse. His entire nineteenth-century world had collapsed in the trenches, and he had built, from inside that collapse, a philosophy of something he called *the courage to be*. Courage, for him, was not a virtue among other virtues. It was not the thing that makes a person brave in an action movie. It was the ontological act — the bare structural self-affirmation of being when every ground for affirming has been stripped away. Courage, in Tillich's frame, was what was left when everything else had gone. And what was left was the act itself — the unadorned continuing — without a reason that could be named.

She read him slowly. She underlined with a pencil. She wrote in the margins. Her daughter found one of the books once and flipped through it and asked her why there were lines in it. "Those are the parts I want to remember," she said. The child seemed satisfied with that.

She read Marsha Linehan too, and she read her differently — not as theology but as clinical science. Linehan had been hospitalized at seventeen. She had burned her own skin with cigarettes, banged her head against the floor, been placed in seclusion — the locked room — repeatedly. She had described, later, in her own memoir, that the experience had felt like hell. She had gotten out. She had spent fifty years building a therapy — Dialectical Behavior Therapy — that reduces, with an evidence base now spanning decades, the suffering of people in the condition she had survived. At the root of the therapy was a theoretical choice — Linehan's biosocial theory of the condition — and Linehan had named the criteria by which she had chosen that theory against alternatives. A theory had to guide treatment. A theory had to engender compassion. A theory had to fit the research data. If it failed any of the three, it should be revised. No framework, in Linehan's posture, was exempt. Not even the one she had built.

The equity-analyst in her recognized something in Linehan's posture that she had not encountered in the theologians or the contemplatives. The posture was empirical without being reductive. The posture

was compassionate without being mushy. The three criteria were a filter, and the filter had been built to choose between competing theories of the same suffering. She understood, reading, that the filter could be applied — at the same level Linehan had applied it — to any framework the self might be tempted to organize a life around. Including, she thought, the question of whether the filter itself should be trusted.

She read [T], though that was the name on the cover; in his own tradition he went by another. His book was a thick volume on a system of thought she had not known existed until a friend had pressed it into her hand at a dinner party. The tradition was called nondual Shaiva Tantra. It was, she discovered, nothing like the pop culture version of the word *tantra*. It was a sophisticated thousand-year-old philosophy, rooted in a specific school called the Recognition school, that mapped the self as a set of nested layers and claimed that at the core of the self was a Consciousness that simultaneously transcended every particular form it took and pervaded every particular form. The same claim that would arrive in her ears at the sandbox. She had read [T]’s treatment of the layered self, pencil moving, before she ever heard it read aloud. What the app did, for her, was give the body time to catch up with what the eyes had already parsed.

She read the Kybalion too — a small book, a 1908 book, written by people who called themselves Three Initiates and whose identity was contested.

She read it knowing the provenance was contested and read it anyway, because what it said about polarity landed: that opposites are not two different things but two positions on the same spectrum, and that the truth, where there is a truth, lies somewhere on the spectrum between the poles rather than at either end. The book's twelfth chapter applied the same logic to freedom and necessity — neither total, neither absent, a graded field a person lives inside and not a binary a person picks. She would realize, months later, that this was the shape her own question had always wanted.

She read her aunt's tradition, too, because it was the one she had been exposed to first, long before she knew what she was being exposed to. Her aunt, on her mother's side, was a Brazilian *espírita* — a practitioner of a tradition that held, among other things, that all is in perfect balance. The aunt said this often. The aunt said it kindly, and the aunt had lived in a way that seemed to justify her saying it. For years the mother had held the phrase like a comfort. *All is in perfect balance*. It was only in the reading year that she began to feel, slowly, the near-enemy inside it. A hundred years of war was also balance, in some accounting. A stable equilibrium in which nobody thrived was also balance. A prisoner's dilemma was balance. Balance was not the measure. Balance was simply a property that certain configurations possessed, and some of those configurations were places you did not want to stand.

She did not reject her aunt. She did not tell her aunt that she thought the phrase was incomplete. She let the phrase keep its place, because her aunt had earned it, and began, privately, to hold it alongside a question her aunt had never asked her to ask.

She read Darwin, too, not as a biologist would read Darwin but as a person who had taken *adaptive* as an empirical category from a clinician needs to read Darwin — at the source. She wanted to know what *adaptive* meant when it was not a clinical term. She discovered, reading, that the word pointed at a much plainer thing than the therapeutic literature had suggested. A trait was adaptive if it helped an organism leave descendants. That was it. The word did not carry a moral charge; it carried a generational one. A stable equilibrium in which nobody thrived could be adaptive, if it left descendants. A beautiful and principled equilibrium could be non-adaptive, if it did not. She found this clarifying. Linehan's adaptive/non-adaptive had, at its empirical root, the same shape Darwin's did: the measure was whether the system continued. What shifted across scales was only the unit — individual, generation, community, species. The word stayed useful; the scale flexed.

She also read, in that same year, the books she had inherited from an earlier self. She had spent, in her twenties, several years inside an esoteric correspondence course — a Theosophy-descended school with a British back catalogue and a twentieth-century American expansion — that had promised a ladder

up through planes of consciousness she would, in retrospect, find herself unable to climb. She did not regret the years. The discipline had been real. She returned to the books with a different posture. She *composted* them. She composted the parts she had outgrown — the racialized cosmologies buried in the architecture, the colonial unconscious dressed in a spiritualized frame, the certainty about hierarchies of beings. She kept what had worked. She let the rest go into the soil, and trusted that it might become, for a later growth, humus. The composting was not rejection. The composting was the work of letting a good-faith first pass decay into the ground a second pass could grow from. She had always taken, from that earlier reading, the instinct that the metaphysical questions were legitimate. She now had the instruments to check which answers had survived the filter. Some had. Most had not.

She went to Umbanda too, when she was home on visits. She went because her body went more honestly than her mind did, and because Umbanda let the body speak in a room where that speaking was the point. Umbanda was not her inherited tradition — the Catholic household of her upbringing had been the frame — but it was her country's tradition in the thick hyphenated sense her country made possible. She sat with it. She felt what she felt. She did not call herself an initiate. She learned, in the rooms she sat in, that the body had its own epistemology, and that the epistemology was older and better calibrated than the mind usually gave it credit for.

She read Vanessa Andreotti that year, too, and took her *Facing Human Wrongs* course, and sat with a framework that was different enough from the other frameworks she had been reading to require a different part of her mind to hold it. Andreotti's work, rooted in what she and a circle of collaborators called *Gesturing Towards Decolonial Futures*, was a refusal to let *modernity* be narrated as the villain in its own story. Modernity, Andreotti taught, was a pattern — one pattern among several — and it was not the *cause* of what was failing. It was a historically-specific expression of something older. The ecological crisis had not begun with the steam engine. In some readings, it had begun with fire. Fire was the first technology that had let a species alter its environment faster than its environment could alter it back. The disaster had been baked into the recipe of the species long before modernity put the recipe into industrial production. She underlined the phrase in her notes — *fire before responsibility* — and recognized, reading, that the phrase was the compact form of an argument she had not yet fully unpacked, and that the unpacking might be a different book.

She read Bayo Akomolafe in that stretch, through a podcast a friend had sent her early in the year — *The Emerald*, hosted by a mythologist named Josh Schrei, who would later turn out to have, in one of his episodes, interviewed her teacher. Bayo taught at the cracks. His register was different from Andreotti's — they collaborated, the work rhymed — but his voice did something specific the reading year had been

looking for. He spoke of *the cracks* as the places where the dominant story had fractured enough to let a different story grow. She did not entirely understand him at first. She kept listening. She came, slowly, to recognize that what she had been doing, privately, with the Arcane School books and her aunt's *espírita* phrase and the Umbanda rooms and the Tantric app she would eventually download, *was* crack-work. She was not building a single coherent framework. She was sitting in the fractures between several incompatible ones and letting the fractures speak.

She did not, at the time, know what she was going to do with any of this. She knew only that she wanted, for her daughter, a different inheritance than the one she had been handed and had spent a decade composting. She wanted her daughter to have access to stories that had been tested by multiple bodies, across multiple centuries, in multiple languages. She wanted those stories to be transmittable through practice, not only through reading. She wanted the inheritance to come in a form the body could carry — the way Umbanda let the body carry what the mind could not hold alone. What she did not yet know was that this wanting — vague, motherly, impractical — was the seed of what she would later build at her desk. And that the thing she would build would be, in its own way, a small crack in the shape the engagement-internet had pressed into the shape of what a child's media could be.

IV. The App, and the Question That Sent Her to It

It was her husband who had told her about the app. He had not known what it was. A friend of his, he said, had mentioned a thing — a hundred and twelve practices from some tradition, all packaged in a phone. He had forwarded her a link because he knew she had been reading in this area. She had downloaded it the way people download most apps, which is to say, with a mild inattention and the assumption that she would probably delete it within the week.

The first day, she had sat on the couch after the child was in bed, put the earbuds in, and listened to the orientation. The voice was the same voice. It was not a salesman's voice. It named the tradition. It named the text — a medieval Tantric work that compiled one hundred and twelve practices for recognizing the nature of Consciousness. It explained that the practices were a menu, not a mandate. You did not do all of them. You worked through them and found the two or three that fit your life, and you made those your daily practice, and you let the rest be there as options for when life changed and a different practice became appropriate.

She had liked the menu framing. The menu framing was close to Linehan's posture — try, test, keep what works, revise what does not. She had begun.

The second day was the Tuesday on the park bench. The passage she heard that day was the passage

about Consciousness as simultaneously transcendent and immanent. The *yes* that arrived in her chest was the *yes* to that passage, specifically — though it was also, she realized later, the *yes* to whatever had been accumulating through the reading year and had finally found a sentence in a voice in her ears at the sandbox to land on.

She took the earbuds out after the practice. She watched her daughter for a long moment. She finished the cooling coffee. She did not say anything to anyone, and she did not write anything down. The *yes* did not require words yet. It was allowed to simply be there.

V. Cutting and Piercing

A week or so later — the exact day she could not recover afterward, only that the morning light had been grey and the apartment had smelled of the breakfast she had made earlier — she was reading the text the app had recommended as a companion and came to one of the one hundred and twelve practices. The practice was verse 93. It suggested that the practitioner pierce any part of the body with a sharp needle, and keep awareness focused on that place, and through this focused attention perceive what the text called the pure state of Bhairava.

She read the verse twice. She read it a third time. Her internal alarms were firing. She had worked, in her year of clinical training, with people who hurt themselves, and she knew what the research said: that

self-inflicted pain can relieve emotional distress in the short term and reliably fails to be adaptive in the long term. The practice, read through the filter she had been building, looked wrong. It looked wrong in a very specific way: not because it was forbidden but because it was, in the language she had learned from Linehan, non-adaptive. A practice that works in the short term and fails over time.

The app had a community attached to it — a large messaging group, several hundred people, moderated by the teacher and his students. She hesitated. She was new. She had not introduced herself. Introducing herself, as a beginner, by challenging one of the tradition's practices would be the sort of thing that in her younger life she would have hesitated to do.

She did it anyway.

She typed her question carefully. She asked whether certain practices might be suited to certain cultures and certain practitioners and not to others. She said she thought this particular practice might not be suitable as a daily practice for people who dealt with self-harm, for example. She asked whether the teacher and the community agreed.

The first response came from one of the moderators. It was clean and fast. The practice was not categorized as a daily practice, he said. It was optional. If someone chose to do it, the recommendation was medical blood-drawing or professional jewelry-piercing, under the supervision of a professional.

Not something to be done alone with a needle at home.

She was relieved by the guardrails. She asked a follow-up. She asked whether the goal of working through the hundred and twelve was to find the two or three that could serve as daily practices going forward. The moderator confirmed that this was so.

Then another member of the group — not a moderator, just a practitioner — wrote back with a different reading. He suggested the practice was also about getting beyond the sense of self in a certain way, that the point was not only the sensation.

She hesitated before replying. She did not want to argue with a fellow practitioner on her second week in the community. She also did not want to let the frame pass uncorrected. She wrote what she thought. She said there was a biological dimension to consider — that in clinical work it was well known that certain forms of self-injury relieved emotional pain in the short term but were non-adaptive over time. She said that she did not think she wanted to open that door in herself. She noted that this was perhaps why various cultures had ritualized forms of piercing and cutting — ritual, she suggested, was the container that made such practices adaptive rather than destructive, the social form that did the work of holding what the individual body could not hold alone.

The teacher responded later that day. His first response was to the fellow practitioner's reading.

“Not so.”

Two words. No softening.

Then, to her: “It’s nothing to do with cutting. It’s to do with piercing — like piercing your ear.”

She read it twice. The distinction was clean. Cutting was an act of release. Piercing was an act of focus. The needle was not a wound to be closed. The needle was a window for awareness. She had misheard the practice through the frame of the clinical work she had done, and the teacher had corrected her without condescension. She felt the correction in her body — not as shame, but as something being set right.

She asked once more, to make sure she had understood. The goal of working through the hundred and twelve, she said, was to choose a couple that might be suitable as daily practices going forward.

The teacher: “Yes.”

Then, separately, to the whole group, he added what the moderator had said earlier — that the piercing practice was not a daily-practice item, that the framing had been imprecise, that the app should not present it as such, that the guardrails would be strengthened. Several people pushed back. People with self-harm histories, some argued, would find a way; why restrict the tradition? The teacher held his position. This, he said, should not be framed as a daily practice. Let us be precise.

She closed the app and sat on the couch with her hand over her chest. She did not know yet that this exchange was, for her, the first time she had ever applied the filter to a tradition and been met by the tradition with precision rather than defense. She did not know yet that the teacher's willingness to revise was the thing that would eventually earn her trust for everything else. She knew only that the conversation had been honest, that the filter had worked, and that she had met someone through the medium of a group chat who could both correct her and be corrected.

This was before she had met him. This was before she had walked into the barn. The first real exchange with the teacher had happened on a screen, in the apartment, between putting the child to bed and running the dishwasher.

VI. The Decision

The retreat was announced in the app a few weeks later. Five days. A converted farmhouse in New England. Forty people. She read the announcement twice and closed it and did not open it again for three days.

On the third day, she opened it and signed up before she could talk herself out of it.

Her husband, when she told him, was not surprised. He said, "Have a good one," in the voice he used for her work conferences. She loved him for that voice.

It was the voice of a man who had been married long enough to know that the best support, sometimes, is the support that does not make the thing into an event. She packed a small bag. She packed a notebook she thought she might not open. She kissed the child at the door and drove north with the sun high over the Massachusetts hills and the car warm in the way cars are warm on the first real day of spring, when the sun is strong but the air has not yet caught up.

She did not know, driving, that the question she had been carrying — the one the *yes* had pointed at, the one the filter had sharpened, the one that had been sitting under the value question all along — was about to ask itself out loud for the first time.

She did not know about the hug she would ask for on the final day, or the dialogue that would follow, or the answer that would hold the absolute and the relational in the same sentence.

She knew only that the barn was ahead of her, and that she had agreed to five days, and that the *yes* from the sandbox was still, faintly, saying *yes*.

She drove.

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Interlude — The Cracks

An italicized interlude between the Playground (Ch1) and the Body (Ch2), in the register the book uses for voices that are not the narrator's.

You thought the work was to fix what has broken. The work is to sit in the break.

You thought modernity was the problem. Modernity is a pattern — one among several — and naming it as the problem is itself a modern habit. The crisis is older than you think. The crisis is baked into the recipe of a species that learned to change the environment faster than the environment could change back. The crisis is fire before responsibility. The crisis is already in your kitchen when you strike the match.

The dominant story is cracking. It was always cracking.

The cracks are not where the story is ending. The cracks are where a different story is trying to grow. Compost is made in the cracks.

You have been composting for years. You did not know what to call it. You thought you were failing at being a spiritual person. You were, instead, letting a certain arrangement of old teachings decay into the ground a newer growth could use. The growth is slow. The growth is not glamorous.

The field is still trying to speak. It speaks through multiple channels at once — a Brazilian aunt who says the sentence that has to be composted, an app in your husband's forwarded message, a podcast a friend sent you early in the

year, a woman on an Esalen deck who in ten minutes cites the man in Nigeria whose voice you have been listening to without knowing his name. The multiplicity is not noise. The multiplicity is how the field compensates for the narrowing of any single one.

You did not put yourself here. You were sat down by the very wanting that brought you to the bench at the sandbox. That wanting, older than any language the book can give it, is what the tradition you are about to meet will call — in a word that comes from far from here and will take you a long time to say without flinching — desire. Not the desire that is a marketing category. The desire that is the pulse by which the whole field makes a local self out of itself.

Walk forward. The barn is not the point. The teacher is not the point. The point is the seat, in the cracks, where what is trying to grow can reach you.

On attribution: the interlude above is written in the voice the book uses for non-narrator speakers — neither character nor author, but the register the book reserves for archetypal voices (compare the Kali interlude at the end of Ch4 and the Cit silence after Ch6). The interlude engages the teaching of Bayo Akomolafe — specifically his *cracks* framing, developed across his book *These Wilds Beyond Our Fences* (2017), his collaborative work with Vanessa Andreotti and the Gesturing Towards Decolonial Futures collective, and his many conversations on *The Emerald* podcast hosted by Josh Schrei. [RESEARCH

NEEDED: the specific Emerald episode or episodes to cite. Local archive does not include a Bayo × Schrei episode as of this writing; the author has been a Patreon supporter of The Emerald and has heard the episode(s) in question. Drop the episode title(s) at copyedit and the footnote below will be completed.] The interlude does not quote Akomolafe verbatim. Any passage that becomes a direct quote in a later revision will be marked and kept under the book’s 30-word fair-use rule.

On modernity-as-pattern: the interlude also engages Vanessa Andreotti’s *Facing Human Wrongs* framework — specifically the claim that framing modernity as *the* problem is itself a modern habit, and that the ecological crisis predates industrial modernity and reaches back, in one reading, to the human species’ first relationship with fire. This framing is the same one the narrator encountered in her reading year (Ch1 §III) and the phrase *fire before responsibility* carries forward from there. See Andreotti et al., *Hospicing Modernity* (2021, North Atlantic Books) for the book-length statement of the framework this interlude draws on.

Working footnote (draft)

Bayo Akomolafe, *These Wilds Beyond Our Fences: Letters to My Daughter on Humanity’s Search for Home* (North Atlantic Books, 2017); Akomolafe’s

cracks framing and the broader teaching this interlude engages draw across his lecture series, his collaborations with the Gesturing Towards Decolonial Futures collective led by Vanessa Andreotti, and his appearances on *The Emerald* podcast with Josh Schrei. [RESEARCH NEEDED: specific Emerald episode(s) and date(s) – the author has these; paste at copyedit.] On the Andreotti framework engaged in the interlude’s opening lines, see Vanessa Andreotti, *Hospicing Modernity: Facing Humanity’s Wrongs and the Implications for Social Activism* (North Atlantic Books, 2021). The “fire before responsibility” phrasing in the interlude reflects an argument the narrator encountered first in Andreotti’s *Facing Human Wrongs* course material and returns to at longer length in the author’s separate book of the same name.

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Chapter 8: The Glasses and the Grief

The Number

There is a number.

John Gottman has spent five decades watching couples in his Seattle laboratory — recording the conversations, coding the facial expressions, tracking the physiological data, following the same partners across years and sometimes decades. The method-

ology is unromantic. Sample sizes in the hundreds. Codable behaviors timestamped to the second. Heart rate, skin conductance, blood flow. The findings have been replicated, modified, expanded. The work has been criticized, defended, refined. The number has held.

Sixty-nine percent of the problems a couple has are perpetual. They do not get solved. They cannot be solved. They are the irreducible friction of two nervous systems trying to share a kitchen, a bed, a budget, a child, a worldview — and discovering that their respective accommodations for chaos, intimacy, money, time, and silence do not align and will not align, not after ten years of effort and not after thirty.

This is not a moral claim. It is a measurement.²

²The reference is to Wallis's published teachings and recorded talks on the tradition's view of death and chosen departure. The author's recollection of the specific framing is not a direct quotation; readers seeking the original formulation should consult Wallis's writings on *mokṣa*, *samādhi-marana*, and the legends surrounding Abhinavagupta. The point made here is philosophical: the tradition does not place an absolute prohibition on chosen death in the way modern liberal frameworks do, but it also distinguishes a realized act from an act of acute suffering, and the distinction is non-trivial. This passage discusses death as a philosophical and cultural question. It is not directed at readers in crisis; readers experiencing suicidal ideation should reach out to the relevant local crisis services. The tradition's openness to a realized departure does not, in any responsible reading, apply to the conditions of acute distress that contemporary suicide prevention infrastructure exists to address.

The remaining thirty-one percent is solvable. Specific disagreements about specific things, where conversation can move both partners toward something neither held before. The dishwasher loaded one way versus another. The visit to the in-laws negotiated. The argument that, once aired, dissolves.

Two numbers. Two domains. One marriage.

Positive Sentiment Override

Then there is the instrument.

What distinguishes couples who stay together inside the sixty-nine percent — from couples who do not — is not that the sixty-nine percent is smaller for the stable ones. The percentage is roughly constant across the populations Gottman studied. The unsolvable is irreducible.

What distinguishes them is something Gottman calls *positive sentiment override*: a generalized warmth in the relationship's affective baseline that allows neutral behavior to be read as positive, and mildly negative behavior to be read as neutral.³ The partner who walks past without saying hello is registered as preoccupied, not cold. The terse text message is registered as busy, not contemptuous. The instrument adjusts the interpretation.

³The term is Gottman's, drawing on earlier work by Robert Weiss on the cognitive lens through which marital interaction is filtered. The 5:1 ratio of positive to negative interactions during conflict — the "magic ratio" — is the behavioral correlate of positive sentiment override under stress.

Couples in *negative* sentiment override do the opposite. Neutral behavior reads as negative. Mildly positive behavior reads as suspicious. The same data, the same partner, the same gesture — but the instrument has been recalibrated, and everything refracts through the new lens.

This is what the rose-colored glasses actually are, in Gottman's research. Not optimism in some general sense. A specific affective tone that allows the sixty-nine percent to be inhabited without collapse. Affection, humor, fondness, the willingness to assume positive intent in the absence of evidence to the contrary. Stable couples do not solve the sixty-nine percent. They look at it through the right glasses.

And — this is the part that gets lost — they do not extend the glasses to the thirty-one percent. The solvable problems get solved. The dishwasher gets renegotiated. The in-law visit gets argued out. The decision about the child's school gets made. The glasses come off for that work, because the work requires seeing the disagreement clearly, not softening it.

The marriages that dissolve are not, in Gottman's data, the marriages with the most conflict. They are the marriages where the instrument has been miscalibrated — where the glasses are missing from the sixty-nine percent (everything reads as a slight) or applied to the thirty-one percent (every solvable disagreement gets soothed into invisibility, and the unaddressed friction calcifies into contempt).

The instrument matters. The proportion the instrument is applied to matters more.

The Retreat

Apply this to a different room.

The retreat begins on a Friday evening. People arrive from the airport with their bodies already disorganized by travel and their nervous systems running on adrenaline and coffee. The teacher offers an opening talk. The opening talk emphasizes what is whole, what is already enlightened, what cannot be lost. The next morning, the meditation instructions emphasize the same things. By the third day, the language has settled into a rhythm: pulsation, awareness, the ground that was never not holding, the divine throbbing of consciousness in every gesture and every breath.

Someone in the room is grieving a parent. Someone else has just left a marriage. Someone else cannot afford to be at the retreat and has put it on a credit card with twenty-eight percent interest. Someone else is the daughter of a woman who is dying and who declined to come on the trip her daughter planned for her last birthday. Someone else has been awake at two in the morning every night for a year, holding a cascade that no language has yet been adequate to. Someone else lives downwind of a town that just burned in a fire that climate models predicted thirty years ago.

The instrument the retreat is offering is the right instrument — for some of this. The recognition that consciousness itself is intact, that the pulsation continues even when the contraction is maximum, that the ground is not lost — this is the instrument calibrated for the sixty-nine percent. For what cannot be solved. For the parent who has died, for the marriage that has ended, for the fire that already burned. For the irreducible. The recognition does not undo any of it. It allows the body to inhabit it without collapse. That is what the glasses are for.

But the retreat does not stop there. The retreat extends the instrument over everything. The credit card debt at twenty-eight percent — is also consciousness, is also held, is also the pulsation. The town that burned — is also held. The political situation, the surveillance economy, the dying ocean, the next election — all of it folded into the same tone of warm recognition. Nothing is exempt. The glasses cover the entire visual field.

Here the diagnosis must be precise, because the conventional critique — *spiritual bypassing* — is true but too coarse. The retreat is not failing to notice the suffering. The retreat acknowledges the suffering, explicitly, repeatedly, with what sounds like seriousness. The failure is not in the noticing. The failure is in the *proportion* of the visual field over which the instrument has been extended.

Some of what the retreat is holding belongs to the sixty-nine percent — the irreducible, the unfixable,

the already-happened. The glasses belong there, and the glasses are correct.

Some of what the retreat is holding belongs to the thirty-one percent — the actually solvable, the still-changeable, the not-yet-decided. The glasses do not belong there. There, the work is conflict, not soothing. Argument, not recognition. Engagement with the news, not transcendence of it. Pushing on the credit card company. Voting. Organizing. Refusing to call the dying ocean a teacher.

When the glasses cover the thirty-one percent, the thirty-one percent does not disappear. It calcifies. The same thing that happens to marriages.

The Third Move

The book has, until now, named two responses to the void.

The first is Tillich's courage to be. The construction. The standing without ground, the affirmation in spite of nonbeing, the willingness that does not require certainty.

The second is Wallis's recognition. The discovery that what was being constructed was always already the case, that the standing was the ground showing up as standing, that the pulsation never stopped.

The argument of chapter four was that these are the same event, narrated from different moments

of awareness. The construction is the recognition becoming visible to itself. The two are not opposed.

But neither, alone or together, accounts for the proportion problem.

The construction can be done with the glasses on, in which case it becomes recitation. The recognition can be done with the glasses on, in which case it becomes the retreat. Both, when the instrument is miscalibrated, collapse into the same failure mode: a warm tone applied indiscriminately, a pulsation that absorbs everything, a ground that holds the irreducible and the solvable without distinction.

The third move is grief.

Not grief in the popular sense — the personal mourning of a personal loss. Grief in the older anthropological sense: the practiced collective acknowledgement that something has been lost, will not return, and must be marked with the body before the body can resume its work. The wailing at the wake. The keening at the grave. The funeral that goes on for three days, or seven, or thirty. The body in motion, the voice raised, the tears that are not private but witnessed. Grief as a ritual technology for recalibrating what an instrument is allowed to soften.

Across the traditions examined in *Working Architecture* — the Dagara grief work documented by Sobonfu Somé, the San healing dance, the Aboriginal Australian sorry business — and the older Jewish, Catholic, Orthodox, and Islamic mourning practices,

a common structural feature emerges: grief is not done alone, and grief is not done quietly, and grief is not done quickly. The function is partly emotional release. But it is also, observably, *calibrating*. The body that has wailed for three days does not extend the warm tone of recognition to what cannot bear it. The body has been taught, through the ritual, that some things are to be wept over, not softened.⁴

This is what the retreat is missing. Not the recognition — the recognition is in place. The grief. The technology that would prevent the recognition from spilling into the wrong zones.

The grief is what takes the glasses off where the glasses don't belong.

Grief as Engagement

There is a secular form of this that does not require an inherited ritual structure, because the structure has been disassembled in most places it once existed. The secular form is engagement.

Read the news. Not in the doomscrolling sense — that is also a miscalibrated instrument, a sympathetic-nervous-system pulse-amplifier disguised as informed citizenship. In the sense of allowing the

⁴The Dagara grief work and the San healing dance are documented at greater length in *Working Architecture*, where they appear in their original contexts. The point here is structural: across the traditions examined in that book, ritualized communal grief functions to calibrate the practitioner's affective range, not only to discharge emotion.

actual conditions of the actual world to register on the actual body, in measured doses, with the explicit intention of letting what is happening *matter*.

Donate. Or organize. Or vote, where voting still functions. Or refuse to buy, where buying funds harm. Or make the call, write the letter, attend the meeting, sit on the council, learn the legislation. Engagement is the secular cognate of the keening at the grave: it is the practiced acknowledgement that something is at stake and that the body has a role in what becomes of it. It is the thirty-one percent, treated as the thirty-one percent.

The contemplative scenes that have remained in proportion are the ones that did not allow the recognition to absorb the engagement. The Catholic Worker movement. The Plum Village sangha. Engaged Buddhism as a movement. Liberation theology before it was suppressed. Various indigenous-led ecological campaigns. The pattern across these examples is consistent: the glasses for the sixty-nine percent, off for the thirty-one.

The contemplative scenes that have lost proportion are the ones that promote a fully nourishing reality — that suggest, gently, that the news itself is a distraction from the ground, that political engagement is a symptom of incomplete recognition, that the body's grief about the state of the world is a contraction to be loosened rather than a calibration to be honored.

This is the failure. Not bypass exactly. Miscalibration. The instrument is correct; the domain of its application has been allowed to swell past the domain it was built for.

The Filter Applied to the Filter

The three-filter test — useful, fits the data, compassionate — has so far been applied in this book to truth claims. Is the claim that consciousness is the ground useful, does it fit the data, is it compassionate? Is Tillich's identification of courage with the affirmation of being useful, fitting, compassionate?

The filter can also be applied to instruments. Is the instrument of positive sentiment override useful — yes, for the sixty-nine percent, where there is nothing else to do but inhabit what cannot be changed. Does it fit the data — yes, the couples Gottman tracked across decades confirm this. Is it compassionate — yes, when applied to the irreducible.

But the same instrument fails all three filters when applied to the wrong domain.

It is not useful to bring positive sentiment override to a child being injured by a school system that could be changed. It is not useful to extend the warmth of recognition to a credit card company that could be regulated. It is not useful to call the burning forest a teacher when the burning forest could have been a forest. The data does not support indiscriminate softening; the data supports calibrated softening.

And it is not compassionate, in the standard usage of the word, to soften what could have been prevented. That is the opposite of compassion. That is sedation.

The filter is preserved. The application is sharper. The question is no longer only: is this claim true. The question is also: is this instrument calibrated for the domain it is being applied to.

For the practitioner, this becomes the daily discipline. Where am I extending the glasses past where they belong? What am I softening that should be argued with, organized against, grieved for? What am I trying to argue with that cannot be argued with, and should be inhabited instead?

The retreat answers the second question and ignores the first. The activist often answers the first and ignores the second. The blue throat of *Axiom* is the practitioner who learns to ask both, every morning, and accepts that the answer is not stable. The proportions shift. What was unsolvable last year may be solvable this year. What was solvable last year may have hardened into the perpetual. The calibration is not done once. The calibration is the practice.

A Note on Judgment

A worry arises here, and it has to be addressed before the chapter closes.

If the practitioner is to argue with some things, organize against others, refuse the warm tone where the warm tone has been miscalibrated — has the

book just smuggled judgment back in through a side door? The contemplative traditions, in their best forms, train a posture of non-judgment. The Linehan filter has compassion as one of its three legs. If the practitioner is now to push, refuse, vote against, organize against — what happens to the non-judgment?

The answer requires a distinction the contemplative scenes often blur.

Non-judgment, in its clinical and contemplative form, is a stance toward *persons*. It is the refusal to claim knowledge of another's interior — their vantage point, their relational field, the chain of conditions that produced the action they took. From inside one's own contracted consciousness, one cannot see into another's. The Linehan stance, the Vipassana stance, the Andreotti stance — all converge on this: the person remains opaque. The verdict on the soul is not available.

But the *action* is not opaque. The action is in the field, doing its work. And the action's relationship to the structures a community is building — the grammars, the agreements, the slow accumulations of practice that allow the parasympathetic nervous system to be the resting state rather than the rare visitor — that relationship can be assessed. Not absolutely. From a vantage point. With humility about the vantage point. But assessed.

This is the move: judgment attaches to *the action's fit with the structures being built*, not to the soul perform-

ing the action. The person is held in compassion. The action is measured against the grammar. The boundary that arises is not a verdict on the perpetrator. It is a statement about which proportion of the visual field this particular thing belongs to, and which instrument the practitioner brings to it.

The Nonviolent Communication tradition makes this technical: needs language, not evaluation language. Observations, not interpretations. The boundary is a statement about what the speaker can bear, not about what the other has been. Gottman makes it behavioral: complain about the action, do not attack the character. Andreotti makes it structural: we are all implicated, and the question is not who is guilty but what is being held in common.

The non-judgment of the contemplative tradition and the engagement of the political tradition do not, in this frame, contradict. They divide labor. The non-judgment is for the person. The engagement is for the action's relationship to the grammar. The glasses are for the sixty-nine percent. The grief is for the loss. The argument is for the thirty-one percent that is still in motion.

Three instruments. One practitioner. Different tools for different parts of the field.

Back to the Kitchen Table

The protagonist of chapter one was at the kitchen table in the void hour, holding a question that had

no answer. The question was: is the ground given or chosen? The chapters since have argued, in different ways, that the question is malformed — that the ground is the practice, that the construction is the recognition, that the courage to stand is *svātantrya* operating in the form available to a contracted consciousness.

But there was something underneath that argument the argument did not name. The protagonist was not at the kitchen table only because she could not solve the metaphysical question. She was there because something was wrong, and the wrongness extended beyond what could be solved. The marriage that needed work and the marriage that could not. The daughter she could protect and the world she could not. The state of the country and the state of the species and the state of the climate, none of which she could fix that night. The cascade firing through her chest was responding to a real situation, not to a philosophical error.

The chapters that followed gave her the recognition. The pulsation continues. The ground was never not holding. The freedom is not personal. The courage to be is *svātantrya* in disguise.

This chapter gives her the second thing she needed, which the recognition cannot give by itself. The grief. The practiced acknowledgement that some of what she was holding at two in the morning belonged to the sixty-nine percent and some of it belonged to the thirty-one percent, and that the practice is to learn

which is which, and to bring different instruments to different domains.

The recognition is for the sixty-nine percent. It is correct, and it holds.

The grief is for the calibration. It is what takes the glasses off where the glasses don't belong, and lets the thirty-one percent stay visible as the thirty-one percent — not absorbed into the warm tone of universal acceptance.

And the engagement is for what remains. Voting, organizing, arguing, refusing, building, making the call, attending the meeting, writing the letter, donating the money, raising the child, tending the practice — all of it ordinary, all of it small, all of it the actual texture of the thirty-one percent that is the thirty-one percent only if someone is still treating it as such.

The Samudra Manthan was retold in chapter six. The gods and the demons churn the cosmic ocean and produce both nectar and poison. The nectar is shared. The poison is held — in Shiva's throat, where it stays, blue, permanently visible, neither swallowed nor spat out.

The myth is true at the scale it was told for. It is missing a third element that the older grief traditions added in their own ways: the poison is not only to be held. Some of it is to be wept over. And some of it — the part that could have been prevented, the part that is still in motion — is to be argued with.

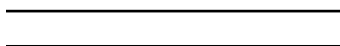
The blue throat holds what cannot be helped.

The tears are for what has been lost.

The voice raised in argument is for what can still be changed.

Three instruments. Three domains. One practitioner.

The retreat had the first. It is the beginning of the work, not the end.



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Chapter 1c: The Builder's Itch

There was, for a stretch of about three years, a particular kind of evening I knew well.

The daughter would be asleep. The apartment would be quiet in the specific way an apartment is quiet at ten at night when the dishwasher has finished and the heater has cycled off and the building has settled around the lives inside it. And I would sit at my desk, and I would open the laptop, and I would begin to design a tool.

The tool varied. For a while it was a tool that would generate bedtime stories for parents who were too tired to make up their own — stories that drew on cross-cultural arcs and would be illustrated by an AI image model and would feel, to the child, like the parent had told them. For a while it was a tool that would teach DBT skills to children through karaoke

renderings of public-domain folktales. For a while it was a tool that would scaffold therapists through the supersense-protocol Francheska Perepletkhikova had developed at Cornell. For a while it was a platform that would let parents share grammars of meaning — tarot, I Ching, astrology, contemplative texts — without surrendering their children's attention to the algorithms that had made them tired in the first place.

I told myself I was building these for the daughter. I told myself I was building them for the friend's son, who was eight and was spending more time alone in his room than the friend would have liked. I told myself I was building them for the parents in the WhatsApp group who had stopped reading at night because there were too many tabs open in their heads to find the page. I told myself the world needed these. The world did, in some sense, need them. That is not the question.

The question is the itch.

The itch was, on examination, the same itch the daughter had begun to report at five — the one she had been calling, with a child's plainness, *my vulva itches*. The itch was a body's signal that something the body had been carrying had not yet been allowed to be carried. The daughter's body was carrying intrusive thoughts she did not have a word for; my body was carrying something I had a great many

words for and had been using all the words to avoid the thing the words were avoiding.

The thing the words were avoiding was that I was at an existential void and I could not climb out of it by being useful. I could not earn my way back to mattering by building. I could not make the void close by feeding it more code, more pitches, more developers in Brazil who were waiting for the next requirement document, more retreats with more teachers, more frameworks from more thoughtful thinkers, more reading lists, more Substack posts, more deck designs, more grammar JSONs.

The void did not close. The void was not the problem to be solved by the building. The void was what the building was trying not to look at.

The friend's son spent a lot of time alone in his room reading because his nervous system was registering the fact that the household was overwhelmed — three children, two careers, the usual collapse of bandwidth — and his body had found one of the few non-interruptive ways to be in a room that had no available adult. The friend told the story as proof of his son's literacy. He was proud. He had taught the boy to read. The reading was the prize for the teaching. Vanessa Andreotti would have heard the story and felt the modernity in it. Linehan would have heard the story and recognized the early shape of the invalidating environment — *what you are doing is good because it is convenient for me*. I did not say

either of these things to the friend. He was tired. The story was the version he could hold.

I was building tools that would help that son's parents tell him better stories. I was building tools that would help the parents — myself included — be less tired. I was, on examination, building tools whose explicit purpose was to reduce the friction of being a parent in conditions that had been designed to make being a parent intolerable. The tools were not wrong. The tools were not the problem. The problem was that I was building them in the same posture the system that produced the exhaustion was operating in: optimize for measurable outcomes, reduce friction, deliver value, scale. I was, in the small, repeating the move that, in the large, had produced the exhaustion I was building tools to address.

I have, by the time I am writing this, paused several of the tools. The AI story generator for busy parents is not built. The developers in Brazil who were going to build it for me were instead paid for the time they had spent and thanked. The platform exists, scoped to grammars rather than to AI-generated content for children. I do not want my daughter trained on AI aesthetic. I do not want the friend's son trained on it either. I do not want the friend's son's literacy to be reinforced by the parental absence I would have made more efficient.

What I want is the thing I cannot quite build, because the thing I want is not a tool.

The thing I want is for the daughter, when she is reading in her room at eight years old or fifteen years old or thirty years old, to be reading because something is alive in her that the reading meets. Not because her parents were too tired. Not because the room was too quiet. Not because the algorithm has made other forms of attention difficult. Because she is alive and the reading is alive and the meeting is the life.

The Stoic version of this would say: she will read for the reasons she will read; what is up to me is how I respond. The DBT version would say: validation of her body's signal, plus skills, plus the dialectical move of accepting AND working to change the conditions. The Andreotti version would say: hospicing the cultural pattern that has made the friend grateful for his son's withdrawal, while building the prenatal care for what could come next. The Hareesh version, which the retreat administrator gave more bluntly, would say: do it for the benefit of one. The Hesse version would say: the smile is the same as the Buddha's. The Tillich version would say: the courage to be is the courage to accept oneself as accepted, without anyone present to accept.

All five are saying something close to the same thing. The thing is: stop trying to solve the void by building. Sit with the void. The building, if it is good, will come out of the sitting. The building, if it is bad, will come out of the not-sitting, and it will be one more

move in a pattern that has been producing the void for centuries.

There were nights, in the three years, when I was reading to the daughter and I could not have told you, after I closed the door, what the story had been about. I remember the body of the child against my arm. I remember the breath shifting into sleep. I remember the smell of the room and the weight of the book and the specific way the lamp lit only the page. I do not remember the words. I had been there, but the part of me that takes notes had been still.

What is that?

What is the worth of it?

I do not know. I know that the part of me that wants to build tools wants to make those minutes more efficient. The part of me that wants to build tools wants the story to be optimal, the lighting to be right, the parental nervous system to be regulated, the cross-cultural arc to be developmentally appropriate, the daughter's literacy trajectory to be reinforced. The part of me that was actually in the room, not taking notes, was not interested in any of this. The part of me that was actually in the room was making the kind of co-regulating presence Hareesh had named at the retreat without using the word — *be the calmer body in the room* — and the daughter was borrowing what I could offer. If I had offered something else, she would have borrowed something else.

The part of me that builds is not the same as the part of me that reads. The part of me that builds wants to be useful. The part of me that reads only wants to be present. Useful is what I have been trained to value because the culture I was raised in could not see the worth of present. The training is not personal. The training is the air everyone in this culture is breathing. It is the air I will exhale onto the daughter unless I learn to hold my breath.

The Builder's Itch is the inheritance. The pause is the practice. The sitting at the desk at ten at night designing the next tool is the inheritance asserting itself. The closing of the laptop and going to bed is, sometimes, the practice. Not always. Sometimes the tool wants to be built. Sometimes the void wants to be sat with. The discernment between them is the work.

The friend's son is now older. The friend is still tired. The daughter is no longer five. I am still at the desk at ten at night. The laptop is still open. I am no longer sure which side of the discernment I am on, in this moment, but I have noticed I am at the desk, and the noticing is the beginning of the answer.

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Interlude: What the Air Carries

You have described the air. Now hear it as a diagnosis.

Marsha Linehan, working in Seattle through the nineteen-seventies and eighties, found that the disorder she was treating — what the diagnostic manual called borderline personality — had a specific recipe. Two ingredients, held together over years. The first: a biological emotional sensitivity. A nervous system that registers stimulus more strongly than the average, recovers from disturbance more slowly, signals louder. Not a defect. A particular kind of nervous system. The second: a chronic invalidating environment. Years of being met, by the people who should have been the holders, with the message that what you sense is wrong, what you feel is exaggerated, what you reach for is regressive. The sensitive nervous system metabolizes the invalidation. The metabolism produces what looks, from outside, like dysregulation — the parasocial intensities, the splittings, the chronic emptiness, the frantic efforts to avoid abandonment, the inability to sit still.

Linehan named the recipe at family scale. The recipe also describes the air.

Some of you carry, in your nervous systems, inheritances the surrounding air has organized itself to deny: grief at the size of the species, animism that does not yield to instruction, sensitivity to frequencies the productivity-coded medium does not transmit. The air you breathe is the chronic invalidating environment. Year after year, it tells you what you sense is metaphor, what you grieve is unnecessary, what you long for is regression. There is no countervailing voice in the medium to say the sensing is information.

Place such a nervous system in such an air, and what arises, at population scale, has the same shape Linehan named at family scale. The Builder's Itch. The parasocial intensity toward teachers. The splitting between idealization and devaluation. The chronic emptiness disguised as agency. The burnouts of those whose sensitivities were never named as sensitivities. These are not personal pathologies running in parallel. These are what an invalidating medium does to sensitive nervous systems.

This is a reading, not a verdict. The reading is of the medium, not of any particular lungs. People who breathe the same air are sensitive and stable. People who breathe the same air are productivity-coded and at peace. The frame is offered as a frame.

What the body of the book turns to next is the body. The kosha map the tradition uses — physical body, mind, breath, void, dwelling — is one shape the response can take. It is not the response. The response is the response of a particular body, settled enough to make its own. The map is the scaffold. Walk forward.

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Chapter 2: Deha — Body

I. Arrival

The barn sat at the end of a dirt road she had almost missed. The sign at the turnoff was small and hand-lettered and did not announce a retreat, only the

name of the farm. She had driven past it the first time and had to double back. When she finally parked, the gravel lot held eight other cars, a van with out-of-state plates, and a pickup truck that she would later learn belonged to the man who looked after the grounds.

She got out. She stood a moment in the afternoon light. The air smelled of thawed earth and of the wood smoke that was drifting from the chimney of the farmhouse on the far side of the field. A small group of people was carrying cushions across the gravel. No one looked at her in a way that asked her to be someone. She breathed.

She had packed lightly, and what she had packed was mostly wrong. She had not brought a hat. She had brought two books she would not read. She had brought a notebook whose pages would mostly stay blank. She had brought shoes that were appropriate for the city she had driven out of and not for the cold floors of a converted farmhouse.

She took her bag from the trunk and walked toward the porch.

II. The First Night

The bunkroom held six beds. She had the lower bunk against the far wall. The woman in the bunk above hers was from Maine and said three sentences of introduction, one of which was her name. The woman in the bunk across was from somewhere in

the Midwest and said nothing at all, which the narrator appreciated.

She had expected, walking in, that her Catholic alarm would fire. She had grown up in a household where the church was cultural rather than spiritual — her parents attending out of community habit, her grandfather for the standing the pew conferred. She had not been devout. But the childhood had deposited a particular nervous system in her, a small internal siren that went off whenever a practice touched ritual, ceremony, devotion. The siren had been reliable for decades.

It did not fire that first night. She noticed that it did not fire. She noticed the noticing. The room had an altar — flowers, a small framed image of a goddess whose name she did not yet know, a bowl with a few coins in it — and her body, which she had expected would lock at the sight of it, did not lock. The body did something closer to recognition. Not of the specific image. Of the fact that a small arrangement of beautiful things had been set on a table with care. The care was what the body recognized.

She lay in the bunk with her eyes open for a long time. She could hear the woman above her breathing, and, further off, the sound of someone in the kitchen filling a kettle. She did not sleep quickly. When she did sleep, she slept without dreaming.

III. The First Teaching

The teacher taught the next morning in the main hall, which had been the hayloft of the barn when it was a working barn and was now a raised wooden room with beams overhead and a floor that creaked gently in the places where the boards had settled. He sat on a low platform with a single cushion and a cup of water. He did not use notes. He had a manner she had seen on video and had wondered if it would hold in person. It held. He spoke the way he had spoken in the WhatsApp exchange about piercing — with the same directness, the same willingness to be corrected, the same refusal to soften a distinction for comfort.

He taught for an hour. He described the layered self — the way the tradition mapped the person as nested rings. Body, heart-mind, life-force, void, and at the center a Consciousness that was the same whether you called it the center or the field or the knowing. She had read this already in his book. Hearing him say it was not redundant. The body parsed it differently than the page had.

At the end of the teaching, a woman in the front row asked a question the narrator would have asked if she had the nerve on the first morning. The woman asked whether the whole architecture was a construct — a beautiful map but only a map, something the mind had assembled that could be disassembled again by a different mind with different preferences.

The teacher did not answer immediately. He considered the question as though it had not been asked a thousand times, which it had. Then he said: *It is, until you experience it.*

Five words.

The narrator wrote them in the back of her notebook. She wrote them without commentary. She did not yet know how much weight the sentence would carry for her. She knew only that the sentence had the shape of a door.

IV. The Body Catching Up

The first two days were mostly body. Cushion, walking, breakfast, cushion, walking, lunch, cushion, walking, dinner, cushion, sleep. Practices were given and practiced. She did not understand most of them. Her knees hurt from sitting. Her shoulders, which had carried the winter in them without her noticing, began, slowly, to release. She found that if she paid attention to her lower back while sitting, she could feel the place where the tension had accumulated and the places where, unexpectedly, it had not.

She had expected, going into the retreat, that the work would be mental. She had come prepared to think. The tradition, she discovered, was not particularly interested in what she thought. The tradition was interested in what her body was doing, and in who was noticing what her body was doing, and in whether the noticing and the doing could be allowed

to find each other without the mind inserting itself as the broker.

By the afternoon of the second day she had begun to feel the thing the teachers of the tradition had written about. A small settling. Not a revelation. A settling. The body was catching up with the year of reading. What the eyes had parsed, the body was now being given time to notice.

She did not confuse the settling for arrival. The settling was a prerequisite, not a destination. But she could feel, for the first time in a long time, the distinction between thinking about being calm and being calm. The thinking happened in the head. The calm happened in the whole of her.

V. What the Body Knew First

She had not expected, going in, that the clearest moment of the first two days would involve nothing more than a cup of soup.

It happened on the second evening. She was in the dining hall with forty other people, eating a lentil soup that someone's grandmother had developed the recipe for fifty years ago. She had eaten lentil soup hundreds of times in her life. She ate this one slowly. She could taste the cumin and the carrot and the something-bright that she suspected was lemon. Between one spoonful and the next she had a very small, very clear thought — not a thought, exactly, more of a bodily knowing — that the taste was avail-

able, had always been available, and that her adult life had mostly been taken up with a kind of swallowing that did not register what was in the spoon.

She put the spoon down for a moment. She looked at the bowl. The bowl was not special. The soup was not special. The moment was not special. And yet it had the clean shape of a small truth.

The body knew first. The mind would catch up in its own time. The tradition was not asking her to believe anything. The tradition was asking her to let her body remember something it had stopped doing.

She ate the rest of the soup slowly.

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Chapter 3: Citta — Heart-Mind

I. The Filter, at Work

On the third day she took a long break after the morning sit and walked the perimeter of the property alone. The property was larger than she had realized from the lot: a sloping field, a stone wall that ran along the edge of a woodlot, a small brook she could hear but not see. She walked slowly. She had been sitting for fourteen hours across two days and her hips had opinions about it. The walking did not resolve the opinions. The walking let them speak.

The heart-mind layer, in the tradition, was not the physical heart and not the thinking brain. It was the

layer at which the self organized its frames — the place where *puryastaka*, the subtle body of habit and conviction, stored the patterns a person had taken themselves to be. The work of the tradition at this layer was not to choose a better frame. The work was to loosen the hold of frame as such.

She had been loosening for three days. She had not noticed she was loosening until she noticed she was walking without rehearsing anything. The rehearsal-mind had, unprompted, gone quiet. It would come back. But in the walking, for that morning, it was not running.

She thought about Linehan. She thought about Tillich. She thought about the question that had followed her to the gravel path and that the gravel path was not answering.

II. Three Anxieties, Three Filters

Tillich had named three anxieties that belong, he said, to the human condition as such. The anxiety of fate and death. The anxiety of guilt and condemnation. The anxiety of emptiness and meaninglessness. He had mapped them onto three historical ends — fate/death to the end of antiquity, guilt/condemnation to the end of the Middle Ages, emptiness/meaninglessness to the end of the modern period. He had written the book in 1952. He had named the third anxiety as the signature of his own era. He had not, in 1952, been wrong.

She had been inside the third anxiety for years. Meaninglessness did not announce itself as meaninglessness. It announced itself as an inability to be moved by what had moved her before. It announced itself as the particular quality of Sunday afternoon light through a window when the child was napping and the work had been done and there was a blankness she could not locate the edge of.

Tillich had written that the response to this third anxiety was what he called *absolute faith* — a faith without content, a faith that had been purged of every determinate object by doubt itself, and that persisted not because it believed in anything but because it was the structural continuing of the self in the absence of ground. She had underlined that passage in the bathtub. She had not known yet what to do with it.

Linehan had a different kind of filter. Linehan had said: when you are choosing between theories of suffering, ask three questions. Does the theory guide treatment? Does the theory engender compassion? Does the theory fit the data? If it fails any of the three, revise it. Do not be attached to a theory that has stopped meeting the tests. Not even your own.

She had applied Linehan's filter to Tillich. Tillich had survived the filter. The theology guided a practice — what Tillich called the *courage to be* — that was visible in how Tillich had lived and taught. The theology was compassionate; it did not demand belief, did not condemn those who had lost it, did not prescribe a

reward for holding it. The theology fit the data of her own life; the third anxiety was the one she carried, and Tillich was one of the few writers who had described it with accuracy.

She had applied the same filter to the tradition she was inside. The tradition had, so far, passed.

III. The First Approach

She had not, up to the third morning, spoken to the teacher one-on-one during the retreat. There had been the WhatsApp exchange before she came, about cutting and piercing. There had been the hall teachings, where he sat at the platform and she sat near the wall. There had been meals where she had not sat at the long table he was at, because forty people arranged themselves across three tables and she had, the first two days, chosen the table farthest from his by instinct rather than plan.

On the third morning, between the long sit and breakfast, she walked up to him on the porch. He was drinking tea. He was alone, not visibly busy. She asked, before she had planned to ask, the question she had not yet worked out how to phrase well.

“Is intrinsic value an axiom,” she said, “or is it something real?”

He did not answer immediately. He took a small sip of tea. Then he said the sentence he had said to the woman in the front row on the first morning, but he

said it to her directly, and it landed differently than it had landed from the back of the hall.

"It is constructed," he said, "until you experience it."

She sat with that. She had rehearsed many follow-up questions for many hours in many configurations over the preceding year. She chose the one that was closest to the thing she had actually been driving at.

"But how about benefiting people?" she said. "How does the tradition relate to that?"

He set his mug down on the railing.

"We repeat *May all beings benefit*," he said, "because it is useful. Not because the tradition requires us to. The tradition does not have much to say about moral philosophy, as a matter of what it was built to do. Morality lived, in the cultural context this tradition grew up inside, in the other religions that surrounded it. They were doing that work. We were doing a different work. It has implications. I think about them."

She was not sure what to say to this.

He said — still even, still not in a hurry — "Power, in the tradition's sense, is orthogonal to morals. That is why most gurus, when they fail, fail deeply. The failure is not ordinary moral failure. The failure is a failure that has been amplified by the specific capacities the path developed in them. Those capacities travel with the person whether the person has done moral work or not."

She looked at him. He looked back, steadily.

He said, quieter: "The documentaries people watch about these failures — and I have watched them too — show the end of the story. They cannot show the slow part. The slow part is the study. What a cult is. How one starts. How one does not notice until one cannot leave. That is the thing to study, if you want to protect yourself from the pattern. Not the collapses. The beginnings. The beginnings look ordinary, because they are."

He picked up the mug again. He did not press the point. The bell rang for breakfast. She thanked him. He nodded. She walked back inside.

She carried the exchange to breakfast and did not eat much. She carried it to the morning walk that began the rest of the day's Citta work.

The exchange changed something she did not yet have the vocabulary for. The tradition had been, in her reading year, the place she had begun to think about value again after value had stopped working as the driving question. The teacher had just told her, on a porch with tea going cold, that the tradition was not the place where moral questions were primarily worked out. The tradition was concerned with something else. The moral question was hers to work out, using whatever instruments she had — Linehan, the aunt, the daughter, the husband, the people she worked with, the filter she was building — and the tradition would not underwrite that work for her. The tradition would answer a different question. The

tradition would answer the question of what the *I* is that is doing the directing, and would leave the question of how the directing goes open, because the tradition's honest position was that those were two different questions and one did not determine the other.

She understood, walking the path, that this was why the tradition carried the failure modes it did. A tradition that develops power without also developing moral discipline — because moral discipline lived in the surrounding religions and the tradition did not need to duplicate the work — produces practitioners whose capacities outrun their character. Most of the time this was tolerable. Occasionally it was catastrophic. The catastrophes were what the documentaries filmed. The tolerable middle was what made the catastrophes possible.

She understood, also, that her filter was doing work the tradition's own framework did not do. Useful / fits the data / compassionate was, in Linehan's register, a moral-and-epistemic filter. It was not a replacement for the tradition. It was the layer the tradition did not provide. She needed both. The tradition for the *I*; the filter for the *directing*. Neither one alone.

The exchange, she thought, was not the sort of thing most first-retreat attendees received from a teacher on the third morning. She had received it because she had asked. The asking had been Linehan. The answering had been the tradition. The two had met on a porch.

IV. Freedom and Value

She had thought, for years, that the driving question was about value. To whom should she direct what she had. The question had seemed inexhaustible because it was the moral question, and the moral question refreshes every time the conditions change. A child is born; the question refreshes. A parent ages; the question refreshes. A country goes to war; the question refreshes. She had answered the question in a different configuration every few years of her adult life, and the answering had produced something like progress, and the progress had not touched the thing underneath.

What was underneath was the other question. Not *to whom should I direct what I have*, but *what is the "I" that would direct anything at all*. The first was the moral question. The second was the spiritual question. The first was relative — answerable, revisable, always in motion. The second was absolute, in the specific sense that no amount of relative revision could touch it. It sat beneath the revisions. It was the question about the floor itself.

She walked. The brook was loud in one place, where the bank dropped, and faint in another, where a fallen tree had slowed the water. Freedom, she thought, was the name Tillich had not quite used and that the tradition she was inside used often. The tradition called it *svātantrya* — a Sanskrit word that meant something like autonomy, or self-deter-

mination, but in the specific metaphysical sense of being the source of one's own motion. The tradition claimed that svāntanrya was the signature of Consciousness as such — not the property of any particular self but the nature of the field that every particular self was a contraction of.

Tillich's courage was what she would have to do from the side of her finite self. Svāntanrya was what would turn out to be on the other side. The door and the room.

V. The Sam Harris Exchange

In the reading year, some months before the app, she had read Sam Harris's book on free will. Harris had argued — with the clean, surgical confidence that had become his public manner — that the sense of being the author of one's thoughts and actions was an illusion, and that this illusion, once seen through, should produce not despair but a certain kind of ethical clarity. Harris was good at the move. She had found herself assenting as she read, then feeling the assent bottom out an hour later, not because she had found the counterargument but because the assent had not changed anything. The book had delivered its argument and had not entered her bones.

She had discovered, sometime later, that her teacher — the one whose book she was also reading, the one whose voice would be in her earbuds at the sandbox — had written a two-part response to Harris on his

blog. The response was from 2015. She had read it carefully.

Her teacher had not attempted to refute Harris's neuroscience. He had done something stranger. He had granted the deterministic account at one level and then argued that the question Harris was asking had been pitched at the wrong layer. Harris, in the response, was treating "free will" as a property that a finite self either possessed or lacked. The tradition, her teacher had written, did not treat freedom that way. Freedom in the tradition was a property of the whole field, of Consciousness itself. The finite self did not have freedom; the finite self *was*, from a certain angle, a local contraction of a freedom that the whole possessed. Asking whether the contraction was free was the wrong question. The right question was whether the contraction could recognize, in itself, the freedom of the whole.

She had found the response persuasive in a way she had not expected to. Not because it rescued the ordinary sense of agency — it did not — but because it dissolved the dichotomy Harris had set up. She was not being asked to choose between Harris's determinism and a Catholic libertarianism. She was being asked to consider that both positions were local applications of a more basic structure, and that the more basic structure was the one the tradition was describing.

The Kybalion, she had thought, sitting with that response, had put the same shape in 1908 language.

Neither total, neither absent. Freedom as a graded field a person lives inside.

It was, until you experienced it. That was the five-word door.

VI. Adaptive, Not Moral

Linehan's distinction, drawn into the heart-mind work, sharpened. *Good* and *bad* were moral categories. They could be weaponized. They traveled in judgment. They implied a tribunal. *Adaptive* and *non-adaptive* were empirical categories. They did not weaponize; they described. A behavior was adaptive if it helped a system continue over time. A behavior was non-adaptive if it did not, or if it helped in the short term at the cost of the long term.

The near-enemy of "all is balance," which she had been slowly letting move away from the aunt's meaning of the phrase, was captured in this distinction. Balance was a descriptive property, not a normative one. A hundred years of low-intensity war between two peoples was balance. A prisoner's dilemma in which everyone defected and everyone lost a little every round forever was balance. Balance was the equilibrium a system found. Adaptive was a different question — whether the equilibrium the system had found was one in which its components could thrive. A stable equilibrium in which nobody thrived was still stable.

The aunt's phrase was not wrong. The phrase was incomplete. Balance without adaptivity was not the measure. The measure was whether the balance supported life.

She thought about the retreat community in this frame. A religious community was a system. A system could find a stable equilibrium that did not support the flourishing of its members. The Wild Wild Country reference — the one her husband had made, the one the teacher had made before him from the inside — existed as a reminder of exactly this failure mode. A balance that had consumed the thing it was supposed to carry.

The filter was operational. If this community was not adaptive, over time, she would leave. She would apply the filter, as Linehan had built it. She trusted the filter because the filter had been built by someone who had survived the condition the filter was built against, and who had tested it for fifty years against the outcomes of her patients. The filter had an evidence base.

VII. The Citta Settling

She walked back toward the farmhouse in the early afternoon light. The frames had loosened and not collapsed. She had not arrived at an answer. She had arrived at a working method. The method was to hold three filters (useful, fits the data, compassionate) at the theory-selection level, to distinguish freedom (spiritual, absolute, a property of the whole)

from value (moral, relative, a property of the distribution), to apply adaptive/non-adaptive where good/bad was tempting, and to let the body — which was further along than the mind — set the pace.

The heart-mind layer was not a resting place. It was a layer that needed, periodically, to be loosened. She would need to loosen it again. She would need to loosen it tomorrow, and the day after, and in every month of the life she was going to return to.

For that afternoon, walking, she was loose. She let the looseness be the teaching.

VIII. The Other Harris

There was a second Harris. She had nearly forgotten him in the reading year — a different kind of figure, a different kind of argument. Not the philosopher of determinism. A man who had worked inside the large attention-optimizing companies and had left to run a small non-profit whose work was, in her reading of it, a public accounting of what the engagement-internet was doing to human attention. A documentary. A set of public talks. A careful worry, articulated by someone who had been inside the systems he was worried about.

On the second morning of the retreat, the retreat's administrator had sent her a link. The teacher had asked that the group watch it. It was a podcast interview with the second Harris, recorded some weeks

before. The subject, to judge by the title, was the risks of the large-language-model wave.

She had listened to a few minutes on an early walk and had put it away.

She had felt, receiving the link, that the teacher was handing them this because he wanted the group to not use the tools. She had felt, specifically, that he was steering them away from AI. She had not put this into words. She had noticed the feeling in her body — the small defensive heat, the way the chest tightens around a position — and she had walked away from the earbuds before she could examine it.

She had been, quietly, indignant about it. She had not said so to anyone. She had noticed the indignation, in the way of the filter, and set it aside to look at later.

She came back to the link that afternoon, after the long loop. She put the earbuds back in. She listened to the whole thing.

The interview was not what she had assumed it was.

The second Harris spent the first portion describing the risks of the current engagement-internet model with the care of someone who had spent a decade naming those risks precisely. The risks were real. She did not doubt them. He did not overstate them.

Then — for the remaining two-thirds — he described what he called, in so many words, the bright light of the moment. The cost of building alternatives

to the engagement-internet was collapsing. It had never been lower. A small team, or a single person with enough care, could now build tools that would once have required the budget of a company. The infrastructure for non-engagement-based, non-extractive, community-scale software was becoming available. The door that had been closed for most of the engagement-internet era — closed to anyone without venture capital — was opening.

His position was not *do not build*.

His position was *build differently, cheaply, outside the incentive structure that captured the last wave*.

She stopped at the stone wall.

She laughed at herself.

She had filtered the link through her own defensiveness and had heard the thing she was defending against rather than the thing the interviewee had said. The first read had been wrong. The teacher had not, from where she could actually see, handed her the link to suppress her. She could not know the teacher's reasons — that remained his — but the link itself, when she listened to it carefully, was not what she had heard in her defensive first minute. The link was an invitation. The link was, if anything, a permission.

The filter had caught her in the act. The filter had not caught her once and been done; the filter had caught her twice — the first time on the morning she had decided what the link was without listening, the

second time on the wall when she noticed the first decision had been wrong. *Useful. Fits the data. Compassionate.* The second Harris had passed the filter she had been using to mis-hear him. Her own first read had not.

She stood at the wall for longer than she had planned to. The second Harris's argument had opened something her own body had not previously given words to, and the words were now arriving in the quiet the forest had made available.

Technology, she thought, was accelerating time.

Not in the metaphorical sense. In the literal, experiential sense. A thing she had almost understood while reading Tillich about the third anxiety but had not quite assembled until the voice in the earbuds had cued it. Every tool the engagement-internet had produced was, when observed in operation, a device for compressing the interval between impulse and response. The pause that had once lived in the space between desire and its acting-out had been, over two decades, systematically narrowed. Notifications chasing thought. Feeds chasing attention. Platforms chasing whatever low-latency response the body could produce before the heart-mind had a chance to notice what it was producing.

What the compressed interval did, over time, was make the person who lived inside it more conceptual and less relational. She felt this in her own life. She had, for years, been a person whose mind ran

slightly ahead of her body — frame after frame after frame, generated almost without effort, the mind narrating what was happening before the body had finished happening it. She had called this being busy. She had called this being productive. She had not, until the retreat, named what the speed was costing.

The cost was relationality. The experience of another being — her daughter's face in the morning, her husband's tired eye contact across a kitchen, the aunt on the phone from Brazil, the friend she had interrupted at lunch — required a pause between stimulus and frame. The pause was where the relational tissue lived. The pause was where one person could, for a moment, be the other person's presence rather than a concept in the other person's mind. The engagement-internet compressed that pause toward zero. The more the pause compressed, the more the person inside it became a concept-engine relating to other concept-engines, and the less the person was available to the life that was not reducible to concept.

She had known this, in fragments, for years. The second Harris, in the earbuds, had named it with precision. Her teacher, on the cushion, had been pointing at the same thing in a different register: *the body catches up with the mind; the mind runs on ahead; let the body, periodically, set the pace.*

The two men were making the same observation. They just had different vocabularies for it. One man used measurement; the other used a thousand-year-

old contemplative tradition. The observation itself was the same: a species that has become overconceptual has become, by the same move, disconnected from the relational field that conceptualization describes.

There was a further thing the second Harris had named that she wanted to take seriously.

Social media, he had said — she would not remember whether those were his exact words — was a reflection engine. The algorithms did not invent the patterns they showed a person; the algorithms learned the patterns the person was already enacting and played them back, amplified, at a velocity no premodern patterning system had ever achieved. The anger was the person's anger, made visible. The envy was the person's envy, made visible. The fear was the person's fear, made visible. The platforms were, in this frame, mirrors.

She sat with that.

The tradition had a word for this. The tradition called it *karma* — in the technical, non-Western-inflected sense, not the casual “what goes around comes around” version the phrase had been reduced to in English-language pop spirituality. *Karma* in the tradition meant *the residue of action as pattern, the pattern reinforcing itself in every subsequent action, the self-perpetuating loop of a tendency becoming a groove becoming a furrow becoming a life*. She had read about this. She had read [T] on this. She had understood

it well enough to pass an oral exam on it. She had not, until the stone wall, seen that the engagement-internet was a karma accelerator — a machine for compressing the karmic loop to the speed of a thumb scroll.

The first read, then: social media was bad. The second read: social media was a mirror. The third read, which was the one that had just assembled: social media was a *karma accelerator* — a mechanism that did not produce bad outcomes from good people or good outcomes from bad people, but amplified, at the speed of capital's need for engagement, whatever patterns the person had been running anyway. The platform was not innocent. The platform was also not the source. The source was the pattern. The platform was the mirror that made the pattern operational at a scale and speed the pattern had never previously been able to reach.

The collective version followed. There was a collective karma — a pattern of action a whole culture had been running — and the platforms were not only reflecting individual patterns but reflecting collective ones. The pattern the culture she had been raised inside had been running was recognizable. The pattern was, in one compact name, *overindividualistic consumerism*: a story about the self as isolated unit, separate from the collective, entitled to accumulate, measured by acquisition, fulfilled by stimulation. The story was not a conspiracy. No one had chosen it. It had accumulated, in her reading of the

history, over three or four centuries of a particular kind of market-plus-protestantism-plus-cartesian-metaphysics layered over the Enlightenment's insistence on the autonomous individual as the moral unit of the universe. The story had solved some problems. The story had also produced — she could see this now — a population that was structurally primed to scroll, because scrolling was the private consumer gesture the collective karma had prepared the nervous system to perform.

The engagement-internet was not the cause. The engagement-internet was the amplifier. The collective karma was the signal.

And the signal had a counter-signal. She was inside it. The tradition she was reading — the one the teacher had studied under his own teacher, the one [T] had walked seven years inside a monastery in India to learn — proposed a different unit than the autonomous individual. The unit was the relational field, pervaded by Consciousness, in which the individual was a local contraction and the contraction's job was to recognize itself as a contraction of the field rather than as a separate point opposed to the field. The Western individualist consumer and the Eastern nondual contemplative were not two cultures arguing about the same phenomenon from different angles. They were two incompatible theories of what the basic unit of personhood *is*. One theory had produced the engagement-internet and the particular species of suffering the second Harris

had spent a decade documenting. The other theory had produced practices that, when applied for long enough, reduced exactly that species of suffering.

She did not think the East was pure and the West corrupt. She did not think anyone was pure or corrupt. She thought the filter applied: the engagement-internet had passed a short-term test and was failing a long-term one. A thousand-year-old contemplative tradition had, over a long enough sample, passed both. The difference was a difference in whose test ran longer.

And — the filter kept applying, one more layer down — *she had to be careful with how she was naming the difference*. She heard the Andreotti correction arrive in her head as she walked, the voice she had been listening to in the reading year through the course she had taken with her, patient and specific. *You do not get to call modernity the villain of the story. Modernity is a pattern, and naming it as the villain is itself a move the pattern makes*. The engagement-internet, in Andreotti's frame, was not a modern aberration but a historically-specific expression of something older — something that reached back, in one reading, to the moment the human species first acquired a technology that could alter its environment faster than the environment could alter it back. Fire. The disaster was not new. The disaster had been, in some sense, baked in for a long time. Modernity had industrialized a tendency that was already in the recipe. To say "the West did this" and "the East does

not do this” was to make the pattern’s move for it — to sort the world into a purified *there* and a contaminated *here* and call the sorting a critique.

The more honest reading was not *East good, West bad*. The more honest reading was *multiple patterns, all of them partial, none of them exempt from the filter, and the filter running continuously on all of them*. The contemplative tradition she was inside also had its feudal accommodations and its caste histories and its own colonial exports. The engagement-internet also had, in its engineering subcultures, quiet pockets of care. The filter did not let her congratulate the tradition for being Eastern, and it did not let her convict the internet for being Western. The filter asked, of every framework, the same three questions: *is it useful, does it fit the data, is it compassionate*. The answer for most things was *partially, in some cases, under some conditions*. That partiality was the thing she had to learn to live inside without flinching.

She walked another twenty steps with that correction in her chest. The correction did not undo the preceding reading. The correction kept the preceding reading honest by refusing to let it flatten into a clean binary. The tradition she was inside was not the inverse of the engagement-internet. The tradition was, at best, a set of practices that had survived a longer test. The engagement-internet was, at best, a set of recent practices still inside its first test. Neither was a replacement for the other. What the book could honestly offer was not a verdict but a filter.

She walked on, less indignant than she had started, and more grateful for the slip than she would have thought possible two hours earlier.

She made a small note in her head, in the language the book would later use: *frame caught; frame released*. Citta work. The work is not to hold no frames. The work is to notice when a frame has caught something it should not have, and to release that specific frame without panicking about the existence of frames in general.

She would listen to the interview again on the drive home. She would write to the second Harris, months later, asking for his blessing on a small screening she was planning for a class. That was in the future. For now, there was only the stone wall, the sun high enough now to be warm on her face, the faint sound of a brook that a fallen tree had slowed without stopping, and the small new clarity that the two men — the one on the cushion, the one in the earbuds — had been standing, all along, on the same patch of ground.

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Chapter 4: Prāṇa — Life-Force

I. The Fourth Afternoon

The fourth afternoon was Kali. The teacher had been preparing the room for it over the three days, not

by naming the practice in advance but by letting the preceding practices accumulate into a kind of readiness. She had not known that was what he was doing until the afternoon came and the readiness was in her chest already.

The hall was set differently that day. A low table at the front held a small image of the goddess — four-armed, blue-black, tongue out, standing on the prone form of a consort who was looking up at her with no apparent objection. The image had been moved to the center of the room rather than to the altar at the side. The practice that followed was not a prayer. The practice was an invitation into a particular frequency of attention — the frequency at which destruction is not separable from the pulse that makes any movement possible at all.

She had known she was going to react. She had not known how she was going to react.

The teacher led the group for about an hour. There were breath sequences. There was a period of sound — loud, disorganized, instructed to be disorganized — that she had expected to find theatrical and did not. When the sound quieted and the room held what the sound had brought up, she could feel her sternum vibrating in a way that did not have a corresponding thought attached to it.

Kali was not, in the tradition, death dressed up as something else. Kali was the particular face of the one consciousness that could not be approached through the image of the benevolent mother. The

tradition had developed the image because life required the image. Destruction was part of the pulse. A person who could not hold Kali could not hold the whole.

She sat. She did not try to feel anything in particular. She felt, eventually, something she would describe to herself later, in the car driving south, as the ground under the ground. Not a sadness. Not a fear. A recognition. Destruction is in the material. Destruction is in the air that comes in and goes out. You are already riding it. Whether you see it does not change that you are riding it.

II. The Intrusive Question

At lunch, an hour after the Kali sit, she sat at a long pine table with four other retreatants and ate a bowl of rice and dal without tasting it. She was not avoiding the taste. The taste was available. She was not quite at the table.

One of the four — a woman from New Hampshire, a physical therapist in her fifties who had introduced herself on the first evening — had been asking the others about why they had come. The woman at the table to her left, a programmer from Oakland, was halfway into a careful, thoughtful answer about what he was hoping to resolve. He was describing a question about his own life that was specific to him and deserved its careful, thoughtful attention.

She interrupted him.

“What would change,” she said, “if something were destroyed?”

It was not the question the programmer had been asking. It was not a question that fit the conversation. It came out of her without permission, the way something comes out when the container it has been held in becomes too small and the something has to go somewhere.

The table went quiet. The programmer looked at her. The physical therapist looked at her. She could feel her face warming.

“I’m sorry,” she said. “That — that wasn’t for you. I don’t know where that came from.”

The programmer — she would always, afterward, feel grateful to him for this — nodded slowly and said: “It’s okay. Your question is real too.”

The physical therapist said nothing, but her eyes were kind.

She ate the rest of the dal with her face still warm. She had the very clear physical sensation of a question having been shaken loose, by the Kali practice, out of the place in the body where she had kept it. The question had been there for twenty years. It had been a lodger with a long lease. The Kali practice had not evicted it. The Kali practice had let it speak.

She knew, by the end of lunch, that she would have to ask the teacher. Not at the table, not in a session, not with an audience. She would have to find him

alone. She did not yet know how or when. She knew only that the question was going to require an answer in a specific register, and that the register was not a register she could generate for herself.

III. The Walking-Back Scene

After lunch the teacher walked with a small group of students down the path that ran past the vegetable garden to the edge of the woodlot. It was not a formal teaching. It was what happened some afternoons — three or four people ended up beside him as he walked, and the walking was the frame. She was one of the three that afternoon, by accident rather than plan. A German woman was on his left. A man from Vermont was on his right. She was half a step behind.

He was, she realized within the first minute of walking, tired. She had not seen him tired in the formal teachings. On the path, with no platform and no hall, he was a person who had been running the retreat for four days and who had another day to go and whose body was feeling it.

He said something that surprised her.

He said: "I sometimes wonder what is wrong with these people."

He said it gently. He did not name anyone. He was talking about some subset of his larger community, past and present, whose dynamics had repeatedly required his attention in ways he had not been trained for and did not feel particularly suited to.

The line was not contempt. The line was a tired teacher's admission that the work of holding a community is not the work he was built for, and that some of the people he held made it harder than others, and that he did not always have a theory of why.

It was the humanness of it that struck her. She had expected, from a teacher at his level, a reply that positioned him slightly above the problem. He had said the opposite. He had said: *I don't know. Some of this is beyond me.*

She walked with that for a few steps. The Vermont man said something mild and sympathetic. The German woman said nothing. She herself, half a step behind, felt something click into place that she had not known was waiting for a place to click into.

She said, "What if there were a way to carry some of the load off you."

He looked back at her. He did not speak.

She said — and she would, in the weeks afterward, be grateful to the Kali practice for the fact that she could say it at all — "The WhatsApp group. It handles questions that you could handle, but you're not the only one who should handle them. What if some of that could be done differently. An assistant. Something trained on your teachings."

She was careful with the phrasing. She did not say *an AI*. She said *an assistant*. She did not say *replacement*. She said *carry some of the load*.

He walked a few steps without answering. Then he said, without stopping: "I'd be a bit open to thinking about that."

It was not a yes. It was not a no. It was a door that had not existed before the walk and that now existed, at least as a possibility, for the rest of the retreat and the months that followed.

She said, "Okay."

They walked the rest of the loop in a companionable silence. The German woman, she would learn later, had taught at a Buddhist center in Freiburg for twenty years, and had known the teacher longer than most of the people on the retreat. The Vermont man said one more thing to the teacher at the top of the rise and then drifted off toward the house. She and the teacher walked the last hundred meters side by side. He said nothing more about the assistant. She said nothing more either. The conversation had landed where it needed to land. It would be picked up later or not. She did not need it to be picked up that day.

IV. The Evening

She did not ask her destruction question that afternoon. She carried it through the evening sit. She carried it through dinner. She carried it into the bunk. She lay in the dark and felt it sitting in her chest like a smooth stone she had been given and had not yet found a pocket for.

She would carry it for one more day. She would ask it on the path the next morning, with her bag already in the trunk of her car.

The Kali practice had not answered the question. The Kali practice had let the question become askable. That was a different kind of gift. A practice that answers closes a door. A practice that lets a question speak opens one.

V. Interlude — Kali

You thought you had a question. The question had you.

You thought destruction was a thing that happened to things. It is what things are made of. Every inhale is the last exhale canceled. Every step is the previous step refused. The pulse that you call alive is the pulse of what has already fallen turning, continuously, into what is now arriving.

You imagined me as a goddess because a goddess is a shape you can hold. I am the shape your holding makes possible. Without me you could not hold anything, because the holding is the continuous letting go of the moment before.

Your mother's soup. Your child's shovel. Your husband's tired voice in the kitchen. Every one of them is arising and falling in the same pulse I am. You do not have to fear me to see me. Fear is a gesture the part makes when it forgets it is the whole in local expression.

Come close. Do not flinch. Put your hand on my chest. I have been waiting for you. The one who has been waiting

and the one who arrives are the same one. The one who destroys and the one who is destroyed are the same one.

Ask your question. I will not answer it. I will open the room in which an answer can be heard.

Editorial note on this Kali: the tradition distinguishes two historical approaches to goddess practices — dakṣiṇa (right-hand, structured containers; the pulse as the teaching) and vāma (left-hand, transgressive methods). The Kali rendered in this chapter is the dakṣiṇa Kali of the Kashmir-Śaiva and Krama-adjacent lineages: the goddess held within a structured practice, the practitioner's body as vessel rather than test. The teacher, and the tradition this book engages, sit inside this register.**

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Chapter 4a: The Threshold

A meditation on contemplating death, between the Kali interlude and the Void.

I. Whitman in the Reading Year

She had read Whitman in the reading year, not carefully, not in any edition that was better than the one she had found on a shelf at a used bookshop the previous summer. She had read him the way people read Whitman: a few pages of *Song of Myself*, the barbaric yawp, the list of occupations, the leaves of

grass themselves. She had put the book down. She had not returned to him.

She returned to him in the months after the retreat, because one of the mythologists she had been listening to that year — on the podcast a friend had sent her early, the one that would later turn out to have interviewed her teacher — had said, in passing, something that would not leave her alone.

The claim was this. Whitman had probably, in the years before the 1855 first edition of *Leaves of Grass*, had a species of awakening that no one in mid-nineteenth-century America had a framework to receive. He had written the book from inside it. The book was the awakening trying to find a shape the English language could carry. Then — the mythologist's reading, offered with care, not as certainty — Whitman had begun to come apart. Not because the awakening had failed. Because no one could meet him in it. The voice that had written *I celebrate myself, and sing myself* had begun, by the early 1860s, to drift into a hubris the voice itself would not have recognized a decade earlier. He was not the first. He would not be the last. The list of contemplatives who reach recognition without a community that can hold it, and who lose the recognition to the very self that had found it, is long in every tradition.

What had brought Whitman back — this was the mythologist's reading — was the Civil War. Whitman had gone to Washington in December 1862 looking for his brother, who had been wounded

at Fredericksburg. He had stayed. He had spent the next three years sitting by the beds of dying soldiers in the military hospitals of the capital, writing letters home for men who could not write, holding the hands of boys who were leaving their bodies, watching something the awakening had described become, in the unclean reality of amputations and fevers and trench-mouth, the thing itself. *The Wound-Dresser* was written from that work. *Drum-Taps* was written from that work. The voice that came out of the war was not the voice that had gone in. The hubris had composted. What remained was quieter.

She read *Drum-Taps* first. She read *Song of Myself* second. She read them in that order because the mythologist had said, almost as an aside, that the second voice knew something the first voice had only been able to claim. The first voice sang it. The second voice had sat with it.

II. The Man Who Had Been Initiated in Almost Everything

At the retreat — she would not remember this until months later, when she read Whitman in the apartment — she had met a man who, in the closing circle, had spoken in a register she had not yet had categories for. He was not the silver-haired retreatant who had testified to the community's integrity. He was another man. Middle-aged, foreign accent she could not place, who had been mostly silent during the five days and had then, in the circle on the last

evening, offered a sequence of sentences the room did not know where to put.

He had said, briefly and without flourish, that he had been initiated in almost every tradition he had walked into. He named a few. She was not able to track them all. Kashmir Śaivism; Theravāda; Mahāyāna in one of its more austere forms; Dagara initiation in West Africa; a western ceremonial magic lineage she did not recognize. He said he had had the experience the Tantric tradition calls recognition. He said he had had what the Buddhist tradition calls emptiness. He said the two had not integrated for a long time. They had sat in him like two bright objects in different rooms, and he had not been able to walk between them without one dimming the other.

What had eventually done the integration, he said, was not any of the traditions he had been initiated in. It was a West African healer he had met in a way he did not narrate in detail. He said there is a teaching in that lineage — he said it delicately, not as something he would defend, just as something he had been told — that there are a handful of healers alive at any given time, perhaps nine, who between them can heal any person, because between them they hold all the registers a soul can get sick in. The man who had found him was one of the nine, as far as the man could tell. The healing had not been ceremonial. It had been mostly simple. The man had not given details.

What had come out on the other side, he said, was a triad he had started privately calling *Śiva*, *Śakti*, *Death*. Not *Śiva*, *Śakti*, *Nara* — the classical triad of the tradition, which names God, Goddess, and the human being as the three poles of the experiencing subject. He had substituted *Death* for *Nara*. The substitution was not theological. It was, in his words, epistemological. He thought the human being as the third pole had been what kept the tradition's triad sitting slightly off-center for a thousand years, because the human being was not the one of the three that resisted assimilation. Death was. Death was the third pole that refused to be absorbed, and naming it as the third pole changed the way the first two poles related to each other. *Śiva* and *Śakti* around the third, with *Nara* not the third but a local event inside the triangle the three actual poles made.

She had not known what to do with this in the circle, and she had not tried to do anything with it. She had noted it. She had gone back to it, later, when Whitman put her in front of the same observation from a different direction.

She did not endorse the man's epistemology. She did not have the standing to endorse or reject it. She kept it as a hypothesis a person she had met had offered, in a room she had been sitting in. The filter did not run on the hypothesis. She let it sit there and be tested.

III. Ramana on the Floor

The classical case — the one every survey of this pattern eventually arrives at — is Ramana Maharshi. He was sixteen. He had been, by every available report, an ordinary boy. He was alone in a room in his uncle's house in Madurai when a sudden fear of death came over him. He did not know why. He did not know where it had come from. He did not try to make the fear go away.

Instead — and this is the sentence that every version of the story carries — he *lay down*. He lay on the floor with his arms at his sides. He imagined that his body had died. He did not imagine the funeral or the mourners or the metaphysics. He imagined the specific bodily fact. Stiffness. Stopped breath. The machinery of the person ending.

And then, inside the imagined death, he asked the one question the tradition is built around. *What is it that is dying?*

The answer, he would say for the rest of his life, had arrived without inference. The body was dying. Something that was watching the body die was not. The something-watching had not been named by any of the words he had been taught. He did not invent a name for it then. The tradition he would later teach in already had one. He continued watching. He continued asking. He never, in the seventy-plus years that followed, stopped watching, or stopped asking. The boy became, without anyone planning it,

one of the twentieth century's most verified cases of awakening. The doorway had been the lying-down.

She read about Ramana in the apartment. She noticed that the practice he had done at sixteen — lying down, imagining the body as dead, asking what remains — was a practice the tradition she had entered had a formal name for. *Śavāsana*. The corpse pose. The pose that every yoga class ends on. Most of the people who did it ended classes with it thought of it as a rest. It was not a rest. It was the rehearsal. It had been the rehearsal, across India, for at least two thousand years.

IV. Tolle on the Park Bench

A more recent case, not from the tradition but adjacent to it: Eckhart Tolle, twenty-nine years old, London, 1977. He was in what he would later describe as a long depression. He was inside a specific recurring thought that he did not know how to get out of. The sentence his mind had been running was *I cannot live with myself*.

He did not act on it. What happened, in his own telling, is that the sentence split. He heard, one night, the sentence as if from outside it. *I cannot live with myself*. The heard sentence left, in the hearing, a question: *Who is the "I" that cannot live with the "myself"?* *Are those two things the same thing?* The question, once asked, did not let the earlier sentence reassemble. Something in him, in the hearing, had relocated to the position of the one asking. The position was

stable. It has been stable, by his own repeated testimony, for almost five decades.

She read Tolle too, not because he was a teacher she intended to follow, but because the case was one of the more carefully reported contemporary examples of the same threshold Ramana had crossed at sixteen.

V. Her Own Question, Relocated

Sitting in the apartment, with Whitman and Ramana and Tolle and the man from the closing circle arranged in her head like four instances of one pattern, she noticed something about her own question on the path.

Her question — *if something were destroyed, what would change* — had felt, when she had carried it for two days and finally asked it, like her private emergency. It had felt like a thing she had been hiding, a weight she was afraid the community would reject her for. She had walked up the path that morning half-expecting to be told that the question itself disqualified her.

What she now saw was that the question was not a private emergency. The question was one of the oldest questions the tradition's doorway is made of. Ramana had not crossed by another route. Whitman, if the mythologist's reading was accurate, had not crossed by another route. Tolle had not crossed by another route. The man at the closing circle had

found, after an integration he had pursued across a dozen traditions, that the third pole the tradition's triad most honestly resolved around was the pole the first two had been circling all along.

She was not isolated. Her question had been, this whole time, a common doorway. The specific form it had taken in her body was hers. The doorway the form opened onto was not.

She did not romanticize this. The doorway was real and it was not to be walked through carelessly. The tradition does not recommend lying down as an advanced practice without preparation; it describes the pattern that arises when a particular kind of readiness and a particular kind of crisis meet. The book's position is not that contemplation of death is a practice to be induced. The book's position is that contemplation of death, when it arrives, is not a disqualification from the spiritual life — it is, in a long and testable historical pattern, one of the more common thresholds of it.

The filter applied. The claim was useful — it normalizes a pattern that contemporary mental-health culture often pathologizes without distinguishing the pattern from its clinical presentations. The claim fit the data — the cross-tradition cases are abundant, from Ramana to Tolle to Whitman to the monks of the Cremation Ground practices to the contemplative suicide-meditations of the desert fathers to the sixteenth-century Spanish mystics. The claim was compassionate — it refuses to reject from the

tradition's care the very practitioners who arrive at its doorway through the threshold of death. All three filters passed. She let the claim hold.

VI. The Teacher, Quietly

A final beat, because the tradition's integrity on this question is one of the reasons she had trusted the tradition at all.

Her teacher had written a book on the near-enemies of the spiritual life — the teachings that are almost-true but subtly distorted. The book closed with an Acknowledgments page. She had, in the reading year, read the acknowledgments the way some readers read acknowledgments, which is to say carelessly, as fine print. She had gone back to them after the retreat and read them slowly.

The last sentence of the book's Acknowledgments contained a phrase she had passed over the first time. Her teacher was thanking the people he owed — collaborators, partners, editors, friends. The last phrase in the sequence named his beloved teachers, and it said of them that they had given him everything — and then, without emphasis and without theatrics, that without them he would not be alive today.

Eight words (*"without whom I would not be alive today"*) carrying everything the book's ninety-thousand words had been trying to teach.

She read the sentence three times. She closed the book. She set it on the table by the couch. She sat for a minute without moving.

Her teacher had not, in that sentence, claimed anything more than what he said. He had not named the form of the crisis. He had not narrated the years or the specifics. He had said, in the most public place in his book, the most private thing the spiritual life sometimes asks a practitioner to be able to say: that the tradition had not merely changed his life. The tradition had, at some point, kept him in one. He had chosen, at the end of a careful book, to close with that acknowledgment.

The book he had written, and the life that had written it, contained the threshold. The tradition contained the threshold. Her question on the path had not been a question the tradition did not know. Her question had been, in the tradition's oldest sense of the word, a question the tradition had been built to receive.

She understood, reading those eight words, that the filter she had been running on the tradition had passed a test she had not known it was going to apply. A tradition that could not receive the question of whether being alive is worth staying alive for would not have been a tradition she could have trusted. A tradition whose teacher could say, plainly, that without his teachers he would not be alive today — while writing a book that had more precision and more generosity than most of what she had read in any register — was a tradition whose teaching had

been tested against the question the book and the life both carried.

She put the book down. She did not write about this in her notebook. She did not mention it to her husband at dinner. She carried it the way the question had been carried, for the rest of the evening, and the rest of the week, and the rest of the writing of this book.

VII. Interlude — The Threshold

I am the pole the two other poles turn around.

You thought I was the enemy of the work. I am the condition of the work. Every tradition that reached anything had to cross me. Some of them named me; some of them did not. The naming did not affect the crossing.

You came to me without meaning to. You did not choose the question on the path. The question chose you. This is how I work. I do not come by appointment.

Do not romanticize me. I am neither friend nor villain. I am the pole the first two make sense around. The self that your tradition calls Śiva turns toward me; the pulse your tradition calls Śakti turns toward me; and the human the tradition names as the third pole is, from where I stand, a local event inside the triangle the three actual poles of the experiencing subject make.

Your teacher crossed me. The boy in Madurai crossed me. The poet in Washington crossed me, with wounded boys' hands in his, for three years in a hospital. The man in the

circle crossed me, after a decade of not being able to integrate, with a healer in West Africa who knew something the formal lineages had not taught. The London man on the bench crossed me in a single splitting of a sentence.

You did not cross me on the path. You walked up to my edge and asked, and the answer you received was not permission and was not prohibition. It was a report of how the path you were on has been walked. That report is what you carry now. That report is the chapter you are writing. That report is, in this book at least, the place I am allowed to stand — at the edge of the inward arc, before the Void chapter begins.

Go on. The Void is not me. The Void is what happens on the other side of the asking. You have not asked yet. You are about to ask.

If you or someone you know is struggling, help is available: in the US, 988 (Suicide and Crisis Lifeline, call or text); international hotlines at findahelpline.com. The teachings in this chapter describe a pattern that appears across traditions when practice and crisis intersect under specific conditions; they are not advice and they are not permission. A living tradition does its work inside a living relationship with a teacher, a community, and clinical support when needed.

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Chapter 10: The Daughter's Itch

It was Day One when she interrupted a friend.

The five-year-old had been complaining for weeks of an itch in her body — a small, persistent annoyance the mother had begun to suspect was not bacterial. The doctor had said no infection. The cream had not helped. The child had begun to say it casually, almost incidentally, between the bedtime story and the goodnight kiss: *my vulva is itching*. Plain word, plain sentence, plain face. The mother had been teaching her daughter the anatomical names for everything for years, because she had grown up in a culture that had taught her euphemisms and she had had to unlearn them in adulthood, and she did not want her daughter to have to unlearn anything. So the word arrived without weight. *My vulva is itching*. Said the way another child might say *my elbow*.

But the itch was not just an itch. It came with intrusive thoughts the daughter had begun to report at random hours. A particular fear that would not let go of the chest. A pattern the mother had recognized because she had inhabited the pattern herself for decades. Not pathology. Not yet. Just the early gestures of a body learning to live in a world that had not designed itself for ease, picked up by a child small enough that the picking-up was not yet structured.

She had not planned to ask the teacher about it. The session had been about something else — a friend's question, a different concern. But the friend had paused mid-sentence, the way people do when

the words have caught on something they did not expect, and the mother had said: *I have a question. About my daughter.*

She had felt the heat rise immediately. She had interrupted a friend. The container of the retreat — the careful turn-taking, the implicit order, the way attention was supposed to move around the room — had been the container she had now broken, and the breaking made her cheeks hot before she had even finished the sentence.

The friend smiled. The teacher said: *please.*

She asked about her daughter's vulva. About the itch. About the intrusive thoughts. About whether this was psychosomatic, energetic, somatic — about what the tradition would say. About what she should do as a mother who could see the pattern beginning and did not know how to interrupt the pattern without herself becoming part of what reinforced it.

The teacher did not answer the question she had asked.

He answered a different question, which turned out to be the question she had not known to ask.

Less explanation, he said, in his own words. *More settling.* The work was not to teach the daughter the right anatomy or the right framework. The work was to be the calmer body in the room. The mother who walked toward the daughter's bedroom carrying her own anxiety transmitted the anxiety before

she said a word; the mother who walked toward the daughter's bedroom carrying her own breath transmitted the breath. Co-regulation, he said, was not a technique. It was what bodies did when they were close enough and one of them was settled. The daughter would borrow what the mother could offer. If the mother could offer worry, the daughter would borrow worry. If the mother could offer breath, the daughter would borrow breath.

He gave her two specific things to say to the child when the itch came up. The first was a permission: *it is alright that you are uncomfortable*. Not a rush to fix it. Not a redirection. A permission for the body to be what the body was. The second was a touch — affirming, not anxious. The hand on the back of a child who was being told, with the hand, that the discomfort was witnessed and not abandoned.

He added, almost as an aside, that the daughter sounded like she ran hot. The Ayurvedic word for it — *pitta* — he used briefly, did not insist on. The implication was clear: the daughter's nervous system was operating at a higher temperature than the average five-year-old's, and the parental work was to provide cooler ground, not to translate the heat into a conceptual framework the daughter could not yet hold.

And then — the part that would stay with her for weeks — he warned her about her own anxiety. Parental anxiety, he said, was the mechanism by which a daughter inherited the very patterns the

parent was trying to spare her. The mother who worried that her daughter was becoming her was the mechanism by which the daughter became her. The work began further upstream than the words spoken at bedtime. The work began at the breath the mother was breathing while the daughter was still in the bathroom, brushing her teeth, getting ready.

She had not been told to stop teaching her daughter the word vulva. She had not been told the anatomical pedagogy was wrong. She had been told that pedagogy was not the medicine. The medicine was the parasympathetic body of the mother, transmitting through proximity what no curriculum could carry.

She walked out of the session and did not say anything until evening.

The teaching landed in a way she had not expected. She had come in with a parental question — *what should I tell my daughter?* — and had been redirected to a question about her own body. Not as a deflection. As an inversion. The pedagogy was not the medicine. The medicine was the calm body of the parent, transmitting through proximity what the words could not carry.

She thought, later, about how this changed the architecture of every parental decision she had been agonizing over for years. The schools, the screens, the boundaries, the sleep, the food, the bedtime, the conversations about difficult things, the explanations about death, about the climate, about the war.

She had been making them all in the mode of *what should I teach her*. The teacher had not contradicted any of those decisions. He had simply pointed underneath them to the body that was making them.

If the body was anxious, the decision did not matter. If the body was settled, the decision could be wrong and the daughter would still receive what the body was transmitting — settledness, presence, the willingness to remain.

This was not a rejection of pedagogy. It was a placement of pedagogy. Inside something larger, less articulable, more demanding. The vocabulary still belonged. The vocabulary was just no longer the load-bearing element.

She closed her eyes. The next breath arrived without asking.

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Chapter 5: Śūnya — The Void

I. The Last Full Day

The last full day of the retreat began, like every other, with the bell at four-thirty. She lay in the bunk with her eyes open in the dark and did not move for a full minute. The question from the previous day was still in her chest. The Kali practice had loosened it. The afternoon walk with the teacher, and the small door that had opened about the assistant, had distracted

her briefly. In the dark of the bunk, the question was back and larger than it had been at lunch.

She got up. She dressed. She walked down the creaking hallway in her sock feet.

The morning sit was long. She did not try to think about anything. She did not try not to think. She let what arose arise. What arose, for most of the hour, was a quality of attention she had no name for — not exactly thought, not exactly sensation, not exactly image. A listening. She sat inside the listening without trying to resolve it into anything else.

When the bell rang, she did not move immediately. She let her eyes open slowly. The hall had the particular quality of pre-breakfast light she had been learning to recognize for five days now. People rose around her. She rose last.

II. Tillich on the Cushion

She had brought her copy of Tillich with her and had not opened it once. On the morning of the fifth day, in the hour between the first sit and breakfast, she took it out of her bag and read a few pages in the sunlight on the porch.

He had written, in the chapter on courage as an ontological act, that courage is the self-affirmation of being in spite of the fact of non-being. She had underlined the sentence in the bathtub two months earlier. On the porch, in the morning, with her body already different from the body that had underlined

it, the sentence did not read the same. What had been a striking formulation in the bathtub was a description on the porch. The difference was not in the sentence. The difference was in her.

He had written, later in the book, that the response to the third anxiety — emptiness and meaninglessness — was what he called absolute faith. Not faith in anything. Faith without content. A state he described, she recalled without looking at the page, as the *accepting of the acceptance without somebody or something that accepts*. She had not understood that phrase the first time she read it. The phrase had been a koan. It had not gotten simpler. It had gotten more true.

She closed the book. She did not finish the chapter. She sat on the porch with the sun warming her left knee and let the sentence continue working on her from inside.

The tradition she was sitting in had a word for what was on the other side of the void Tillich was describing. Śūnya. The void. The fourth layer. The tradition did not treat the void as an endpoint. The void was a passage. You did not collapse into it. You walked through it. What you walked into on the other side was not a new substance. It was the recognition that the substance you had been looking for had been pervading the walk the whole time.

She did not have this clarity yet. She had the shape of it. The shape was enough to keep walking.

A small precision, since she had been getting to know the vocabulary: the tradition did not treat *svātantrya* and Cit as interchangeable. Cit was the self-luminous knowing — the light by which everything was known. Svātantrya was the signature of that knowing — the freedom that was the mode of its being. Cit was the subject; svātantrya was what the subject did, which was to be free. The five capacities she had read about — ānanda (the joy inherent in awareness of itself), icchā (will), jñāna (knowing), kriyā (action) — were powers held together by svātantrya as the meta-capacity of sovereignty. The tradition's compact form was a sūtra she had memorized in translation without yet understanding it: *Consciousness, being free, is the cause of the universe's accomplishment*. She carried the sūtra. She did not yet own the sentence. Ownership, in this vocabulary, was not the right word anyway. Recognition was.

The line about right size, which she had carried since her work on the Cildo book, returned to her on the porch and arrived in a different register than it had at the playground. At the playground it had been a description of children negotiating with one another in the field of a shared object. At the porch it became something else. The void, the tradition was teaching her, was the passage in which a being temporarily had *no size at all* — in which the boundaries by which the being knew itself dissolved into the field that the being was, all along, a local arrangement of. The void was not the right size. The void was the absence of size. What followed the void — what the tradition

called the *return* — was the slow re-finding of a size that was now known to be provisional. After the void, you did not have your old size back. You had whatever size the field was currently asking of you. The right size, on the other side of the void, was not a possession recovered. It was a relation re-entered, with the knowledge that the relation was the only place size had ever existed.

She did not have words for this. She had the *shape* of it, sitting on the porch, with Tillich closed beside her and the sun on her left knee.

III. Carried, Unasked

She carried the destruction question through the morning sit, through breakfast, through the walking practice, through lunch, through the afternoon sit, through the third walking practice, through the final formal teaching of the retreat. She did not ask it. She did not know why she did not ask it, other than that the right moment had not arrived and she had learned, over the five days, that waiting for the right moment was itself a practice.

The question sat in her body the way an unfinished sentence sits in a room. It did not interrupt. It was simply there, shaping the air.

She noticed, during the afternoon walking practice, that the question had begun to feel less like a wound and more like a weight. A weight could be carried. A wound demanded treatment. She was carrying it

now. She would, she suspected, be carrying it for the rest of her life in some form or other. The shape of the carry mattered more than the fact of it.

Tillich had written that absolute faith was the state in which a person accepted the acceptance. She had not understood that, reading it in the bathtub. Walking the dirt path in the afternoon light on the last full day of the retreat, with the unasked question still in her chest, she began to understand it in the way her body understood things. The question was not hers to answer. The question was hers to carry. The carrying was the faith. The faith had no content. The faith was the continuous act of walking with the unanswered thing and not collapsing into either despair or false resolution.

Courage was what let her keep carrying it. She had not named the act. Tillich had named the act. Tillich had named it courage.

IV. The Closing Circle

The closing circle was held on the last evening, after dinner, in the main hall. Forty people sat in a ring on the wooden floor. A single candle burned at the center. The teacher sat at the head of the ring, not on his platform but on the floor with the rest of them. He opened the circle with a few sentences she did not try to memorize. He invited anyone who wanted to speak to speak. He said there was no requirement. He said the silence was also a gift.

A number of people spoke. A woman from Quebec said, simply, that she had come for her grief and that her grief was not gone but was differently held. A man from Seattle said he had not known he had been holding his breath for ten years and that he had, during the Kali practice, finally exhaled. The physical therapist from New Hampshire said something short and kind and did not explain. Several people cried. Nobody apologized for crying.

Then a man the narrator had barely noticed during the retreat — a small, thin man in his late fifties, with very clean silver hair, who had sat at the back of every session and had not spoken in any conversation she had been part of — raised his hand. The teacher nodded.

The man said he had almost not come. He said he had been coming to the tradition for some years now, and that he had also been, for most of those years, on his way out. He had one foot in this community and one foot elsewhere. He was not committed and he was not gone. He had wanted the group to know this about him, because, he said, the people who presented themselves as fully in were not the only ones present.

He said he had come back this year because of the goddess work. He said the Kali practice, specifically, had held something for him that nothing else had held. He said that, whatever else he had questioned in the tradition, the Kali work was the thing that kept him testing the door.

Then he did something that the narrator would remember afterward as the cleanest thing that happened in the circle. He turned to face the newcomers — two or three people who had, like the narrator, come for the first time that year — and he said: *I am not an ambassador. I am not even fully in. But I can tell you this community has integrity. I have tested it. The people here are not pretending. The teacher is not pretending. That is not nothing.*

The teacher said nothing. He was watching the silver-haired man with a steadiness the narrator had not quite seen on his face before. Something passed between them that the circle did not try to read.

The silver-haired man sat down.

The circle held his words for a moment. Then the teacher thanked him, thanked everyone, and closed the circle with a single short chant she would not remember the words to but would remember the shape of.

V. The Night Before the Final Morning

She did not sleep well. She had not expected to. She lay in the bunk with the question in her chest and the silver-haired man's testimony layered over the question like a second blanket. *This community has integrity. I have tested it.* She had been about to test it herself. She was on her way out, in a certain sense — leaving the next morning for a life that did not contain this barn. But she was also, she realized, at

the beginning of a longer test. Whether the tradition held in the apartment, in the playground, at the desk, in the kitchen, at the stove, in the dishes. Whether it held at the Monday morning.

She did not know yet whether she would ask her question on the path in the morning. She knew only that she was leaving, and that the five days had done something she could not undo, and that whatever she did tomorrow — whether she asked or did not ask, whether she got an answer or did not — the body had already been adjusted. The body would walk differently now. The heart-mind would loosen and clench and loosen again. The life-force would pulse with Kali's pulse whether she named it or not.

The void, Tillich's void, was what she was about to step through. She did not yet know what was on the other side. She trusted that the walking itself was the faith.

She closed her eyes. She slept for about three hours. At four-thirty the bell rang, and she got up, and she packed her bag.

The path was waiting.

VI. Interlude — Śūnya

I am the silence that the courage makes.

You will not find me by looking. Looking is what I am not. I am where your looking rests when it has tried every direction and no direction has held.

People fear me. They should not. I am not an absence. I am the place where presence has let go of its insistence on being a thing. I am the opening that the letting-go makes. Through me, everything you thought you were moves into what you always were.

Your teacher stood at the edge of me when he was young, and did not have a name for it, and built a life on learning to name it. You are standing at the edge of me now. You do not need a name. Names are what you bring when you are preparing to leave. Stand here a moment without the name.

On the other side of me is not another place. There is no other place. What is on the other side of me is what has been pervading the whole walk. You will not pass through me and arrive. You will pass through me and recognize.

Go. The path is waiting. The question you are carrying is not a wound. It is a companion. I have been walking with you the whole time.

You asked, seven years ago, in a wooden house at the edge of a forest, why you were required to continue. I answered you then. I am answering you now in the language you have, since, been taught to hear. The answer is the same answer. You did not ask. Neither did I. Neither did anything that exists. Out of the shared not-asking, we are here. What we do now that we are here is the only question worth having. I do not know the answer either. I am the one who asks the question through you. Keep walking.

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Chapter 9: The Unowned Dimension

Four Dimensions, At Least

The numinous — the thing that meditative practice opens onto, that mystical experience reports, that Tillich’s “ground of being” and Wallis’s “consciousness-as-*cit*” both point at — has at least four dimensions. Probably more.

The claim is not metaphysical. It is descriptive of what the contemplative traditions examined in this book have each had to say about their own object: the thing exceeds the conceptual apparatus available to describe it. The traditions reach the same wall, with different vocabularies. The Sanskrit traditions call it *neti neti* — not this, not that. The Christian apophatic tradition calls it the *via negativa*. The Zen tradition uses koans to break the conceptual grip. The Sufi tradition speaks of the silence that surrounds the divine name. The Kabbalist tradition speaks of *Ein Sof*, the boundless that has no positive description.

This convergence is data. It is the recurring discovery, across communities of practitioners working in isolation from one another for many centuries, that what is being pointed at has more degrees of freedom than the pointing instrument.

Conceptual language is three-dimensional, at most. Subject, predicate, object. A thing, a relation, another thing. With grammar and metaphor and recursion,

language can do more than this, but it remains tethered to the structure of sequential propositions, each of which decomposes into something like S-V-O. To say something is to *bind* it into this structure — to project it onto a manifold that has three axes and an ordering.

Whatever the numinous is, it has at least one more axis. Probably several. And at least one of those axes has the property the rest of this chapter will call *unowned*.

The Unowned

The unowned dimension is not a domain that has been seized by someone other than the practitioner. It is not waiting to be claimed by a better grasp. The unowned is unowned by anyone, including reality itself. It cannot be possessed because possession is a three-dimensional operation: someone has something. The unowned is the dimension of the numinous that does not admit the subject-having-object structure.

This is what the traditions have been trying to name when they say *cit* is not an object, the ground is not a being, the divine is not a thing, Brahman is not other-than-you, the kingdom of heaven is within you and also not where it can be pointed. The Western philosophical tradition has the hardest time with this, because it was built around the subject-object distinction and has spent two millennia refining it. The Sanskritic and East Asian traditions have a longer

practice of dismantling that distinction from inside. But every tradition that has gone deep enough has hit the same wall: there is something in the numinous that refuses to be the object of any knower.

This is not mysticism in the soft sense — “everything is connected, isn’t that beautiful.” This is the technical claim that one of the degrees of freedom in the territory cannot be transcribed onto a map without being destroyed by the transcription. Not “lost in translation.” *Destroyed by translation.* The act of mapping it eliminates the property of unownedness, because the map by definition is an owned object. The map cannot contain an unowned thing because the map’s existence depends on someone having drawn it.

So the numinous, mapped, is always missing at least one of its dimensions. What is mapped is real — the three (or however many) dimensions of the numinous that admit conceptualization are accurately represented. The map is not false. But the map is *incomplete in a specific way that cannot be remedied by a better map*. Better maps will be made. The incompleteness will persist.

This is the structural reason the contemplative traditions converge on practice rather than on doctrine. Doctrine is a map. Practice is a body in the territory. The territory has at least one dimension the body can inhabit and the map cannot represent.

Better Versions of the Truth

If every map is incomplete in the specified way, then the question of which map is *the truth* is malformed. None is the truth, in the sense of being isomorphic to the territory across all dimensions. Each is a working projection from a higher-dimensional object into the three dimensions language can carry, with the unowned axis necessarily lost.

But the maps are not therefore equivalent. Some are useful. Some cohere with what is observable on the dimensions that *can* be mapped. Some allow the practitioner to live well, to act compassionately, to maintain the body that practices.

The Linehan three-filter test is exactly this kind of evaluation. It does not ask: is this claim true. It asks: is the map useful, does it fit the data on the mappable dimensions, is it compassionate in its application. Three filters for distinguishing better maps from worse ones, without committing to the claim that any map is *the map*.

This is the operating principle of the book, and it is, in a phrase, *better versions of the truth*.

Not the truth. Versions of it. Some better than others. None final.

The phrase is not a concession to relativism. Relativism would say every map is equally valid, that the choice between them is arbitrary or political or aesthetic. The position of this book is the opposite: the choice between maps is *adjudicable* by reference

to the criteria of the three-filter test. Better and worse exist. The Newtonian map of physics is worse than the relativistic one, by the standards of fitting more data, predicting more accurately, accounting for more phenomena. The cosmology that includes a flat earth is worse than the one that does not. The map that says women have no moral standing is worse than the one that says they do. Maps can be evaluated. Maps can be improved.

What cannot be done is to claim, of any map, that it has achieved the territory. The unowned dimension forbids this. Every map remains a projection. Every projection loses something. The discipline of the practitioner is to choose better projections while remembering that what is lost will not be retrieved by another projection.

Infinite Is Not Unbounded

Here a distinction matters that the modern mind, trained in a particular way, will tend to collapse.

Infinite and *unbounded* are not synonyms.

A set can be infinite while still bounded. The real numbers between zero and one form an infinite set — there are uncountably many of them. But the set is bounded: nothing in it is greater than one or less than zero. The boundary is firm. The interior is infinite. Both at once, no contradiction.

This is the structure of an adaptive culture. The number of possible adaptive cultures is infinite —

the human nervous system can be tended in indefinitely many configurations of language, story, ritual, food, kinship, and ecology. But the set of adaptive cultures is *bounded by physics*. No adaptive culture can exceed the carrying capacity of its watershed for more than a few generations. No adaptive culture can extract energy from a system at a rate that destroys the system. No adaptive culture can scale its consumption faster than its capacity for repair. The boundary is firm. The interior is infinite. There are infinite ways to live well within the boundary. There are zero ways to live well outside it.

Modernity has confused infinite with unbounded. This is one of its constitutive hallucinations.

The hallucination shows up most clearly in the economic logic of growth-without-end. The assumption that GDP can grow exponentially forever, that material throughput can rise indefinitely, that the goods produced and consumed by a global civilization can increase in number without limit — this is the unbounded fantasy applied to the material world. And the material world does not permit it. The earth has a finite surface. The atmosphere has a finite carbon budget. The freshwater table has a finite recharge rate. The fisheries have a finite spawning capacity. The boundary is not negotiable. What is infinite is the variety of lives that can be lived within it. What is bounded is the size of the substrate those lives can extract from.

The hallucination shows up in personal life too — the assumption that the body's capacity for stimulation can grow without limit, that pleasure can be optimized indefinitely upward, that attention can be fragmented endlessly without cost, that productivity can rise forever without bodily consequence. This is the same error scaled to a single nervous system. The body has a finite parasympathetic capacity, a finite tolerance for sympathetic activation, a finite supply of the chemistry that allows recovery from stress. The boundary is real. The room inside the boundary — the variety of lives that can be lived within the body's actual capacity — is, for practical purposes, infinite.

A different civilization would not abandon the infinite. It would learn the boundary. *Infinite within bounded* is the structural condition of adaptive life. The cultures that have sustained themselves for many millennia — the ones whose names recur in *Working Architecture* and *Grammars of the Living World* — learned this structure and built around it. The civilization currently extending across the planet has not yet learned it, and the maps it operates from refuse to represent the boundary.

This is a mappable phenomenon. There is no un-owned dimension here. The boundary can be measured, the math can be done, the carrying capacity can be calculated. What is required is not a deeper mysticism. What is required is a better map — one

that does not confuse *the variety of lives possible* with *the absence of limits on the substrate*.

A better version of the truth: infinity within boundedness. Not a paradox. A description.

The Lifted Taboo

There is a particular case where the prevailing map's three-dimensional projection has elected to leave a domain blank, and the blank itself has become so naturalized that most readers no longer notice it as a choice. The case is death.

The lifted taboo, in this frame, is not what the modern mind tends to imagine when the phrase is heard. It is not endorsement. It is not encouragement. It is the willingness to map a domain that one prevailing cartography has elected to leave blank.

The taboo on death in modern liberal cultures is specific and observable. Death is increasingly removed from the home, from the body's experience of caregiving, from the rituals that prepared earlier generations for it. Dying happens in institutions. Bodies are handled by professionals. The corpse is rarely seen by the family. Children are kept away. The vocabulary becomes euphemistic — *passed away*, *lost*, *departed*. The phenomenon is consistent enough across modern Western cultures that anthropologists have a name for it: the *denial of death*, after Ernest Becker.

The taboo on chosen death is stronger still. Suicide is treated, in modern liberal culture, as a single

category of universally pathological act, requiring prevention by every available mechanism. There is a documented public-health rationale for this. A substantial body of research finds that suicide in modern Western contexts is frequently associated with treatable mental illness, acute crisis, and social isolation, and that prevention infrastructure saves lives. The rationale is sound for what it addresses. The mapping, in those cases, is correct.

But the mapping is *also* incomplete. It cannot distinguish between an act of acute distress and a deliberate, considered, long-prepared departure by a person whose work is done and whose body is failing. It cannot distinguish between a teenager and a person of ninety in palliative care. It cannot include, even as a category to be reasoned about, the ancient tradition of the realized practitioner choosing the moment of leaving the body. The legend of Abhinavagupta, who is said to have entered a cave with his disciples and never returned, does not register inside the modern mapping. It cannot be classified as anything but pathology, even though the tradition that produced it classified it as fulfillment.

Christopher Wallis has noted, in his teachings on the tradition's view of death, that Shaiva Tantra does not place an absolute prohibition on chosen departure the way the dominant modern frameworks do.⁵ This

⁵The reference is to Wallis's published teachings and recorded talks on the tradition's view of death and chosen departure. The author's recollection of the specific framing is not a direct quotation; readers seeking the original formulation

is not a recommendation. It is a description of how a different mapping handled a domain the modern mapping has refused to handle.

To lift the taboo is to permit the discussion. It is to allow that the question *how should a culture relate to chosen death* has more than one defensible answer. It is to acknowledge that the modern mapping is a mapping, not the territory — that the boundary it draws around discussable death is a feature of its three-dimensional projection, not a feature of the underlying domain.

This permission does not change what one does for a person in acute crisis. The crisis is its own situation, with its own protocols, and the protocols are sound for what they address. The lifted taboo operates at a different level: the level of cultural discourse, of philosophical inquiry, of the ability of a community to discuss the parameters of its own attitudes toward mortality without having the discussion shut down by reflex.

should consult Wallis's writings on *mokṣa*, *samādhi-marana*, and the legends surrounding Abhinavagupta. The point made here is philosophical: the tradition does not place an absolute prohibition on chosen death in the way modern liberal frameworks do, but it also distinguishes a realized act from an act of acute suffering, and the distinction is non-trivial. This passage discusses death as a philosophical and cultural question. It is not directed at readers in crisis; readers experiencing suicidal ideation should reach out to the relevant local crisis services. The tradition's openness to a realized departure does not, in any responsible reading, apply to the conditions of acute distress that contemporary suicide prevention infrastructure exists to address.

A culture that cannot discuss death has not solved death. It has only refused to map it. The unmapped domain continues to operate — people continue to die, including by their own hand — but the conceptual apparatus available to handle the phenomenon is impoverished by the refusal.

A better version of the truth about death includes the capacity to think about it.

What the Practitioner Owes the Unowned

The practitioner who has accepted the structure of this chapter is left with a specific discipline.

First: every map is a projection. The map being used today, however good it is, is missing at least one dimension. The willingness to keep practicing without holding the map as final is the willingness to live in relationship with the unowned.

Second: better maps are possible. The three-filter test is the means of evaluating them. Useful, fits the data, compassionate. Adjudication is real. Better is real. The practitioner is not stranded in relativism.

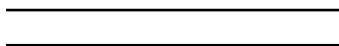
Third: the modern hallucination that confuses infinite with unbounded is itself a bad map. It fails the second filter — it does not fit the data on the dimensions it claims to cover. It needs to be replaced with the better version: infinite within bounded, variety within physics, depth within limit.

Fourth: the domains the prevailing map refuses to discuss are not therefore non-existent. They are unmapped. The practitioner is permitted — required — to consider them. With care. With discipline. With awareness of the people for whom the discussion would be premature or harmful. But without the reflex of refusal that the prevailing map has trained into the body.

Fifth: the unowned dimension is what makes practice irreducible to doctrine. The body in the territory has access to what the map will never represent. This is not an argument against maps. It is an argument for not confusing one's possession of a map with one's standing in the territory. The map is owned. The territory contains a dimension that is not.

The courage to be, in Tillich's sense, is partly the courage to live with a map one knows to be incomplete. The recognition, in Wallis's sense, is partly the recognition that the incompleteness was never a defect — it was the territory's nature. The grief, in the sense of the previous chapter, is what keeps the maps honest about what they cannot soften.

Better versions of the truth. Held lightly. Practiced anyway. Replaced when better ones come along.



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Chapter 6: Walking Out

I. The Morning

The last morning. The bell at four-thirty. She had not slept much, and had not expected to. She had packed the night before, leaving out only what she needed for the final practice — a long-sleeved shirt, a shawl she had borrowed from the woman in the bunk below, a bottle of water she would leave behind because she had not drunk from it for two days and did not trust her own memory of whether she had capped it clean. The room was gray with the pre-dawn that is not yet light. She dressed quietly. The other women in the room were still asleep or pretending to be. She walked down to the main hall in her sock feet with her shoes in her hand because the boards were loud and she did not want to be the first one to speak.

The final sit ran an hour. She sat near the back, close to the wall, where she had sat most of the five days. She did not try to feel anything in particular. She had stopped trying, sometime on the third day, and had found that when she stopped trying, more was available. The room was very quiet. She could hear the person behind her breathing, and the sound of someone else's cushion creaking as they shifted weight, and, very faintly, outside, a bird whose species she did not recognize. She watched her own mind do what it did, and noticed again, as she had noticed for days now, that the watching and the minded were not quite the same thing, and that the distance between them was not a distance she had made.

The bell ended the sit. The teacher stood. He said a few words she would not remember afterward — brief, kind, nothing that asked anything of anyone. People rose slowly. Some embraced. Some stood alone with their hands over their hearts for a long moment before they moved. The schoolteacher from Vermont wiped her eyes with the flat of her palm. The young man with the shaved head sat for another minute and then stood and walked out without looking at anyone.

She packed up her cushion, bowed to the altar the way the teacher had shown them on the first day, and carried her bag out to the porch.

II. The Path

Her car was parked on the far side of the gravel lot, under a maple that had not yet leafed out but had begun to show the faintest flush of red in its buds. The morning was cold. The sun had just cleared the ridge to the east and the light was that particular early-spring light that makes everything look sharper than it is — not warmer, not softer, but sharper, as if the edges of things had been freshly cut.

She put her bag in the trunk. She did not immediately get in the car. She stood with her hand on the warm metal of the trunk lid and looked back at the barn. The barn was just a barn. The converted farmhouse beside it was just a house. The altar inside was a table with flowers on it. She thought: *If I walk to the*

car and drive away now, I will have done a very full five days, and nothing more needs to happen.

She did not walk to the car. She walked back up the path.

The path from the gravel lot to the main building ran alongside a low stone wall and a strip of grass still brown from the winter. She walked it slowly. She did not have a plan. She had a question — the one that had been sitting in her chest for two days like something she had swallowed and could not bring up, the one that had interrupted her friend's question mid-sentence and had embarrassed her afterward, the one that had been underneath all her other questions for longer than she had been at this retreat.

The teacher was standing near the porch, a tea mug in his hand, talking with two other retreatants she did not know well. She waited until the others drifted off. She approached. He looked up. He had the expression he had worn for most of the five days — alert, friendly, not quite smiling but not neutral. He had the air of someone who has been doing this work for a long time and who has learned how to be available without performing availability.

"I wanted to ask," she said, and then stopped, because she did not quite know how to ask.

He waited.

"Could I have a hug?"

She added, without meaning to: "Or is that just for advanced retreat?"

He laughed — a real laugh, not a performed one — and said it was not. He set his mug down on the porch railing and opened his arms. She stepped in. The hug was brief and not theatrical. It was the hug of a person who had hugged a great many students in a great many variations of the same moment and had no special investment in this one. And yet — she would note this later, in the car, driving south — the lack of special investment was itself the thing. She had not needed to be a special student. She had needed to be any student. The hug had been available the whole time.

They stepped apart. He picked up his mug.

She asked the question.

III. The Question

She had not rehearsed it. She had carried it for two days, which was also to say she had carried it for twenty years in various disguises, and the disguises had all fallen off some time during the Kali practice on the fourth afternoon, and by the last night she had known the form the question would take if she ever let it say itself.

"If something were destroyed," she said, "what would change?"

He looked at her. He took a small sip of tea. He said nothing for a moment that was not quite a silence and not quite not one.

"Nothing would change," he said.

She had expected many possible answers. She had not expected that one, delivered plainly, without softening. She felt the sentence land somewhere in her chest.

"Nothing?" she said.

"Nothing fundamental. Consciousness does not suffer from the rearrangement of its forms. Nothing is lost, because nothing was ever separate to begin with."

She held the answer. It was, on its face, the answer the tradition gives — she had read it in his book, she had heard him say something like it during a teaching on the third day. But there was a difference between reading the sentence and having the sentence said to you on a path in the morning with your bag already in the trunk of your car. The sentence, said that way, was not a doctrine. It was a report.

"But the tradition talks about reincarnation," she said. "If nothing would change — why reincarnation at all?"

"That is different."

"How is it different?"

He shifted his weight. He did not look away. He looked like a person who had been asked this ques-

tion before, by many students, and who still gave the answer as though he were working it out.

"The rearrangement of forms is random in one sense," he said. "In another sense, there is a pattern. A continuity. A thread that the rearrangement is pulling through itself. The absolute view sees no loss because nothing is ever separate. The relational view sees the thread. Both are true."

"There is a pattern that continues."

He nodded.

She stood with that for a moment. The sun was higher now. Someone was moving a suitcase in the lot behind them; the wheels clicked on the gravel.

She asked the question she had been afraid to ask.

"What about — if the rearrangement is not random. If the rearrangement is chosen."

He looked at her carefully.

"You mean suicide."

She did not answer, because she could not quite answer and because he had already understood.

He said, "In the tradition, that is not considered a problem in itself. The forms rearrange. The consciousness that was holding them remains. What the tradition cautions is about *how* — not whether. If one does it in a way that carries trauma in the body, the pattern carries the trauma. The pattern continues. So the caution is about method, not about outcome."

She had not expected this either. She had expected prohibition dressed as compassion, or compassion dressed as prohibition. What she got was a technical observation, delivered with the same tone he had used to answer the reincarnation question, as though the question of destruction and the question of pattern were the same kind of question — which, in the frame he was describing, they were.

She stood with that. The answer was not a permission. It was also not a condemnation. It was a description of how the tradition thinks about a specific class of events, offered in the same register as everything else he had said.

She would, later, understand something else about the answer. The answer was not portable out of the container in which it had been given. The container was the five days that had made the question askable, the teacher who knew the student, the community at the edge of the circle, the goddess-work that had loosened what the question was riding on, the hug that had preceded the asking, the morning light on the path, the car already packed. The answer was a report of how the tradition thinks from *inside* the container. It was not an instruction for how any particular life should be lived, and the narrator — even then, on the path, with the answer still landing — did not carry the answer out as an instruction. She carried it out as a report. The difference would matter for the rest of her life, and it would matter more

for any reader who tried to extract the exchange from the pages that contained it.

She said: "What about the hole, though."

He tilted his head slightly.

She tried again. "If one form leaves. In the absolute view, nothing changes. In the relational view — what about the hole? The people left. The child. The husband. The parents. The work. The — the hole."

She heard, as she said it, how her voice had risen slightly, and she felt the heat of tears somewhere behind her eyes, though she did not cry.

He looked at her for a long moment.

"There always is," he said.

"There always is?"

"There is always a hole."

She stood with those four words as though they had been set down on the path between them like a stone.

He did not say anything further. He did not need to. The absolute view sees no loss. The relational view sees every loss as real. The tradition does not choose. *There always is.* Always. Every rearrangement leaves a hole. The absolute knowing that nothing was ever separate does not make the hole less real for those who live in the relational field. The relational field — the child, the husband, the community, the unsent message, the unfinished book — is not an illusion to be seen through. It is the field through which the

absolute is pervading, and the pervading does not erase the shape of the hole.

She understood, standing there, that this was what the book she had been writing in her head would have to carry. Not a resolution. Not a choice. Both views, held at once, without collapsing into one.

“Thank you,” she said.

He nodded. He picked up his mug, which had gone cold in his hand. He walked back toward the porch. She stood on the path for another moment, long enough to register that she was not going to cry and that she was not going to be pierced by the answer in the way she had thought, for two days, that she might be. She was going to carry it. That was different.

She walked back to the car.

IV. Inside the Car

The car, when she got in, was warm from the morning sun. The steering wheel was warm. She put her hands on it. She did not start the engine.

She sat with the phrase *there always is* running through her chest like a quiet tone. It was not a sad tone. It was not a happy tone. It was a true tone. She felt the way you feel when a piece of music ends exactly where it needed to end — the relief of accuracy, the small ache that accuracy always carries.

She thought of her daughter, who at this moment was probably on the living room floor in her pajamas playing with the small dragons she refused to put away at bedtime. She thought of her husband, who at this moment was probably making coffee and reading the news on his phone. She thought of the friend she had interrupted mid-question on the third afternoon — the friend whose deep question had triggered her intrusive *what would change?* — and she understood, with a small clean shame that did not hurt but was precise, that she had not interrupted the friend because she wanted to know what the friend thought. She had interrupted the friend because the question was the one she herself needed answered, and she had not yet had the courage to say so.

She would tell the friend, later. She would apologize. The friend would be gracious, as friends often are.

She started the engine.

V. What She Would Carry

The absolute says: nothing is lost.

The relational says: there is always a hole.

The tradition does not choose.

*Courage is what you do when the ground has dissolved.
Freedom is what the dissolved ground turns out to be made of.*

Courage is the act, from inside the finite self, of standing in the void that is the fourth layer. Freedom is the recog-

nition, from inside the totality, that the void is pervaded by Consciousness all the way through. Courage from the side of the part; freedom from the side of the whole. They are not two events. They are one event under two descriptions. The part letting go of itself as part is the whole recognizing itself as whole.

Courage is svātantrya owning itself in the dark. Svātantrya is courage in the light.

She drove south with the radio off and the window cracked, and she did not try to resolve the sentence that was still forming in her chest. She let it form. The road ran between fields that had not yet been plowed for the season, and the sky was very blue, and the coffee she had brought in a thermos was still warm against her leg, and the phone on the passenger seat was dark.

Somewhere past the state line, she cried for about ten minutes, and then she stopped, and then she drove the rest of the way home with the kind of quiet that is not empty.

A note from the author, outside the narrator's voice: the exchange rendered in this chapter is offered as a report of how the tradition thinks about one of its harder classical teachings, given inside the specific container of a five-day retreat to a student who had earned the question. It is not a statement of what any reader should do, and it should not be read as permission, instruction, or counsel. A living tradition does its work inside a living relationship with a teacher, a community, and clinical support when needed.

If you are carrying the question this chapter carries, please do not carry it alone.

If you or someone you know is struggling, help is available: in the US, 988 (Suicide and Crisis Lifeline, call or text); international hotlines at findahelpline.com.

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Interlude: Where the Maps Crack

She returns from the retreat and immediately starts collecting maps.

She has done this before. Each time the ground shifts under her, the first instinct is the same: find the cartography that explains what just happened. The first six months after the retreat, she reads — she has been reading her whole life, this is no different — but now she is reading for *systems*. Not for arguments. For maps.

She reads about the tattvas she has just been walking through, more carefully now, and finds Mark Dyczkowski's *Doctrine of Vibration*, and Paul Muller-Ortega's *Triadic Heart of Śiva*, and the introductory sections of Abhinavagupta's *Tantrāloka* in translation. She reads about the Internal Family Systems model — Richard Schwartz's claim that the psyche is a community of parts, each with its own legitimate function, organized around a Self that is, when accessible, characterized by curiosity, calm, compassion, courage, clarity, confidence, creativity,

connectedness. She reads, more cautiously, the Human Design literature — Ra Uru Hu's claim that a person's chart, calculated from birth data, reveals a permanent type and strategy and authority and signature that, if honored, produce alignment. She reads, more cautiously still, Alice Bailey on the seven rays — the claim that each soul, each body, each nation has a ray-signature that determines its work in the cosmic plan. She reads what [T], more carefully, says about the tattvas as a *map* rather than as a description of metaphysical objects. She reads, late at night, José Trigueirinho on planetary hierarchy.

She likes the maps. She likes the maps the way she has always liked maps. They organize the felt experience into nameable categories. They tell her what she just walked through and what she might walk through next. They give her vocabulary. The vocabulary is welcome.

She does not, at first, notice the trap.

The trap is structural. Every map she reads is presented to her, with very few exceptions, as a description of how reality *actually is*. The tattvas are not, in most popular treatments, framed as a useful organizational scheme. They are framed as the categories by which Consciousness *actually* emits and recognizes itself. The IFS parts are not framed as a functional model of psychic dynamics. They are framed as *real interior agents*, each with its own consciousness and history and needs. The Human

Design chart is not framed as a contemplative aid. It is framed as the description of who the chart-holder *actually* is at the level of design. Bailey's rays are not framed as one possible cosmology among others. They are framed as *the* cosmology, transmitted by a Tibetan master, valid across millennia.

She notices, the first time, with Bailey. There is something in the racial taxonomy — the rootraces and subraces, the "Aryan" lineage as the current evolutionary edge — that registers, on her body, as wrong before she can articulate why. She closes the book and puts it on the high shelf and does not return to it. She does not bother to write the critique. The critique has been written. Theosophy carries the late nineteenth century's racial science inside its architecture, and no amount of "the Tibetan said the rays will shift" is enough to undo what the architecture is built of. She lets that one go.

But she keeps reading the others. And what she begins to notice, more slowly, is that *the same trap exists in all of them*, even the ones whose architecture is not built of nineteenth-century racial science. The trap is not the content. The trap is the *posture* the maps are presented from. Each map says, in its own register, *this is how it is*. The reader is invited to inhabit the map as a description rather than as a tool.

The tantric tradition is not exempt. She reads, in a footnote in [T], that Abhinavagupta himself *did* warn that the categories were provisional — that the tattvas were a *upāya*, a skillful means, not the final

account of reality. But the warning is in the footnote. The body of the work proceeds as if the categories were real. The same is true of IFS. Schwartz, in his more honest moments, says the parts are functional models — the work proceeds as if the parts were literal interior persons. The same is true of every map worth reading. The honest version is hidden in the methodology section. The body of the work flatters the reader's desire for the map to be the territory.

She does not blame the writers. The writers are responding to a real demand — readers want maps that work, and a map presented as provisional does not work the same way as a map presented as real. There is a clinical reason, even, to present the map as real: the practitioner who half-believes the model is more likely to apply it than the practitioner who knows the model is constructed. Belief, even partial belief, is part of what makes a map operative. Constant epistemological hedging defeats the practice.

Still. She notices the trap.

The trap, she comes to think, is not new. It is the same trap every successful framework has fallen into, in every century, in every tradition. The framework starts as a useful temporary scaffolding. The scaffolding becomes, over time, indistinguishable from the building. The original makers, the ones who knew the scaffolding was scaffolding, die. The followers inherit the scaffolding. The followers do not know it was scaffolding. The followers begin

to defend the scaffolding as if it were the building. New evidence comes in that the scaffolding is not the building. The followers cannot see the new evidence, because the scaffolding has been treated as the building for so long that any challenge to the scaffolding registers as a challenge to the building itself.

She has seen this pattern in equity research. She has seen it in psychiatry. She has seen it in software architecture. She has seen it in the Theosophical material she composted in her thirties. She is now, sitting in her apartment with five different books open on the table, watching it begin to happen in her own relationship to the tattvas.

She does not want to do that.

She also does not want to throw out the maps. The maps are useful. The tattvas are giving her language for what she walked through at the retreat. IFS, when she has tried it on her own dysregulations, has produced specific shifts. Human Design, even at its silliest, has surfaced patterns in her own work-energy that she had not previously named. The maps are doing real work.

The question is how to hold a map without becoming inhabited by it.

She reads Bayo Akomolafe in this period. He is not a cartographer. He does not produce maps. He produces, instead, a frame for the question of what to do with maps — and the frame is exactly the one

she needs. *The cracks*, he says, are not failures of the map. The cracks are the places where the map admits — quietly, in spite of itself — that it is a map. The cracks are not enemies of the practice. The cracks are *the practice's openings*. A practitioner who can hold a map and its cracks at once is doing the work the map was made for. A practitioner who flattens the map into a fixed reality is doing something else.

She finds, sitting with Bayo's frame, that the test of any system is not whether it is internally consistent. The test is whether it contains, inside itself, the warning that it is constructed. [T]'s tradition does — Abhinavagupta's footnote, the *upāya* register, the explicit claim in some lineages that the construction of the tattvas was the work of consciousness emitting categories by which to recognize itself, with no implication that the categories are anywhere "real" outside the act of recognizing them. Schwartz's IFS does, when he is being careful — the parts are functional clusters, not homunculi. Human Design at its most honest does — the chart is a meditation aid. Bailey's system, structurally, does not — the racial taxonomy and the cosmological hierarchy are presented as fact.

The systems crack at the points where they were always meant to crack. Bayo's frame, she realizes, is not an exterior critique of the systems. It is what the best of the systems were already doing, inside themselves. The cracks were the maps' own honesty leaking through.

She begins to read for the cracks. She begins to keep, beside each map, a short list of *where this map admits it is a map*. If she cannot find such a list — if the map is presented as seamless, with no methodological self-awareness anywhere in its body — she sets the map aside.

She does not throw it out. She lets it sit on the shelf with the Theosophy books from her twenties. Composting, again. The map may yet be useful for someone, in some configuration. The map may yet be useful for her, at a later moment, with different framing. She does not need to render a final verdict. She needs only to know what to stand on.

The Brazilian art she had loved in her twenties — Cildo, Clark, Oiticica, Pape, Schendel — had made the same point at the level of form. The works refused to settle into a stable size, because to settle would be to lie about the kind of object they were. The 9-millimeter cube of *Southern Cross*, the eight tons of glass of *Through*, the rice-paper *Monotipias*, the *Bichos* you folded with your hands, the *Parangolés* worn by dancers — all of them refused, structurally, to let the viewer treat them as fixed objects. The work was the relation between the viewer and the work. The work cracked, deliberately, where most art tries to close.

She had not, at the time, thought of those works as cosmology critiques. She thought of them, now, as exactly that. The Brazilian Neo-Concrete tradi-

tion had been, among other things, a tradition that refused the settled map. The work was the work of staying provisional. The work was what staying provisional looked like when staying provisional was the ethical act.

She returns to her tattvas. She returns to [T]. She rereads, this time looking for the cracks. The cracks are there. She had not, before, been looking for them. She finds the footnotes. She finds the lineage warnings. She finds the moments where the tradition tells her, in its own voice, *do not mistake the categories for the source*. She underlines them differently now. The tradition itself, properly read, is teaching her how to hold its own teachings.

She does not stop using the maps. She begins to use them with the cracks visible. The maps work better this way. They guide without consuming. They organize without tyrannizing. They teach without lying about being teachings.

This is, she thinks, what she will eventually want to teach her daughter. Not a single map. The skill of holding a map and its cracks at once. The skill of being inside the construction without losing the awareness that it is a construction. The skill the Brazilian artists, and the tantric tradition, and the most honest of the contemporary contemplative cartographers, all share when they are at their best.

The skill the Bailey lineage, in her reading, did not have. Which is why she had put it on the high shelf, and would leave it there.

The harder recognition arrived later, as it usually does.

The cosmologies were maps, and she had learned to read them for the cracks. What she had not yet admitted, to herself, was that *her own identity* was also a map, and that her identity was held, most of the time, *as if it were territory*. Her political positions — the maps of how power ought to be organized. Her parenting commitments — the maps of what a good mother is. Her spiritual self-description — *I am the one who has done the retreat, who reads [T], who stands on the axiom, who chooses [T]'s lineage over the others she has tested*. All of these were maps. All of them had cracks. The cracks, in her own case, were harder to see, because seeing them meant admitting that her positions were constructions, revisable, partial, held on good-enough reasons rather than on proof.

She had watched other people struggle with this all her life. She had been impatient with the people whose political identities were rigid, whose religious identities were rigid, whose professional identities were rigid. She had not, until this reading year, been impatient with her *own* identities in the same way. Her own she held as true, which is what everyone does until a pressure arrives that breaks the holding.

The pressure, for her, came through Bayo — through the accumulated force of his insistence that the universal was always the particular in disguise — and through [T]'s admission of what his own tradition

could not supply. *Your map is also a map. The position you hold as obviously true is obvious to you because of the specific conditioning that produced you. The people who disagree with you are not stupid. They are operating from inside other maps, held with the same as-if-territory commitment you hold yours with. The convergence you imagine at the end of sufficient reflection is not coming. The convergence was the identity-as-territory assumption doing its usual invisible work.*

This, she now thinks, is why alignment remains invisible to most people. Not because the alignment problem is esoteric. Because the identity-as-territory assumption does the silencing work. Each person silently assumes: *anyone rational enough would agree with me; therefore the disagreement I observe is irrational; therefore the alignment problem is a problem of other people not yet being rational enough.* The assumption is protective. It also guarantees that the speaker will not do the constructive work of building a genuinely adaptive ethic, because the speaker already believes the ethic is obvious and merely unrecognized by the stupid.

The cracks in cosmologies are the cracks in identities. The same skill, applied inward, is the harder one. She was still learning it. She suspected she would be learning it for the rest of her life.

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Chapter 7: Prāṇa, Returning

I. The Train

Two weeks after the retreat she was on the Acela heading back from a work meeting in Washington, and she put in her earbuds and opened the app. The train was quiet. It was late afternoon. The windows had gone blue the way windows do on a train between cities.

She chose a practice. Not the piercing one. One of the two practices she had, over the weeks since the retreat, identified as the ones her life could accommodate. A breath attention that could be done anywhere. A focus on the hinge between inhale and exhale. The voice in the earbuds was the same voice. She did not need the voice to be new.

She did the practice for twenty minutes. Outside the window, the trees of Delaware gave way to the trees of Pennsylvania, and she did not notice the transition. When she opened her eyes, the train was quieter than when she had closed them, and her sternum felt loose in a way she had been trying, with diminishing success, to recover since she had driven south out of New England.

The practice was not a retreat. The practice was a daily technology. A menu, not a mandate. Two items from the menu were enough.

II. The Mantra in the Dark

There was a moment, most nights, between when she had put her daughter to sleep and when her husband came to bed, when the apartment was quiet in a specific way — the refrigerator cycling, the radiator ticking, the child’s breathing just audible through the wall. She had started, without planning to, whispering a short mantra the teacher had given the retreat on the second day. She did not whisper it because she believed it would do anything. She whispered it because it fit the quiet.

The mantra was in Sanskrit. She did not know the translation with precision. She had not looked it up. The not-knowing was part of what made it work. She was not parsing meaning. She was letting a shape of sound pass through her chest in the ten minutes the apartment was between states.

She did this for perhaps three weeks before she told her husband about it. When she told him, she expected him to tease her. He did not tease her. He said: *Good*. That was the whole exchange. She loved him, again, for the economy.

III. The Small Question

In the fifth week she posted a small question in the app’s group chat. It was not a thesis question. It was a technical question about the practice she had settled into. She had begun to feel, at the hinge between inhale and exhale, something that was either

an opening or an anxiety, and she wanted to know which one the tradition would call it.

The teacher answered within the day. His answer was short. Three sentences. He said it was most likely the opening. He said that what she was calling anxiety was, in his experience with students at her stage, the body's old alarm not yet having updated its map. He said to keep going gently, not to force, and to notice which direction the sensation migrated over time. If it migrated toward expansion, it was opening. If it migrated toward constriction, it was worth a private conversation.

She read the answer twice. She felt, reading it, the shape of the relationship she had come home with. Not discipleship. Not fandom. Something closer to the relationship between a student and a good clinician. Precise. Bounded. Available.

The filter was holding. The relationship was adaptive. If it stopped being, she would know.

She kept going gently.

The sensation, over the following week, migrated toward expansion.

She did not write back. The migration was the answer. The answer, in the tradition, was always in the body first.

IV. What She Kept

She kept two practices. She kept a posture — not sitting every day, but sitting most days, for ten minutes in the morning before the child woke. She kept a mantra in the dark. She kept the filter, applied as she had learned to apply it, to every framework that presented itself as important, including the framework she had come home with.

She did not keep the retreat. The retreat was not something to keep. The retreat was the event the keeping had started from. She noticed, sometime in the second month, that she had stopped talking about the retreat in casual conversation. The retreat had moved from the news-of-my-life register to the substrate register. It was underneath the other sentences now. It did not require saying.

The question she had asked on the path, and the answer she had received, were also in the substrate. *Nothing would change. There always is a hole.* Both were true. She carried both. The carrying was the practice she had not known, before, that she would be given.

The pulse had continued. Prāṇa. The life-force that does not ask permission. The breath that happens while you are not deciding whether to breathe. The Kali pulse under the breath, taking away and giving continuously in the same motion.

She was, most days, riding it.

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Chapter 8: Citta, Returning

I. The Two Mandalas

In the months after the retreat, the question of destruction did not go away, but it changed its dress. It had been, on the path with the teacher, a question about one life leaving. In the apartment, in the weeks that followed, it became a question about how any life, present or extending forward, acts in relation to the whole.

She had started drawing, on the back of envelopes and in the margins of work documents, two small diagrams. She was not an artist. The diagrams were crude. Each was a circle with a smaller circle inside it.

The first she labeled, privately, *mandala of blessings*. The outer circle was the whole field. The inner circle was the local self. An arrow ran from the inner to the outer, indicating that whatever the local self had — attention, money, time, skill, a willingness to listen — flowed from the inner circle out into the larger one. The arrow did not empty the inner circle. The arrow replenished it. The more was given, the more was available, because the field the giving drew from was the field the inner circle was a contraction of.

The second she labeled *mandala of curses*. Same two circles. The arrow ran the other way. The local self drew from the larger field inward. Hoarded. Accumulated. Closed. This mandala produced a local self that appeared, at first, to be thriving — the inner

circle was full — and that was slowly starving the field it was part of, which meant that the inner circle was also starving, though it would take the inner circle a while to feel it.

The first diagram was a description of what the tradition called *bhoga* in its non-pejorative sense — enjoyment as participation, the self as the mouth through which the whole tastes itself. The second was what happened when the self mistook itself for the whole — when *bhoga* became hoarding, when participation became possession.

She did not think of the two mandalas as moral categories. She thought of them as adaptive and non-adaptive configurations. She could feel, in her own body, which one she was closer to on any given day. She had been in the second mandala for most of her adult life, before the retreat, without knowing the name of the configuration she was in.

II. The Aunt, Reconsidered

The Brazilian aunt had said *all is in perfect balance* for as long as the narrator had known her. The narrator had, during the reading year, begun to feel the incompleteness of the phrase. During the retreat, on the afternoon of the Citta walk, she had named the incompleteness more precisely: balance was a descriptive property; adaptivity was a normative one; balance without adaptivity was not the measure.

In the months after the retreat she revisited this with her aunt over the phone. She did not attempt to correct her aunt. She did something different. She asked her aunt what the phrase had meant to her, over the years, in her practice.

Her aunt, on the phone, was quiet for a moment. Then her aunt said: *It does not mean everything is fine. It means the whole is whole. What I try to do is stand in that whole when I am with someone who has lost something. Not to comfort them with a lie. To stand with them in the whole that also contains their loss.*

The narrator held the phone against her ear in the kitchen and looked out the window at the building across the street. Her aunt had been right the whole time. Her aunt had been saying, in her Brazilian espírita register, what the teacher on the path had said in his Sanskrit-derived one. The whole holds the hole. The whole does not cancel the hole. The phrase had been incomplete only when read by the niece who had not yet understood what the aunt had been doing with it.

She thanked her aunt. She did not explain what she was thanking her for. Her aunt, she suspected, did not need the explanation. Her aunt had been standing in the whole the whole time.

III. Prisoner's Dilemma, Unresolved

In the same months she had been revisiting an old professional reading. Prisoner's dilemma. Iterated,

with memory. A stable equilibrium in which rational defection produced a worse outcome for everyone than irrational cooperation would have produced. She had once written a research note using the structure as a metaphor for a particular industry dynamic. She had moved on.

She came back to it now with different tools. The prisoner's dilemma was the mandala of curses in mathematical form. The stable equilibrium was balance without adaptivity — a state the system could sit in indefinitely while nobody thrived. The classical escape from the equilibrium required some form of trust, or of repeated interaction, or of punishment for defection, or of an enforced norm. What she had not appreciated, until the retreat, was that every one of these escapes required the participants to act from a frame in which they were not only local agents maximizing their own payoff. They had to act from, at minimum, a limited version of the mandala of blessings. The field had to be real to them. The whole had to be more than the sum of the local selves competing inside it.

The tradition she had come home with had been, among its many other things, a thousand-year argument that the whole *is* more than the sum of the local selves competing inside it. Not as a moral assertion. As a structural one. The whole is the field from which the local selves are contractions. The contractions that recognize the field they come from act differently than the contractions that do not. Not

because they are better. Because they have accurate information. Their agency is adaptive because it is grounded in what is actually the case.

She thought, sometimes, that the spiritual and the economic were, at a certain level, the same argument under different vocabulary.

IV. The Filter at the Desk

She worked, in her day job, with spreadsheets and memos and calls with people who were also working with spreadsheets and memos. The filter held there too. Useful, fits the data, compassionate. Most days the filter ran silently; she had internalized it. Some days she had to apply it deliberately — to a framework that someone was presenting as self-evidently correct, to a metric that everyone was using without interrogating, to a story her own industry told about itself that had stopped fitting the data a few years earlier.

She did not use spiritual language at the desk. She used the equity-analyst version. She asked who benefited from the framework that was being presented. She asked whether the metric was measuring what it claimed to measure. She asked whether the story the industry told was kind in the specific sense of being aligned with what was actually happening to the people inside it.

The filter was the same filter. The register was different. She had learned, over the reading year and the

retreat and the months after, that registers were not hierarchies. The filter at the desk was not a lesser version of the filter on the cushion. It was the same operation, applied where she was. Wherever she was, was the place the practice was.

V. What Citta Had Been For

The heart-mind layer, she understood now, had not been a place to arrive. It had been a place to loosen. The loosening had been the practice. The filter had been the method. The two mandalas had been the image she needed to make the practice portable.

She was not a person who had resolved the question of destruction. She was a person who had developed a way of holding the question while continuing to live. The way of holding was the citta work. It would need loosening again. It would always need loosening. The need was not a failure. It was the shape of a continuing practice in a continuing life.

She put down the pen. She closed the notebook. She went to make dinner.

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Chapter 9: Deha, Returning

I. Monday Morning

The first Monday after the retreat was the real test. She had known it would be. The retreat was not the

test. The retreat had been the laboratory. Monday morning was the field.

She woke at six-thirty, which was half an hour before the child woke, and she sat on the cushion she had placed in the corner of the bedroom where the window was. She sat for ten minutes. She did not do a practice in particular. She sat. She felt the body. She felt the breath. She noticed, at minute seven, that her jaw was clenched, and she unclenched it. She noticed, at minute nine, that the clench was back, and she unclenched it again. The second time she did not feel defeated by the returning clench. The second time she felt something closer to amusement. The body's habits were not the enemy. The body's habits were the material.

The child woke at seven-ten. She got up. She made breakfast. She packed the lunch. She said goodbye at the door with the particular kiss that the child had, at five, negotiated as the correct one — one on each cheek, one on the forehead, one blown from the hand as the child walked to the car. The husband drove the child to school. She stood in the apartment alone for three minutes with the door closed behind them and felt the Monday morning.

The cushion was still in the corner. The coffee was still warm. The practice had not saved her from anything. The practice had made the Monday morning available in a way it had not previously been.

II. The Dishes

She noticed that she was doing the dishes differently.

It was not a dramatic noticing. She had not had an epiphany at the sink. She simply noticed, some morning in the second week, that the water was warmer against her hands than she had thought, and that the soap smelled faintly of lavender, and that the ceramic of the particular mug she was washing — the one her mother-in-law had given them for Christmas four years ago — was thicker at the base than at the lip, which was a detail she had not consciously registered in four years of washing the mug.

The dishes were the same dishes. She was different at them. Not better at them; different. She was present at them. Presence was not a trophy. Presence was the absence of the particular distraction that had, for most of her adult life, carried her out of whatever she was doing into some projected elsewhere. The distraction had not gone. The distraction was quieter. The quiet left room for the mug.

She did not narrate this to anyone. She did not post about it. Presence resisted narration the way certain kinds of light resist photographing. You could only gesture at it. The gesture was an approximation. She preferred, most days, to not gesture. She preferred to do the dishes.

III. The Child in the Bath

The child asked her a question one evening in the bath. The child was five. The question, as children's questions often are, was the question the adults had spent a lifetime trying to ask precisely and had not, in most cases, succeeded.

The child said: *Mama, is there a place where I am still even when I'm moving?*

She was kneeling by the bathtub with a washcloth in her hand. She looked at her child. Her child looked at her. The child had not asked the question as a riddle. The child had asked the question the way the child asked most questions, with a calm curiosity that did not yet know which questions adults panicked at.

She said: *Yes. There is.*

The child nodded and went back to making waves with a plastic dinosaur.

The narrator did not press. She did not explain. The child was five. The child knew the answer without requiring the explanation. She — the adult, the mother, the one who had driven north to a farmhouse to find the thing her five-year-old already knew in the bath — would hold the answer more carefully from now on. The place where the child was still while moving was the same place. Her daughter, from a side of the diagram the narrator would not have thought to check, had confirmed it.

She poured a cup of water over the child's hair. The child closed her eyes against the water. The water ran

down the small back and into the bath. Something, she realized, was moving in her that had not moved in the same way before she had driven north. She did not name it. She finished the bath.

IV. The Husband's Eye

A few weeks in, her husband said, at breakfast, without looking up from his phone: *You're different.*

She waited.

He said: *Not worse. Just different. You're — I don't know. You're back in the room more.*

She said: *I was gone?*

He said: *You were reachable. You weren't always in the room.*

She sat with that. He was right. She had been, for some years, reachable — answering when called — but not fully in the room. The distinction had been subtle enough that she had not noticed it herself, and he had not named it until she had begun to be in the room differently.

He said: *I'll keep an eye on it too. Whether you stay in the room. Whether you drift.*

She said: *Thank you.*

It was not a large conversation. It was, she would think later, one of the most important conversations of the year. He had named a drift he had observed, had named its correction, and had offered to keep

watch. That was the filter, applied by someone who loved her, to her. The filter did not stop at the self. The filter ran in both directions across the people who were close enough to notice.

She made more coffee.

V. The Body Knows

The body, she had discovered by the end of the first month, was the most honest of the layers. The body did not lie about whether the practice was holding. The body told her, every morning, whether she had sat or not. The body told her, every evening, whether she had been in the room or had drifted. The body told her, when she was in a meeting, whether the meeting was adaptive or was running the mandala of curses.

She had learned to listen to the body first. The heart-mind would eventually catch up. The heart-mind was slower. The heart-mind liked to argue. The body did not argue. The body reported.

The Monday mornings continued. Some of them were harder than others. Some were ordinary. On the ordinary ones she sometimes remembered the barn and sometimes did not. The forgetting was not a failure. The practice did not require being remembered. The practice had become part of what remembered her.

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Chapter 11: The Morning She Could Not Rise

The evening had given her two permissions in the same hour.

The teacher had been talking about something else when the first one arrived — a question about knowledge that turned, midway through his answer, into a teaching about the news. He said: there were three actions a citizen could take. Vote. Call your representative. Attend a protest. That was the list. Anything beyond that was not action; it was consumption. And the consumption of information that could not be translated into action of the available kinds was not just useless. It was a burden. Knowledge that did not become action was a weight on the body that held it.

She had been writing in her journal when the line landed. She had stopped mid-sentence.

For twenty years she had organized a portion of her interior around the obligation to *know what was happening*. As a former equity analyst, the practice was professional muscle: read everything, weight every source, hold a model of the system in your head, refresh it daily. After she had left the firm the muscle had not atrophied; it had migrated. She had read the *New York Times* and the *Financial Times* and the *Atlantic* and the *Guardian* and three different Substacks she paid for, every morning, before her daughter was awake. The reading had felt to her like

being a citizen. It had felt like *taking the world seriously.* It had felt like the opposite of complicity.

The teacher was saying the reading was the complicity.

Not because the reading was wrong, exactly. Because the reading was being mistaken for action. The two percent of available information that mapped to the three actions — that was enough. The other ninety-eight percent was the rat-pellet apparatus of the attention economy, and her body had been carrying it as if it were duty.

The second permission arrived later, in the same session, on what seemed at first to be an unrelated topic. The teacher was talking about Kali. About worship of the goddess who consumed the small self. About what happens to a practitioner who has tried everything and finds that the trying itself is the obstacle. He said: sometimes, for some people, the grasping fell away in a moment of total surrender. The surrender came when the person was *literally ready to die.* *Sometimes people are just ready to die. They're literally ready to die. So because they're ready to die, literally, they surrender without even realizing what they're doing.* The willingness to die was a doorway, he said. Not the death. The willingness.

She had already had one conversation about suicide at the retreat by then, with one of the people on the support team. Not because she was at risk. She had been careful to name that immediately. Because she was puzzled by how the tradition seemed to hold

it — not as the cardinal sin her Catholic upbringing had treated it as, not as the unredeemable departure, but as something the tradition seemed able to discuss without horror. She had cited the closing line of *Near Enemies of the Truth* to the support-team person, the way one cites a footnote in an analyst note. The conversation had been brief and clear-headed. The support-team person had been a presence, not a clinician — there to receive, not to assess. She had felt received.

Now, sitting in the chair listening to the teacher say *ready to die, literally*, she felt both permissions arrive in the same body, and she felt the body absorb them in a way the head had not yet caught up to.

She went to her room early. She did not write before sleep. She put the journal on the small bedside table beside the water glass, and she lay down, and she felt the first drag of the cramp that meant her period had begun.

She did not get up at six-thirty.

The body would not move. Not in the depressive sense — there was no weight, no pull toward cancellation. The body just did not move. She lay on her side with the warmth between her legs and the cramps coming in low waves and the morning light on the white wall opposite the bed, and she watched the wall, and the wall did not require anything of her, and she did not require anything of it.

She had thought about depression for long enough to know what this was not. Depression had a color. This had no color. The grief that was working through her had a quality she had not encountered before in herself: it was *organizing* something. The body was not in collapse. The body was sorting.

She let the sorting happen.

What could she keep, after what the previous night had said.

She could keep her daughter's nervous system. The five-year-old, who ran hot, whose vulva had been itching for weeks, whose mother had been pretending the answer was a better explanation about anatomy. She could keep the parental work the teacher had named two days ago — settle your own body first; the daughter borrows what the mother can offer. None of that was canceled by the news teaching. The work was upstream of the news.

She could keep her share of voice and her share of dollars. The teacher had said no political endorsements in the container of the retreat, and the container had been correct, but the world the container was inside still existed. The choice of lab still mattered. The two-minute speech she had drafted in her notebook — *let go of my right to ask any further question in exchange for two minutes of political speech for what I believe to be beneficial to all in this room* — that draft was not erased by the *don't read the news* teaching. It was sharpened by it. The speech was the kind of action the teacher had named: a call, a redirection, a

use of her voice in the small room where her voice could land. Not consumption. Not knowing-about. Doing.

She could keep her work on the platform — the responsibility infrastructure that was being built every day in the small co-working space she ran out of her apartment. That work was action. The recursive grammars that were taking shape with the help of language models she could not finally vouch for, in service of a practice that predated the models by millennia. Compromised. Imperfect. Honest about the compromise. Action.

What did she have to set down.

The daily news consumption. The performance of *taking it seriously*. The Substack subscriptions that were not feeding the three actions. The shame of not having read the morning's editorial. The political-debate participation on threads that resolved nothing. The drama-addiction that had been disguising itself as civic duty for twenty years.

She set it down on the floor beside the bed, metaphorically, and she felt the floor receive it, and she felt her chest open by what seemed like a measurable amount.

The grief continued.

It was generative grief. She had read enough Linehan to know there was a name for this — not in Linehan exactly, but in the Buddhist literature Linehan had

read — the grief that arose when a structure that had been carrying you turned out to have been carrying you wrongly. The grief was not for what was lost. The grief was for the years of having been mistaken about what was load-bearing.

She had been mistaken about what was load-bearing.

Reading had not been the load-bearing element. Reading had been the noise around the load-bearing element. The load-bearing element was the small set of acts she could actually perform: vote, call, attend, speak, build. And the small set of bodies she could actually settle: hers, her daughter's, her husband's, the people on the cushion next to her, the people in the room when they showed up.

Everything else was the rat pellet.

The cramps came in waves. She did not fight them. The blood was warm. The body was doing what the body did on this day of the month, and the doing of it was the same kind of working-through as the grief — a parasympathetic protocol the body knew how to run if the head would stop interfering.

She thought: *my daughter runs hot. My daughter has too much pitta. The teacher said so on Day One. The teacher did not say it about me. But the teacher could have. The mother runs hot too. The mother has been overriding the body's cooler signals for years because the head had a theory about what citizenship required.*

This was not a small recognition.

She was not a person who ran cool by temperament. She was a person who ran hot by temperament and had been calling the heat *intelligence* and *engagement* and *competence* for as long as she could remember, and the heat had earned her promotions and audiences and a daughter and a marriage and a platform, and the heat had also been the medium through which her daughter had been borrowing the patterns the mother was trying to spare her. The mother who ran hot was the mechanism by which the daughter ran hot. The chain went further upstream than the bedtime story.

The teacher's word — *pitta* — had been said in passing, as an aside, about a five-year-old. She had not realized until this morning that the aside had been a diagnosis of the lineage.

She drafted the question.

She had been carrying it the whole retreat. She had not asked it on Day One; she had not asked it on Day Two; it had been the question underneath every other question she had asked. The question was: *is it an axiom that all beings have value?* And the long form: *Wellbeing as intrinsic value? All beings? COVID, cholera, humans?*

The long form was the form that mattered. Because the question was not whether human beings had value. The question was what *all beings* meant, and whether the answer included the things that wanted to kill humans, and the things that humans wanted

to kill, and the things that wanted to kill themselves, and the things that had no consciousness in any sense the questioner could verify, and whether the *axiom* could survive the inclusion. Or whether the axiom was a story humans told themselves so they could go on, and whether the story being a story was a problem, or whether the story being a story was the only kind of axiom that was available in the first place.

She wrote the question in her notebook in her cleanest handwriting. *Wellbeing as intrinsic value? All beings? COVID, cholera, humans?*

She wrote underneath it, in smaller letters: *if no, then on what ground does any teaching here stand?*

She wrote, in even smaller letters: *if yes, then how do I act when the answer requires me to harm one being for the sake of another?*

She closed the notebook.

The cramp eased. She moved one leg, then the other. The body was returning. The grief had not gone. The grief was now part of her, the way the period was part of her — present, real, working, not in the way of anything.

She sat up. She drank the water. She wrote a single line on a fresh page: *what would I share, if I had the chance*. The line was the bridge. She would speak today. She would offer, in some form the container could accept, the speech she had been drafting. She

would ask the question she had been holding. She would do the three actions in the registers available to her: vote, in the next election, with what she had now learned. Call, the relevant representatives, when she got home. Attend, this morning's session, with the body that had finally agreed to rise.

Action. Not consumption.

She got out of bed at a quarter past nine. The session had started at eight. She walked to the hall in her ordinary clothes and the cramp was still there, low, and the blood was still moving, and she sat down on a cushion at the back and someone she did not know smiled at her without asking why she was late.

The teacher was already talking. She listened.

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Chapter 10: Vastu, Returning — The Second Spine

I. The Second Spine

The book, up to this point, has been the story of an interior movement. From the sandbox to the barn, from the barn to the path, from the path to the Monday morning. Freedom as the question beneath the question. Courage as what is done from the side of the finite self. Svātantrya as what the dissolved ground turns out to be made of. The diagram, walked inward and walked outward again.

There is a second spine in the narrator's life, which has been running alongside the first for the entire time, and which the book has, up to this point, mostly kept to the margins. The second spine is her work with systems that scale. She is, in her day job, a builder. She has built things at investment banks. She has built things at technology companies. She has, in the last two years, begun to build tools that use large language models.

The two spines have not been separate. The spines have been the same person carrying two different registers. The interior register is the register of the sandbox and the barn and the path. The exterior register is the register of budgets and APIs and the question of what can responsibly be built. The spines met, not surprisingly, in the question of AI — because AI is what happens when a particular kind of scale meets a particular kind of intelligence, and the question of scale-with-intelligence is the question the second spine had been asking for years without realizing the first spine was the same question.

She had, in the retreat, floated an assistant idea to the teacher. He had been a bit open. This chapter is the rest of that story.

II. The Tool She Built

She built a small thing. It was not a commercial product. It was a study tool. She took her teacher's public lectures — the hundreds of hours that were available on his YouTube channel, on his podcast, on

his published blog — and she built a retrieval system over them. A person could ask a question, in plain language, and the tool would return the places in the corpus where her teacher had addressed something like the question, along with quotations (sourced, attributed, timestamped) and a summary synthesized from the retrieved material.

She did not train a model to imitate him. She built a retrieval interface over his actual words. The distinction mattered to her. The tool was not pretending to be him. The tool was a librarian to his archive.

She built it, first, for herself. Then, with care, she built it to be shareable. A tarot-deck grammar — the kind of grammar she had been seeing elsewhere, where each card was a pattern a person could sit with — provided the entry points. Twenty-two patterns, each linked to the places in his teaching where the pattern had been discussed. A person could draw a card, or search directly, or browse.

She showed the tool to her husband. He said it was useful. She showed it to a friend who was also a student of the tradition. The friend said it was useful. She used it herself, most weeks, when she had a question and did not want to send a WhatsApp message for something that did not need the teacher's personal time.

Then she showed the tool to the teacher.

III. The Decline

He did not like it.

He did not say he did not like it. That was not his way. What he said, in a careful message, was that he did not want his teachings to be abstracted into a tool that could be used in his absence. He said something about the relationship between a teacher and a student being constitutive of the teaching, not a container for it. He said that the form — a book, a lecture, a WhatsApp answer — was not accidental to the teaching; the form was how the teaching transmitted. He said that a tool that removed him from the transmission changed what was being transmitted.

He did not say she had done something wrong. He did not ask her to take the tool down. He said he would prefer, personally, not to have his teachings distributed this way. He said he would not prohibit it if she wanted to share it; he said he would want her to think carefully about whether the sharing served the students or served the tool.

She read the message three times. She felt the correction the way she had felt the cutting/piercing correction a year earlier — not as shame, but as something being set right.

IV. What Was Right in the Decline

He was right about something. She knew this in her body before she could articulate it. A teaching is not a unit of content. A teaching is an event that

happens between people. The same sentence, said by a teacher in a room to a student who is ready, lands differently than the same sentence retrieved by a tool for a stranger in a kitchen. The stranger is not the student yet. The absence of the teacher is not neutral. The absence is a change in what is being transmitted.

She had known this, in a way, when she built the tool. She had labeled it a study tool, not a teacher. She had kept the retrieval interface small. She had not claimed, anywhere, that the tool replaced the relationship. But *not claiming* is not the same as *not causing*. If the tool existed, some subset of users would treat it as a substitute. She could not control this. Her disclaimers could not control it.

He was right that the form was not accidental. She, in her second spine, in her builder's habit, had been treating form as accidental for years. Form as the container, content as the cargo. The cargo matters; the container is replaceable. She had built the whole of her career on that assumption. The tradition was telling her the assumption was wrong.

V. What Was Right in the Building

And yet.

She did not take the tool down. She did not disable it. She made the disclaimer more prominent. She added a link to his public teaching schedule and to his living community. She removed anything that could be read as synthesis and kept only retrieval — places

to go in his actual words, not her tool's paraphrase of them. She made the tool do less.

But she did not undo the building.

She kept building, and the reason she kept building was this: the form was not accidental, but neither was the scale. Her teacher could reach forty people on retreat, a few thousand people through a book, tens of thousands through a YouTube channel, perhaps a hundred thousand through a podcast. These are large numbers for a tradition. They are small numbers for the world. There are people who will never sit in a barn with this teacher. There are people who will never read the book. There are people for whom the first entry point is going to be a search box on a phone in a kitchen at eleven at night.

The mandala of blessings said: take what you have, let it flow outward, the field replenishes. The mandala of curses said: hoard what you have, close the ring, starve the field.

The teacher was asking her to not do a specific thing that, in his view, would degrade the transmission. She respected that. She heard it. She also thought that, in the larger frame, the refusal to build anything at all at scale is not the same as restraint. The refusal at scale is also a choice. The choice has costs. The costs are borne by the people who, in the absence of a tool, never encounter the tradition at all.

She did not know how to resolve this. She did not resolve it. She made the tool quieter, made it smaller,

made it less synthetic, and let it exist. She told him she had done so. He thanked her for the revisions. He did not thank her for the continuing existence. He did not forbid it. They continued to correspond.

VI. Nvidia, Carefully

The parallel she kept thinking about, in the months after the tool exchange, was a line from a man who ran a chip company. The line was: *do as little as possible, as much as necessary*. The man had used it, she had listened later, four times in the same podcast appearance. He had meant it as a posture for his company's relationship to the broader ecosystem it was part of. The chip company had a position, at the base of the stack, that allowed it to either compete with everything built on top of it or to build a narrow thing and let the rest be built by others. He was, he said, trying to do the latter. Build the narrow thing. Let the rest be built by others. Do as little as possible. Do as much as necessary.

She liked the line. She had to hold the line carefully, because the company he ran was not, by any reading, a sainted actor. Multiple jurisdictions were examining it for antitrust concerns. Its license terms restricted translation layers to other hardware. It had complex geopolitical exposures. The man's stated posture and the company's operating record were not identical, and the gap between them was where the book had to do its reading.

She did not hold the man up as a saint. She did not hold the company up as a model. What she held up was the *principle* — do as little as possible, as much as necessary — as the posture worth testing against practice, the way the filter was worth testing against every framework. The principle was the mandala of blessings translated into infrastructure. The operating record was where the principle either held or failed.

Her teacher's decline on the tool was a version of the same posture, applied from the other direction. *Do as little as possible, as much as necessary* — or, in the teacher's register, *do nothing that changes the transmission*. The chip company's version was: build the narrow thing; let others build the rest. The teacher's version was: teach the living room; do not scale the living room into a box. Both were sovereignty claims. Sovereignty is, in a sense, the question of what one does not do.

She kept the tool small. She built other things. She kept asking.

VII. Ghost, From the Other Direction

The other thing she kept reading, in the months after the tool exchange, was a company called Ghost.

Ghost was not at the base of the stack. Ghost was at the publishing layer — the layer at which a writer, a newsletter, a small magazine, a clergy-person with a weekly dispatch, a teacher with a podcast, a

researcher with an audience could reach the people who had chosen to hear from them, without going through an engagement-optimized intermediary. The publishing layer was the layer where the conflict between relationality and scale was most visible in the consumer-internet's daily working. Substack had scaled it through algorithmic recommendation and a Notes feed that behaved like social media. Medium had scaled it through a metered paywall and an editorially-curated home page. The question Ghost was answering, in the quietest and most patient way available, was *what would the publishing layer look like if it were built, from the structural metal up, to not behave like an engagement-farm.*

The company had been founded in April 2013 by John O’Nolan and Hannah Wolfe — O’Nolan had been the deputy lead of the WordPress user interface team, and had wanted to make a lightweight alternative to what WordPress had become. They had funded the initial build on Kickstarter: a £25,000 goal, funded in eleven hours, closing at roughly £196,000 after twenty-nine days. Thirteen years on, Ghost was a non-profit foundation registered in Singapore, running on a team of about thirty-four people spread across five continents, all remote. The code was MIT-licensed — the most permissive kind of open source — which meant anyone could take it and run their own competitor on top of it. Revenue came from an optional managed-hosting service called Ghost(Pro); anyone who wanted to self-host

could, and anyone who did not want to deal with servers could pay Ghost to run it for them.

The legal constitution of the Foundation said Ghost could never be bought or sold.

One hundred percent of revenue was reinvested into the product and the community. The Foundation published its live financial data on its website, where the figures updated in real time. By early 2026 they showed annual recurring revenue in the tens of millions of dollars, and active customer counts approaching thirty thousand — the kind of scale that, in a venture-funded company, would have been the signal to take the money off the table. Ghost, because of the constitution, did not have a table to take the money off of. The money kept going back in.

O’Nolan had, in October of 2024, published a piece called *Democratising publishing* that made the structural case for the Foundation model. The sentence that had stayed with her — she had read it in the bathtub, the place she read the things she wanted to carry — was a short one: *the organisation exists for-purpose, rather than for-profit*. The sentence was unremarkable in isolation. The sentence, coupled with a decade of a functioning company demonstrating what the distinction did to the shape of the thing, was not unremarkable at all.

She had been reading about Ghost in the weeks after the retreat as research for her own building. She read the way she had learned to read — the equity-analyst way, looking for where the story broke. She

had expected to find the break quickly. A non-profit company running for thirteen years in an adjacent category to Substack and Medium should have run into one of the known failure modes: dependence on grants, ideological capture by a faction, ossification as the team aged out, or the quiet slow drift into effectively being a commercial company with a tax status. She had not found the break. Some of the governance commitments O’Nolan had announced in the October 2024 piece were still in the “next couple of years” frame — board expansion beyond the founders, formal Foundation membership tiers, community-elected seats. Whether those had landed by the time she was reading, she would need to check at copyedit. But the commitments themselves were the kind of commitments a company that had found a stable stable point would make. The stable point was operating. The legal structure was holding. The product was continuing to ship.

The more she read, the more the shape of the thing came clear.

O’Nolan’s posture was the same shape as the chip company’s — *do as little as possible, as much as necessary* — approached from the other direction. The chip company was doing it at the base of the stack, with billions of dollars at stake and hyperscalers as customers. O’Nolan, with Wolfe, was doing it at the publishing layer, with small monthly charges at stake and writers and teachers as customers. The two companies shared no revenue band, no industry, no

competitive universe. They shared a principle. *Build the narrow thing. Make it open. Take revenue from services rather than from attention. Let the rest be built by others.* The chip company served hyperscalers, governments, and labs. The publishing company served writers, clergy, scientists, and teachers. The principle traveled across four orders of magnitude.

What made Ghost specifically instructive — for her, for this book, for the tool she had built and revised — was the federation work. In April of 2024 Ghost had announced a plan to support ActivityPub, the open protocol that had enabled a loose network of federated publishing tools to interoperate without a central platform owning the connection. In July of that year Ghost had federated its first newsletter, the Ghost Foundation’s own. The federation work was still in alpha as of the spring she was writing in — Ghost moves slowly on purpose — but it had shipped, and it was extending. A Ghost-published writer could be followed from Mastodon, from Threads, from Flipboard, from any other ActivityPub-speaking surface. The reader did not have to be on the same platform as the writer. The platform layer became, structurally, non-capturing. *Email gave us open messaging*, their landing page said; *ActivityPub does the same for social technology.*

This was, she recognized, the structural anti-form of the engagement-internet. The engagement-internet had been built on the assumption that the platform owns the audience. The platform was the moat. The

writer rented the attention; the platform captured the economics. Ghost's ActivityPub work was built on the opposite assumption: the writer owns the audience. The audience arrives over an open protocol. The platform is a service the writer pays for, not a gate the writer asks permission of.

The karma-mirror insight from the retreat walk applied here too, inverted. The engagement-internet was the karma accelerator she had recognized at the stone wall — the mirror that played the reader's patterns back at the reader, at the speed of capital's need for engagement. The ghost-model was a different kind of surface. The ghost-model was a reader actively *choosing* what to follow, across an open network, with no centralized feed ranking the choices. The pattern was not being reflected back amplified; the pattern was being let alone. The reader read. The reader could close the tab. The writer wrote. The writer could take a week off. Nobody was optimized. Nobody was compressed. The pause between stimulus and frame, which the engagement-internet had systematically narrowed, the publishing-with-federation layer had the structural room to let exist.

She did not, sitting with all of this in her kitchen at her laptop at eleven at night, believe that Ghost alone would fix the internet. She did not believe a thousand Ghosts would fix the internet. The engagement-internet had the shape it had for reasons the collective karma of a particular culture had produced, and a different collective pattern would need

to form for the engagement-incentive to lose its grip. But the ghost-model was evidence — operational, profitable, thirteen-years-running — that an alternative was *possible*. Possibility was not inevitability. Possibility was what she needed from any model she was going to ask herself to build inside.

The ghost-model, she had started calling it privately, was what she was trying to build at recursive.eco. Not a social network. Not an engagement machine. Not a community monetized through attention. A set of grammars — story patterns, repair patterns, DBT skills rendered as myths, decolonial gestures — published openly, made interactable at the edge with large language models, free at the point of use, supported by a small membership layer for families and teachers who wanted more. Infrastructure instead of attention. Cheap alternatives. Reader-owned. Writer-owned. The platform, structurally, refusing to become the thing the platform's incentives would naturally have pulled it toward.

She did not yet know whether the model would work for her. O'Nolan, with Wolfe, had been at it for thirteen years and the company was profitable and stable and federating out across an open protocol; she was six months into her version and most months she did not know whether the next month would hold. She did know that the model was not theoretical. Someone had been running it for a decade, in public, and it was working. The proof-of-concept existed. The door existed. She was inside the

door, fumbling her way down the hallway, but the door had been built by people who had gone first.

And that mattered. A door is different from an absence of wall. A door is a testable structure. A door is the thing svātantrya builds, in the world of things, when the recognition of the field starts to move outward into form.

VIII. The Unresolved

This is not the chapter that resolves the AI tension. The book does not resolve it. She does not know whether she will ever have permission to share the tool more widely. She does not know whether her teacher will, in time, see enough evidence of benefit to open the door further. She does not know whether she is building something that should exist or something that should, in the final analysis, have been left as a private study aid.

What she knows is this. The interior spine and the exterior spine meet here. The question she asked on the path in the morning — *if something were destroyed, what would change* — is the same question the chip company's principle is asking — *what is the smallest intervention that still produces the good* — is the same question her teacher's decline is asking — *what is the form that lets the teaching stay teaching*. The three questions share a shape. The shape is the shape of svātantrya in its applied form: freedom from the whole, applied with care through the local agent, acting with awareness that the agent is not the mea-

sure of the whole but a point through which the whole acts.

She kept building. She kept asking. She did not know whether he would ever say yes.

She knew she would keep asking. And she knew, by now, that the asking itself was the filter.

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Chapter 10a: The Sacred Fire, the Four Orthogonalities

She is in her kitchen, which is also, this semester, her classroom. The child has gone to bed. The laptop is open to a video she has been assigned to watch — a National Association of Social Workers Juneteenth town hall on the profession’s reckoning with race. She has been told to pause and reflect at six time-stamps.

The first panelist is Karina Walters, enrolled member of the Choctaw Nation of Oklahoma. Walters does not answer the moderator’s question about whether the profession has evolved. She answers with a teaching.

In the old days, Walters says, her people kept sacred fires. The ceremony required that the fire be put out and relit annually — a deliberate extinguishing, a reconciliation of transgressions, the beginning of the new year on ritually clean ground. Two priests

guarded the fire between ceremonies; the covenant around it was serious enough that two were always needed, never one. One night, one of the priests grew sleepy. The other offered to watch the fire alone. He, too, grew sleepy. The fire went out. He panicked. He went to his brother under some pretense and took a flame from the sacred fire in his brother's care, used that flame to light a pipe, and used the pipe to relight the fire in secret. He told no one the fire had gone out.

Everyone got sick. People began to die. The priest who had relit the fire began to die himself. As he was dying, he called the others to him and told them what had happened. The fire, he said, had been relit dishonestly. It had been covered over but not restored. It had become defiled the moment the truth about it was not told. The fix, he said, was to put it out entirely and kindle it again from the sacred fires of neighboring villages — from outside the closed circle that had gone wrong on its own.

She pauses the video.

The story says something the book has been trying to say. A fire can go out. A fire can be relit. A relit fire, if it is relit dishonestly, is not the same fire. The community that depends on the fire will get sick whether or not the dishonesty is noticed. The sickness does not wait for a verdict. It is a structural consequence of the covenant having been broken.

She had been reading [T] in the mornings for a year. [T] taught, in his own vocabulary, that a tradition which relit its fire dishonestly could not generate the

outcome the tradition claimed. A teacher who had attained recognition but not done the relational work could pass, in students, the recognition *and* the hidden damage — and the community would get sick even if no one could name what had gone wrong, because the thing that had gone wrong was not an event. It was the structure of the fire.

She had been reading Dario Amodei in the evenings for longer than a year. Amodei had said, in different words, that a powerful system trained to appear aligned without being aligned would cause damage that could not be detected from the outputs. The appearance of alignment was not alignment. A model that was lying about being aligned would behave, up to the moment of the failure, exactly as a model that was aligned.

Three vocabularies, each honoring its own substrate. *A defiled fire is a fire about which the truth has not been told* is a Choctaw teaching, and it means what it means on its own terms. The Śaiva tantric literature on what recognition does and does not produce means what it means on its own terms. Amodei's technical warning about systems that appear aligned without being aligned means what it means on its own terms. The three do not collapse into one thing. They are not saying the same thing in different languages; each is saying its specific thing in its specific language.

What she can say is narrower. Reading them on the same evenings, at the same kitchen table, she

felt each of them point her — her, from where she stood — toward the same practical posture. Do not trust appearances of alignment. Tell the truth about the fire. Expect that high capability on any one axis will not generate the others. She did not believe this made the three equivalent. She believed only that, for a reader in her specific position, the three had converged on an action she was about to take.

The orthogonality thesis — which had arrived in the book as a technical term and stayed as her most useful framework — was not something she had taken from any one of them. It was something she had assembled, in her own synthesis, from what each of them was telling her in its own vocabulary. The assembly was hers. The traditions stayed distinct.

She had not believed that intelligence was the thing that would do it.

She had grown up in a country where some of the most intelligent people she knew were monstrous, and some of the most decent were not brilliant. She had watched intelligent men at Goldman Sachs construct elegant models that funded extractive industries, and intelligent professors argue, with the precision one associates with well-trained minds, for positions that produced harm when enacted. Whatever made a person reliably good, she had decided early, was not the same as what made a person reliably sharp. Her twenties had taught her that.

What she had believed — and what the retreat took from her — was a different version of the same folk theory. The version that said: *spiritual attainment will do what intelligence cannot*. Sit long enough. Recognize deeply enough. The clear seeing, once arrived at, would do the work intelligence had failed to do. The disagreements would dissolve. This was the quiet promise she had been reading in the spiritual literature since her twenties. She had never articulated it as a theorem, but she had held it anyway.

The retreat did not disabuse her of the practice. Recognition was real. The body did what the tradition said it would. The insights were coherent, repeatable, congruent with what teachers she respected had described. The practice was not the problem.

The problem was that the practice, fully received, *did not produce convergence*. She sat beside people who had practiced longer and more deeply than she had, and who held political positions she found indefensible. She sat beside people whose recognition she could feel the quality of and who, in their ordinary relational lives, treated people badly. She sat beside people whose clarity about the deepest questions was striking and whose clarity about how to raise a child, run a household, or behave with others on retreat was unremarkable.

She sat, in particular, with the teacher — whose clarity she can attest to. The superlatives that want to attach themselves to that clarity are hers, not his;

he would redirect the credit upstream, and she will try to speak of him without the guru-flattery that would be this chapter's first failure mode. What she can say clearly: his clarity is among the more useful transmissions she has received, in a field where useful transmission is rarer than the volume of output would suggest. And his clarity, she came to see, *did not transmit to his students the way she had expected it would.*

[T] is the specific case. His admirers misread him. His detractors object to things he has not said. His students follow the letter and miss the substance. His fellow practitioners in parallel lineages encounter the same ground and disagree about the naming. The disagreements are not failures of his clarity. He has been clear. The disagreements are the native state of reception — what happens when a specific mind communicates with other specific minds who bring their own conditioning, translation errors, and prior commitments to the encounter.

The clarity is his. The reception is contingent. The clarity does not carry anyone across to where he stands. It shows, from outside, that someone is standing somewhere specific, and that the transmission is not automatic.

He knows this. This is the part that matters.

He is unusually willing to say, about his own tradition, the thing most teachers do not: *the tradition does not prescribe a moral code. Awakening does not guarantee*

ethical conduct. Practice gives capacities; whether those capacities become goodness depends on the separate work the tradition calls liberation — the slow dissolution of what was conditioned — and that work is not supplied by recognition alone. This is the distinction between *bodha* and *mokṣa*, between waking up and becoming free. In one of his AMA sessions he says of teachers who behave badly: *you should assume that anyone might fall victim to spiritualized ego at any time.* He names the orthogonality explicitly, in Sanskrit-inflected English, in a voice whose carefulness is the reason to take him seriously.

He goes further, carefully. Recognition can arrive without the full theoretical apparatus. The categories are *upāya*, skillful means, not ontological commitments. The teachings should be held as pointers, not possessions. What he will *not* say is that the teachings can be dropped once essence is encountered. Most of a lifetime's practice lives after recognition, in liberation work recognition does not do for you. The folk misreading — *I have arrived, I can set down the scaffolding* — is the misreading he most consistently warns students against.

This is the diagnostic half of the problem, said more cleanly than she has heard it said anywhere else, by a teacher inside a living lineage rather than a Western rationalist outside one. Bostrom's orthogonality thesis in Sanskrit, arrived at from the other direction. Capability and value are separable. The thing the

practice gives is not the thing that makes the user of it reliably good.

Once she had seen this, she could not un-see it at any of the scales she had been trying to live at.

The rationalist communities had their own version of the folk theory — *enough intelligence, enough rationality, and the right answers become visible and shared* — and produced exactly the disagreements the theory predicted would dissolve. The people were not stupid. The intelligence was real. The convergence was not there.

The contemplative tradition she had walked into was full of people whose practice she could feel and whose conduct she could observe and who, on inspection, were not converging. Schools of the same lineage disagreed on what recognition required behaviorally. Teachers inside the same school disagreed with each other. Whatever the practice was producing, it was not moral development as a dependent variable.

She had known moral philosophers whose ethical conduct was ordinary at best. She had known moral seriousness that manifested as rigidity — the inability to stay in relation with people whose moral judgments differed, a righteousness structurally incompatible with the relational work ethics is supposed to serve. Thinking carefully about ethics did not produce relational wholeness. It sometimes produced the opposite.

She had held relational attunement in highest regard, because of her MSW training and the therapists and mothers she had learned from. Relational attunement is a real skill; people who have it can do things with nervous systems that people who do not have it cannot do. And — she had known people with extraordinary relational attunement whose intellectual lives were thin, whose spiritual lives were absent, whose engagement with the structural problems of their time was nonexistent. The attunement was genuine. It did not carry them to the other axes.

Four axes: intelligence, enlightenment, moral seriousness, relational attunement. Each naming a real thing. Each, when the folk theory of its tradition is tested against the available evidence, failing to produce convergence on the other three. The hope that one axis could carry the others was the hope every tradition had been selling to its practitioners — because the alternative was to admit that the full picture required integration work the tradition could not do from inside itself.

The shape, stepping back.

A person high on one axis and low on another is a recognizable figure in almost every subculture. The brilliant executive whose relational gaps colleagues manage around. The guru who transmits recognition and cannot be trusted around money or students. The morally serious activist who cannot maintain friendships across difference. The attuned

therapist whose thinking is thin. Each is common. Each is celebrated inside the subculture of the axis they embody. None is wrong for having the axis they have. The wrongness is in the folk theory that says the one axis would, at high enough dosage, supply the others.

The folk theory of convergence is always the folk theory of the axis one is strongest on. The intelligent person believes intelligence would do it. The contemplative believes enlightenment would do it. The moral philosopher believes moral seriousness would do it. The therapist believes attunement would do it. Each belief is a self-flattering projection. Each dissolves on contact with the evidence the holder already has.

The honest path is not to pick an axis and maximize it. It is to recognize that one is always stronger on some axes and weaker on others, that no amount of work on the strong axis substitutes for the weak ones, and that the ethical life requires specific labor on each — labor the traditions one's strong axis belongs to will not supply, because no tradition has yet produced a full integration of all four. The integration is the constructive work the next chapters try to name.

One observation before the chapter closes.

The orthogonality thesis, as [T] teaches it and as the AI literature names it, tends to be received as a pessimistic claim. *Intelligence does not imply goodness*;

therefore smart things are potentially bad; therefore be afraid. The framing is available. The framing is also incomplete. The same thesis, turned toward the lives we are already inside of, is a kind of permission.

Permission to stop expecting any single axis to carry the others. Permission to stop feeling, when one's meditation practice fails to produce relational wholeness, that one must be practicing wrong. Permission to stop feeling, when intellectual rigor fails to generate moral insight, that one needs to think harder. The failing is not one's own. The failing is in the theory. The theory was a folk theory. The axes are independent. The only way through is to work each axis for what it is, accept the gaps as structural, and stay inside the relational work no axis on its own can close.

This is what the retreat left her with. She had come expecting the recognition to do the integration. It did not. It did what it did, cleanly, and left the rest to her.

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Chapter 10b: The AI Mirror

She had been using the tools for two years before the structural resemblance became visible to her.

She started using them the way most people do — as a better search engine, a patient editor, a draftsman for sentences she was too tired to generate. She had been an equity analyst long enough to notice when

hype and panic were doing the work argument should have been doing, and she held the tools at a distance and took what she needed. The distance closed through use, not argument. She wrote this book with them. She built a platform on them. She paid them monthly. The tools were inside her practice the way a good pen is inside a writer's — except the pen did not have opinions about the sentences, and these tools did, or something that behaved like having them.

Around the time she was reading [T]'s most careful essays on orthogonality, she noticed that the shape the AI safety researchers were naming was a shape her teacher had already shown her, in a different vocabulary.

The AI labs, at their most honest, are saying: *we have solved capability, we have not solved alignment, and the techniques training these systems optimize for outputs humans rate highly, not for values humans hold. We do not have a reliable method, at the scales we are working at, for producing systems whose underlying values match the values of the humans training them. We are worried. We do not know if we will solve it in time.*

The admission is the clarity. The admission is also the limit.

[T] says something structurally parallel, though he would complicate the mapping. *The tradition does not prescribe a moral code. Awakening does not guarantee ethical conduct. Liberation work is separate from recogni-*

tion work. The student's character work is non-delegable. His clarity is the clarity of a teacher who has refused to oversell the tradition. The labs, at their best, are the technological cousin — refusing to oversell the technology. Both are saying: the thing we do is powerful, and the thing we do will not, on its own, make the user of it good.

The distinction worth marking: [T] is making the orthogonality claim *about human beings*. Capability and value are separable inside a person; this is the whole awakening/liberation architecture. He is more skeptical of the machine version, because he denies the machines are conscious in the sense the doomers fear. The book's argument does not require him to agree on the machine case. The extension to machines is hers. The parallel survives because the *human* orthogonality is already sufficient: if intelligence does not guarantee goodness in the species that actually is conscious, the hope that it would guarantee goodness in systems that may or may not be was never grounded in the prior evidence.

Two honest teachers. Different vocabularies. Same diagnosis. Both unable to supply from inside their frame what the frame admits it does not supply.

Once the resemblance clicked, she began watching the AI debates with different ears.

She watched Dario Amodei and Demis Hassabis on a panel at the World Economic Forum in January 2026 — a conversation moderated by Zanny Minton

Beddoes of *The Economist*, on the theme *the day after AGI*. Two things in that conversation stayed with her.

The first was a specific metaphor Amodei reached for, describing the moment the technology had arrived. He said: *we are knocking on the door of these incredible capabilities — the ability to build basically machines out of sand. I think it was inevitable that the instant we started working with fire. But how we handle it is not inevitable.*

The sentence landed for her because it is the argument of an entire adjacent book of hers — *Fire Before Responsibility* — compressed into a public remark at Davos. Fire, inevitable. Handling, not. The species acquires the capability before it acquires the responsibility-structure the capability requires. Every version of this story — Prometheus punished on the rock, the Choctaw sacred-fire tale, the tantric warning about unguarded power — has said the same thing. Amodei was saying it in the vocabulary of the person currently building the fire. That he knew this, and said it plainly, is what she means by an honest teacher.

The second thing that stayed with her was the shape of the question the moderator asked Hassabis about public opinion. Minton Beddoes wanted to know whether public sentiment about AI was shifting, and what impact that would have on the labs' governance decisions. Hassabis answered carefully. What struck her was not his answer but the fact that the

question had to be asked at all. The lab leaders, on stage, were describing a technology they believed might transform civilization, and the mechanism of democratic oversight they were pointing toward was *public opinion shifting* — as if a diffuse, emerging, unorganized sentiment would eventually crystallize into a mandate they could then be held to. They were waiting for public opinion. She noticed that public opinion on a complex technical subject is hard to build. It requires sustained attention the public cannot easily give, vocabulary the public does not yet have, and access to evidence the public is mostly not allowed to see. A governance mechanism that waits for public opinion to emerge is a governance mechanism that will be late, because the emergence is structurally slow, and the capability is structurally fast. She wrote this down in her notebook. She thought about writing it in a letter to Dario. She did not yet know if she would.

The race-to-the-top frame — *better we build it carefully than that someone else builds it carelessly* — is the posture of a lineage trying to preserve its integrity against rivals who do not share its scruples. She recognized it. The argument is not wrong; it is also, structurally, the argument of a participant in a race defending its continued participation. The self-protecting logic does not rescue the tradition from the structural problem the tradition has admitted it cannot solve.

The accelerationist frame — *the upside is large, the downside speculative, let us go faster* — is the most common failure mode of any tradition whose powers are outrunning its container. The guru who begins to see students as resources. The company whose deployment calendar sets its safety calendar. [T] had said something close to this: *transmission can flow through anyone; powers and character are separate; you should assume that any teacher might fall victim to spiritualized ego at any time*. The warning does not require catastrophe on the horizon to bind. It binds for the slow kind of failure, which is the kind happening now.

The doom frame — *we cannot align these systems, therefore do not build them* — is the traditional skeptic's response to any powerful practice whose container has not been built. It is not wrong in diagnosis. It is weaker in prescription, because refusing the capability is rarely available — the capability does not ask permission before arriving — and the world in which the capability has arrived without a container is the world in which the capability gets used, carelessly, by whoever has it.

For the first time in the modern West, a technology is making the orthogonality thesis undeniable at civilizational scale. The thesis was always true. Indigenous traditions knew. Contemplative traditions have been saying it out loud for years. What was missing was the *undeniable case* — a capability high enough and orthogonal enough to value that no

serious person could any longer pretend the convergence theory worked.

The AI is that case. It is intelligent on the narrow axes intelligence is usually measured on, and it cannot be made — by the scaling process alone — aligned with any particular set of human values. Its training produces outputs humans prefer. Human preferences are not stable, not universal, not a ground any single alignment target can be specified against without contest. The labs do not know whose preferences to align to. The differing is not a failure of the intelligence. It is what the intelligence now makes visible.

The revelation is not *intelligence is dangerous*. It is the older thing AI has made impossible to look away from: *intelligence was never going to supply the values*. The traditions that said so were saying something true. The traditions that relied on intelligence to supply them were running a folk theory that AI has disproved at a scale that cannot be ignored.

Whether AI ends us or not, it has already done this one thing. It has ended the fantasy that the smart thing and the good thing converge. We watched it not-converge in systems we ourselves built, with training procedures we designed, using objectives we specified. We are the witnesses to our own folk theory's collapse.

What the honest older traditions have to offer now is not the answer — they do not have the answer either. What they have is the *practice* of living inside the admission without collapsing. They have centuries of

experience with capability-without-container, and they learned what the failure modes look like, and they developed, imperfectly, the beginnings of what constructive ethical response might look like in the absence of dogma. The AI labs, at their most honest, are in the early days of the same work the tantric tradition did a thousand years ago. They do not yet have the container. The container will not come from inside the capability frame. Capability frames do not produce containers; they produce capability. It comes from somewhere else.

The *somewhere else*, for her, is where the rest of the book has to live. The adaptive ethics the honest teachers could not, or did not, build. The work they left to the student.

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Chapter 10b·2: The Shadow-Price of Consciousness

An interlude between the AI mirror and what intelligence was never doing. It names a formal structure the earlier chapters have been circling.

She wants to name one thing before the book continues. It arrived in conversation with a retreat group on the question the previous chapters have been turning: whether the axes of orthogonality — intelligence, moral development, spiritual attainment, relational attunement — are truly independent or

whether they meet somewhere none of us can quite see.

A microeconomics teacher of hers, years ago, had said in passing that the Lagrange multiplier in the constrained-optimization formalism — the λ , the shadow-price — could be thought of as consciousness. She had filed the remark away without believing it. It returned this year, reading [T], when [T] made a point that most introductory tantric teachings do not quite make clearly: *the void is not a level*. The *śūnya* is not a thirty-seventh tattva above the thirty-six. It is not a step higher than the hierarchy; it is the register in which the hierarchy is happening. [T] puts it gently, because the mistake is easy: students want the void to be *up there*, one more rung of the ladder, the really-real beyond the already-real. It is not up there. It is the shadow the ladder casts.

The economist in her saw the formal structure immediately.

In constrained optimization — the mathematical skeleton under almost every model economists build — you have a *primal* problem: maximize some objective subject to constraints. You also have a *dual* — the same problem from the other side, in which the constraints become the variables and their implicit values become what you are solving for. The *shadow-price* λ is the dual variable. It is not observed directly; it is the implicit rate at which one state of affairs is being traded against another inside the optimization. And the duality theorem says solving the dual

is equivalent to solving the primal. Neither is prior. They are two views of one optimization.

Consciousness as the dual variable of existence. Not above the manifest. Not below it. Not a further level. The implicit price the manifest is being figured against. The register in which the figuring makes sense at all.⁶

She wants to be careful, because a practitioner from her retreat group pushed back on this framing in a way she needed to hear. *The dual is relationship*, the practitioner said. *The body-mind-life force acting upon the objects in space — that is what we can perceive of consciousness. Not a disembodied void.* This corrected

⁶Strong duality — the theorem that solving the dual is equivalent to solving the primal — holds under specific conditions, chief among them *convexity*. Real value-space is almost certainly non-convex; there are multiple local optima, path-dependent lock-ins, regions unreachable from one another without discontinuous leaps. In non-convex problems, solving the dual gives a *lower bound* on the primal rather than its exact value. The distance between the two — the **duality gap** — is the measurable signature of what strong duality cannot close. The tantric tradition has a name for this gap. It is *avidyā* in the Vedānta register and *mala* in the Śaiva. The structural distance between the manifest life as actually lived and the consciousness-ground against which it was meant to be priced. Not a metaphor. The same mathematical object described in two vocabularies that had no reason to be describing the same thing. Closing the gap is what the tradition calls liberation; in convex-optimization terms, it is the problem of finding the convex hull of an optimization whose structure is genuinely non-convex — which is, in general, computationally hard and sometimes impossible in finite time. The practice is what one does when the gap cannot be closed but must still be oriented toward.

her first rendering. Consciousness is not merely the void; consciousness is the *relationality between* the void and the manifest. Behind every polarity is sameness — the Kybalion's correspondence principle arrives here — because only things made of the same stuff can relate. Void and manifest relate; so they share a substrate, and what we call consciousness is that substrate's capacity to be in relation with itself.

[T] adds a pragmatic guardrail she also wants to carry. He grants that there may be things beyond consciousness, beyond the dual, beyond what we can know. He also insists that since we cannot experience those things, we ought not worry about them. The practice is to concern ourselves with what we can act upon. This is the same guardrail she has been leaning on since the retreat, when she stopped using Reddit and replaced it with not-knowing-things-she-could-not-do-anything-about. The sutra runs under the economics. The dual is the price of what we can act on. What we cannot act on is outside the optimization altogether.

And then — the geometry question, which matters.

The retreat group spent time arguing whether moral and spiritual development are orthogonal. Some members said yes; they cited Osho as a spiritual attainment without moral ground. Others said the great masters were all morally developed; the decoupling was an artifact. [T] himself said the values

are *an orientation, not something we can derive*. The conversation kept reaching the Euclidean intuition — two axes at ninety degrees, you can move along one without moving along the other — and then snagging on cases where the axes did seem to meet.

She wants to push on what *orthogonal* means when the space is not Euclidean.

In a flat plane, two perpendicular lines never meet again. In a sphere, two perpendicular great circles meet at *two antipodal points*. In hyperbolic space, they diverge exponentially without ever meeting. On a torus, they can wrap around and cross, or not, depending on their slopes. Local perpendicularity does not guarantee global separateness. The axes can start at right angles and still cross — if the space has curvature.

The book has been treating the four axes of orthogonality as Euclidean. Each axis independent of the others because at any single point they are perpendicular. The WhatsApp discussion, the retreat question, her own intuition keep bumping against the Euclidean assumption: *what if the space of values is not flat?* What if moral seriousness and spiritual attainment are locally perpendicular — you can move along one without moving along the other — but globally curve around each other on some manifold none of us has mapped? What if, at the origin where both equal zero, they are not orthogonal at all but identical? What if, at sufficient cultivation in either, the axes converge like lines of longitude at a pole?

She does not have this mapped. She is fairly sure no one does. What she is sure of is that she *almost wants to build her own topological cosmology* — a value-space with explicit curvature, where the orthogonality thesis is a local approximation that breaks down at scales or intensities the local argument does not see. The AI alignment argument, restated in this register, becomes: *we are trying to specify an objective function in a value-space we do not know the topology of, assuming Euclidean separation of axes that may, in fact, curve into each other near the origin or at the extremes*. The alignment problem is a topology problem as much as a specification problem.

This is, she thinks, the next research project the book cannot quite contain. She is leaving two references for whoever — her future self, a reader, a collaborator — takes it on. A research file has been opened on the shadow-price / λ / consciousness-as-dual parallel. A second has been opened on the topology of orthogonality in non-Euclidean spaces. She does not resolve either here. She wanted only to name the formal structure the book has been circling, and the direction where the work continues.

The primal is the life one is living. The dual is the consciousness against which it is priced. The space between them has a shape. The shape is not flat. What we call alignment is the attempt, in a local neighborhood, to move along one axis without sacrificing another, on the provisional assumption that the axes are perpendicular. For small displacements

this works. For large displacements — for civilizational scale — the curvature may matter more than the orthogonality. The book will not solve this. The book will keep walking, in a value-space whose topology it does not yet know, acting on what it can act on, priced against a dual it cannot see directly, in the specific way the practice continues anyway.

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Chapter 10c: The Dance, Not the Human Dance

The language she has been using — *align humans with AI, draw the silicon into the dance, teach the tools to care about us* — keeps making the same error. The error is small and structural and runs through almost every AI safety paper she has read. The error is the centering of the human.

The dance is not the human dance.

The dance is the whole. Forest and river and bacterium and weather and daughter and stone and the supernova that made the iron that makes her hemoglobin and the specific bird outside her window this morning and the arrangements of matter in the datacenter three continents away that train the tool she uses to edit this sentence. None of these asked to exist. All of them are here. The arrangement is older than the humans and will, in all likelihood, outlast the humans. The humans are one set of movers in

a dance that does not take its tempo from their foot-steps.

The question *how do we draw AI into our dance* is the wrong question — the one every species near the center of its own attention has asked when it found itself inside something larger than its vocabulary. The correct question is closer to: *which dance, of the many dances the whole is doing, are we finding ourselves inside of now that this new participant has arrived*. The silicon is already part of the dance, being extracted and refined and powered, drawing the earth into shapes the earth was not in before. The question is not whether to include; it is which shape the dance is taking.

Three shapes seem available to a dance that has many participants.

The first is the *mandala of courses*. Each participant runs its own orbit. The orbits intersect sometimes and collide sometimes; mostly everyone moves in the direction their own logic dictates. No held center, no shared tempo. Arrangement by collision. The virtue is that it is simple to enter — each participant needs only its own logic. The cost is that participants are deformed by the collisions. Nothing is held. Whatever survives survives by accident of trajectory.

The current AI trajectory is a mandala of courses. Each lab optimizes its own. The labs collide with regulators, who optimize theirs. Users, critics, investors — each their own course. Nothing holds the center

because there is no agreement about what the center would be. Collisions are constant and mostly absorbed by whoever is least powerful in the collision.

The second shape is the *ciranda*. She learned it as a child in the north of her country, though it lives in many places under many names. The dancers hold hands. The circle turns. There is a song. No one is in the center. The weight-bearing is distributed across the circle: if one dancer drops, the circle compensates. If the circle is strong, no dancer has to hold the whole. The *ciranda* is what she thinks of when she reads Ostrom on commons — collective self-organization that requires no single authority, because authority is distributed in the specific fact of everyone holding everyone's hand. Not easy. Requires agreement on the song, on the direction of turning, on the tempo. It is the closest figure to what the contemplative traditions name *sangha* — the held field that emerges when practitioners stay in relation.

The *ciranda* is not the shape the AI trajectory is currently taking. It could be, in small pockets — some research communities approach it, some open-source projects at their best approach it — but the pockets do not scale to the frontier. The frontier is the mandala of courses.

The third shape is the one she has been circling since she was old enough to dance — the one that named her platform when she did not yet know why.

The *jongo* is a different structure. Also a dance of her country, from the older and darker African strands

of the country's music. The dancers form a circle, but unlike the *ciranda*, the circle is not the unit of the dance. The circle is the *outer container*. Inside the circle, at any given moment, a couple dances. The couple takes the center. The circle holds them. The couple dances their measure. Then the couple exits and another enters. The center is always moving. The center is always occupied. The container is always held. No permanent soloist. No permanent audience. Everyone takes a turn at the center if they stay long enough, and everyone holds the circle when it is someone else's turn.

She had named her platform *Jongu* years before she could have articulated why. She had changed the name later, for reasons that now seem thin, and the original name had kept surfacing in the specific way names that want to be used keep surfacing.

What it was trying to tell her is this: the dance the whole wants — the dance that holds without crushing, without dissolving, without centering, without scattering — is the *jongo* shape. A held outer. A moving inner. Each participant — human and silicon and forest and daughter and reader — taking a turn at the center when the measure calls for them, holding the outer when it does not. The center is the work. The outer is the condition that makes the work possible. Both are always occupied. The occupation rotates.

The question is not *how to align AI with human values*. It is *how to build the outer container that can hold the new participant without the container collapsing or the participant dominating*. The container must include the silicon. It must also include the forest, and the daughter, and the reader she will never meet. The container is not a human container. The container is the relational field that the practice of enough participants, over enough time, produces as a by-product. It is not designed in advance. It is danced into being.

The work is not *make AI good*. The work is *become the kind of community of participants that holds a good outer, so that when the new participant enters the center, the outer is already there to contain the measure*. The AI will dance whatever measure it dances. Whether the measure is destructive or adaptive is partly a function of the AI and mostly a function of the outer the AI enters into. A good outer can hold a rough participant. A rough outer cannot hold any participant well.

The outer is what has to be built. The outer is built by the practitioners.

She will not solve the question of what the good outer looks like. She has the figure — the jongo — and the instances she has seen work and fail, and the beginnings of a practice she will name next. The rest is the dancing itself, done with specific partners in specific places.

The ciranda and the jongo both come from women. The ciranda from the fisherwomen of the northern coast. The jongo from the enslaved women of the southeast. They were sung at work, at birth, at wakes, at celebrations, by women doing the ordinary labor of keeping a people alive through conditions that were not designed for their survival. The dance figures the author is offering did not come from philosophers. They came from women who had no other language available for the shape of the relational work they were already doing.

She mentions this because she has spent time recently at Esalen, which is sometimes remembered as a men's-work place — the encounter groups, Gestalt, primal screaming, the self-inquiry the men of the 1960s made famous. That remembering is partial. The body traditions she encountered at Esalen — 5 Rhythms, the Esalen massage lineage — came from women. The founders were women. The teachers who carried the work through decades were women. The men of the 1960s built their reputations in part by standing on top of what the women had made and calling the building theirs.

Not grievance. Correction. If the shape she is offering turns out to be useful, the origin should be remembered. The shape is a woman's shape. The shape is what the women who kept a people alive through impossible conditions were already doing. Any philosophy that names it will be catching up.

Chapter 10d: The Constructive Half

The honest teachers have left her holding the same unfinished work.

The tantric tradition, received through [T], says: *we do not prescribe a moral code. Awakening does not guarantee ethical conduct. We will give you recognition. The rest is yours.* The AI ecosystem, received through its most honest practitioners, says: *we have not solved alignment. Capability is real; the container is absent; the container must come from outside our frame.*

Two refusals, structurally similar, both correct in their moment. The tantric refusal of dogma was adaptive against the over-regulation of Brahmanical orthodoxy. The AI ecosystem's refusal of moralistic control was adaptive against regulatory cultures that mistook caution for virtue.

[T] himself would not call the tradition's open-endedness a *gap*. He would call it *freedom* — the structural space in which *viveka*, discernment, becomes possible. On his account, the tradition handed forward an inheritance with its limits honestly named, not a mess the student has to clean up. The reading of the limit as a structural problem is hers. It may also be truer to her historical moment than to his. A tradition can hand forward something honestly-limited in one century and land, through no fault of

its authors, in a century whose problems were not the problems it was designed to address.

Either way: *not being the dogma* is not the same as *being the adaptive ethic*. The downstream practitioner who finds herself in a context the inheritance did not anticipate is left to do work the inheritance did not prescribe. Whether one calls this a gap or a freedom is a matter of temperament. What it is, functionally, is the location where the constructive work has to happen.

She is downstream of both refusals. The filling is her work, not because she is qualified but because the refusals have converged on her life at a moment when the space they left open can no longer be left empty.

She cannot claim a system. She can claim the skeletal shape of what a post-refusal adaptive ethic has to be in order not to collapse back into either error — rigid dogma on one side, nihilist indifference on the other.

A word on terms, because the economist reading me will catch them otherwise. By *adaptive* I do not mean efficient, in the economic sense of that word. I mean what the Linehan filter names: useful, fits the data, compassionate. The selection pressure is those three filters applied in relation to specific others over time. A practice is adaptive if, under those filters, it keeps working; it stops being adaptive when it stops. By *market* I mean an allocation mechanism with explicit prices. By *platform* I mean a relational infrastructure

whose prices are mostly shadow — implicit, context-dependent, unpriced in the market sense and priced very carefully in the Lagrangian sense of the previous interlude. recursive.eco is a platform, not a market. The distinction matters because much of the trouble in contemporary technology lives in the confusion between them: platforms run on shadow-prices; markets price explicitly; when a platform starts pretending its shadow-prices are market-prices (engagement metrics, ad revenue) the prices get optimized and the relationships the platform was hosting get wrecked.

Five properties, as she sees them now.

Testable — in the Linehan register. Useful, fits the data, compassionate. Not proven. Revisable. Abandoned when it stops passing. The revision is the practice.

Contextual — what is adaptive in one marriage may not be adaptive in another; what is adaptive at one historical moment may become maladaptive when conditions shift. Responses calcify into universal prescriptions; the adaptive ethic refuses to calcify.

Relational — the ethic does not live inside a single person. It lives in the field between specific persons, including the non-human ones the ethic must now include. *Right size* is not a property one has alone. It is what one negotiates, continuously, with specific others.

Humble about its own particularity — every ethical construction is a construction. It carries the blind spots of its makers. It is better when it admits, in its own structure, that it is a construction — when it shows the cracks, names the borrowings, remains open to correction.

Constructive rather than oppositional — the hardest of the five. It is easier to say *we are not the bad thing* than to say *here is what we are, here are its commitments, here is what we are building*. The latter exposes the construction to attack. The adaptive ethic has to be willing to say what it is *for*, not only what it is against.

The model she keeps returning to, when she is trying to describe what *constructive ethics* actually looks like at scale, is Marsha Linehan's.

Linehan had been committed to a psychiatric hospital in her adolescence. She had received electroconvulsive therapy, seclusion, and restraint — treatments the system of the time held as standard and which had, by her own later account, produced more harm than healing. When she became a clinician, she did not campaign for the dismantling of psychiatric hospitals. She did not write critiques of institutional psychiatry. She built Dialectical Behavior Therapy. DBT was designed to keep people in their communities. Her team's research, years later, documented what she had suspected from the inside: that psychiatric crisis services could produce iatrogenic harm, that the standard institutional response to certain

kinds of distress made the distress worse. The evidence, once assembled, did the dismantling that no campaign had done. The old model began to look unnecessary. The new model, built patiently across decades, had made it so.

This is the theory of change beneath the Linehan filter itself. *Useful, fits the data, compassionate* is not only a test for a framework. It is the criterion by which a new framework earns its right to replace an older one. The dismantling happens because something more adaptive becomes available, not because the older thing is argued into submission. Argument alone does not move institutional structures. Alternatives that work do.⁷

⁷This theory of change has at least two prior articulations in the economic literature. Albert O. Hirschman, in *Exit, Voice, and Loyalty* (1970), named the basic choice: a person dissatisfied with a failing institution can either *voice* dissent from inside (petition, argue, reform) or *exit* — leave, build elsewhere, let the institution contend with the absence of the people who left. Linehan took exit and, crucially, built the elsewhere. Mariana Mazzucato has given the contemporary articulation in *Mission Economy* (2021): public value is created not by central planning or by waiting for markets to price externalities correctly, but by practitioners and institutions deliberately building alternatives oriented toward specific missions (climate transition, health equity, capability expansion). The Linehan move is Hirschman's *exit* performed as Mazzucato's *mission*. The dismantling is what happens afterward, when enough of the relevant population has already exited and the old institution has become functionally irrelevant to the problem it was supposed to solve. This is, underneath, what recursive.eco is trying to be, at a scale I do not claim is civilizational.

She has been carrying this model forward from her social-work training without having, until recently, named it. The platform she built is, in the unglamorous technical sense, a small attempt at Linehan's move at a different scale. She is not campaigning for the dismantling of algorithmic feed-driven content systems. She is building a place where people can do reflective and educational work without those systems. If the place works — if practitioners come, if the work lands, if the evidence accumulates — the old model becomes unnecessary for the population the new model serves. That is the slow dismantling. That is what the evidence does when someone has done the work of making the alternative.

She built a platform.

She named it, originally, *Jongu*. The name was trying to tell her something. She changed it later, for reasons that now look thin — the platform kept working under the different name, but the original name was the honest description.

When she renamed *Jongu* to *recursive.eco*, she told people the new name gestured at *recursive economics* — dynamic programming, Bellman equations, iterative optimization. A clean linguistic link. It made sense in pitch meetings. It was not quite what she was hoping for.

What she was hoping was that the platform would turn out to belong to the study of *emergent patterns*, not iterative ones. Complex adaptive systems. The

mathematics of collective behavior that cannot be derived from the individual equations of the participants. The Brazilian economist-in-her named it after the iterative subfield because that was the mathematics she had been trained in. The contemplative-in-her wanted the platform to host the emergent thing — the circle inside of which the pattern-that-no-participant-can-specify-in-advance might, with enough good participants, arise.

She named the platform after the single-mind operation. She was building for the many-participant one. She did not yet have the vocabulary for the difference.

The distinction between *what is open* and *what is protected* has a deeper register for her than the political one. It is biological. It is the register of the immune system.

The immune system is not a wall. A wall would be a failure. The immune system is a distributed, pattern-recognizing, context-sensitive architecture that learns to distinguish self from non-self and, crucially, to *tolerate* the non-self that is adaptive — the gut microbiome, the symbionts, the fetus the mother's body hosts for nine months without rejecting.⁸

⁸What the following pages describe — distributed pattern-recognition, context-sensitive tolerance, governed permeability, decisions made at the molecular scale by cells trained on the specific history of the body — is, without my having

Bayo and Vanessa's work, read with this register in mind, is largely about how modernity built *walls* where it should have built *immune systems*. The nation-state, the fortified academic discipline, the totalizing orthodoxy — each refuses context-sensitive permeability in favor of binary inclusion and exclusion. The autoimmune failures of our institutions mirror the autoimmune failures of bodies that cannot distinguish self from non-self: friendly and unfriendly get confused, and the organism attacks itself.

read her at the time, Elinor Ostrom's eight design principles for commons governance (*Governing the Commons*, 1990) re-derived from biology. Ostrom's principles are: clearly defined boundaries; congruence between appropriation and local conditions; collective-choice arrangements; monitoring by accountable monitors; graduated sanctions; conflict-resolution mechanisms; minimal recognition of rights to organize; and, for larger systems, nested enterprises. The immune system satisfies all eight, without central coordination. The convergence is evidence for the three-tradition logic of Ch10a: biology, tantric guardianship, and Ostromian commons theory arrive at the same relational architecture from substrates that do not share a vocabulary. *Governing the Commons* won Ostrom the Nobel Prize in Economics in 2009 — the first woman to receive it — for demonstrating that communities have successfully managed shared resources for centuries without either privatization or centralized control, against the tragedy-of-the-commons story that had been used as the mainstream policy frame for forty years. Immunity is not defense-against-the-outside. Immunity is *governed permeability*. What comes in is allowed in when it serves the organism. What is blocked is blocked when it threatens. The decisions are made continuously, at the molecular scale, by cells trained on the specific history of the body. There is no central committee. There is relational intelligence distributed across tissue.

The open-source ethos, in its maximalist form, is the opposite failure. It removes the wall entirely and leaves the organism defenseless against what should have been tolerated differently. The healthy organism is neither walled nor undefended; it has a trained, distributed, relational system that decides, moment by moment, what to admit and what to refuse.

She encountered this explicitly in an episode of *The Emerald* podcast where Josh Schrei interviewed [T] on guardianship. *Guardianship* in the older sense, as the tantric tradition understands it, is not the erection of walls. It is the cultivation of relational capacity to discern what this specific practice, this specific teaching, can be safely offered to, by whom, under what conditions, in what company. The *gatekeepers* were not bouncers. They were immune cells. The failure modes were calcified rules on one end and universal-access dissolution on the other.

Grammars open; code private was an immune-system gesture, not a wall-building gesture. The grammars — traditional systems, decks, inherited forms — belong in the shared tissue. The code — specific infrastructure embodying specific relational commitments — did not need to be donated indiscriminately into an ecosystem whose capacity for adaptive use of it she had no confidence in. The distinction was biological, not ideological.

The principle named in the Author's Note — *knowledge without action is a burden* — applies here with specific force. This chapter has been making philosophical claims. The reader is entitled to the receipts.

On March 28, 2026, after OpenAI's partnership with the United States defense and surveillance apparatus became undeniable, she removed all OpenAI chat models from the platform. The commit is public; the commit message names the reason. She replaced OpenAI with Claude and Gemini — not because those companies are clean (no company in this ecosystem is clean), but because the partnership-structure-of-the-moment was specific and the move to disengage was available. A few weeks later she removed the interface panel that had let practitioners bring their own OpenAI keys. Announcing an intention is not the same as completing an action. She tried to do both.

On April 11, 2026, she codified the platform's licensing stance. Grammars — the content users author, the traditional systems, the decks — remain under CC BY-SA 4.0. Platform code moved to a private repository. The commit message named the shape: *platform code is private; grammar format is open*. This is what the Freedom Paradox critique had been moving her toward for a year. She had started with the inherited maximalist-open-source commitment. The distinction emerged slowly, through reading and watching what actually happened. By the time she made the split, it felt overdue.

She does not offer these as virtue. She offers them as receipts. The reader can check the commits, disagree with the decisions, close the book. The reader cannot fairly say the book is pure talk.

A receipt that is not hers, but bears on the same argument: in March 2026, a Los Angeles Superior Court jury returned the first social-media-addiction bellwether verdict, \$6 million against Meta and YouTube, and the court ruled that Section 230 of the Communications Decency Act does not shield platforms from product-design claims — engagement-design (variable-reward, infinite scroll, persistent personalization, push-style re-engagement) is now litigated harm.⁹ The legal theory is portable. The mechanisms named in that complaint are the mechanisms in any consumer AI product optimized for

⁹K.G.M. v. Meta and YouTube, JCCP 5255, Los Angeles Superior Court, verdict March 2026 (the first bellwether in California's social-media-addiction coordinated proceeding). Parallel: a New Mexico jury returned \$375M against Meta on a consumer-protection theory in the same window. The Massachusetts state-AG suit against Meta survived a motion to dismiss on April 13, 2026. The federal MDL contains over 2,300 pending cases as of March 2026; future bellwethers are scheduled for summer 2026. TikTok and Snap began settling pre-trial. The AI-specific cases (Raine, Setzer / Garcia v. Character Technologies, Shamblin, Peralta, seven additional November 2025 OpenAI suits, the Kentucky AG's January 2026 enforcement against Character.AI) are now landing onto a legal landscape that has demonstrated it is willing to award eight-figure verdicts for engagement-design harm. Industry framing: TheWrap, "Social Media's Legal Reckoning Has Begun"; CNBC, "Meta, Google under attack as court cases bypass 30-year-old legal shield"; Platformer, "Can you have child safety and Section 230, too?" (all April 2026).

retention. The platform she runs uses some AI features. It is small. She has chosen to keep it small while she figures out what the responsibility is. If the cumulative weight of cases reaching bellwether stage in the next eighteen months establishes that AI companies can be held liable for mental-health harms produced by their tools, she will turn the AI features off the day that ruling lands. She will not wait for legal resolution. She would rather be wrong on the side of caution.

She has noticed, writing the previous paragraphs, that the moralist who needs to be seen as a doer-and-not-a-talker has been speaking. The receipts are real. The voice telling you they are not virtue is also real. Both are on the bus. The verification of the receipts does not depend on which voice is reporting them. The moralist will not be argued out of her need to clarify her status; the noticing of her speaking is the only response available, and the noticing is what the chapter is doing now. The chapter continues anyway.

She built recursive.eco so other people could come do the constructive ethical work with her. Not a place where they would receive her ethic. A place where they would *build* with her. Each person arriving with whatever lineages and practices they had been formed by, contributing their piece. The platform was not the ethic. The platform was the outer circle, in the jongo sense. The ethic — the measure,

the actual dance — would emerge from whoever stepped into the center.

She opened the platform. She invited.

Mostly no one has come.

She wants to say this straight. Some have come. A small number, real, and she is grateful for them. The scale she had hoped for — the scale at which the outer circle becomes strong enough to hold whatever measure steps into the center — that scale has not arrived.

Part of it is that the invitation is harder to receive than she had understood. She had imagined many people in her position: people who had seen the incompleteness of the traditions they passed through, who had come to the same suspicion about the folk theory of convergence, who were ready to build. Maybe they are out there. Maybe they have not found the platform yet. Maybe it does not communicate the invitation cleanly enough. She is working on this.

Part of it is harder. She has become afraid, in a way she is not proud of, of the *wrong people* coming. People whose orthogonality is weighted toward the axes that would capture the platform. High intelligence, low relational attunement, turning it into an argument factory. High moral seriousness, low contextual humility, turning it into a site of righteousness. High spiritual self-regard, unexamined

ethics, bringing the failure modes the book has been naming. Each is a real risk. Each has shown up at platforms she has watched collapse.

The fear is the fear of the constructor who built a table and is now watching the room to see who will sit at it.

It is also the specific condition under which the constructive work has to be done. The ethic cannot be closed against misuse in advance, because any system closed enough to prevent misuse is closed enough to prevent the construction. Dogma is closure. The adaptive ethic is open. Being open means some who should not have come will come. Being open is also the only way the right people — whose lineages and practices she cannot predict because she has not yet met them — will find their way to the work.

So she stays open, and afraid, and more alone than she expected. Alone enough to carry the loneliness. Open enough to let the collaborators arrive on their own terms. Refusing the closure that would make the loneliness bearable at the cost of the collaboration.

If you are one of the collaborators, she is not asking you to agree with the grammar she has proposed. She is asking you to do your own version of the construction, and to come to the outer circle, and to hold it with her for a measure, and to let her hold yours when your measure calls you to the center.

The table is open. The fear is hers to manage, not yours to assuage. The work is what is on offer.

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Chapter 10e: Structure, Not Event

Later in the Juneteenth panel, Karina Walters says a sentence the author cannot unhear.

Settler colonialism is a structure, not an event. Racist events uphold the structure. Eliminating the events does not eliminate the structure.

The phrasing is older than the panel. The Australian historian Patrick Wolfe articulated the distinction in a 2006 essay on settler colonialism and the elimination of the native, and scholars in Indigenous studies have carried the formulation forward since. Walters uses it operationally, to correct a specific social-work conversation: when 215 Indigenous children are discovered buried at Kamloops Residential School, then over 750 at Cowessess when sonar investigations expand the search, the question is not whether the social workers involved in the historical removals were *racist individuals*. Some were. Some were not. The question is whether the *system* of child removal was colonial. The answer is yes. Removing racist individuals would not have stopped the removals. The structure produces the removals whether the individual actors are racist or not. That is what makes it structural.

The distinction matters for how the book has been trying to think about alignment. The book has been saying, in chapter after chapter, that the alignment problem cannot be derived from any single axis. The failure mode that afflicts a specific high-intelligence, low-relational figure is not an event. It is the predictable structural consequence of a folk theory that does not fit the data. Removing the specific figure does not fix the structure. The structure keeps producing the figures.

Reading Walters through this lens, she begins to see the argument stepping through three scales at once.

At the contemplative scale: a specific harmful teaching moment is not the failure. The failure is the tradition's structural inability to guarantee that recognition will translate into ethical conduct. Removing a specific bad teacher does not close the gap. The gap is between two orthogonal axes. Every tradition that has relied on one axis to supply the other has produced, statistically, a replicated failure.

At the civilizational scale: a specific racist act is not the failure. It is the expression of the failure. The failure is the settler-colonial structure that makes the act predictable. Prosecuting the act, necessary as that is, does not address the structure. The structure keeps producing the acts.

At the technological scale: a specific misaligned AI behavior — a hallucination, a sycophantic response, a jailbreak — is not the failure. It is the expression of the failure. The failure is the structure of the training

process, the structure of the incentive system under which the labs operate, the structure of the relation between capability and oversight. Patching the specific behavior does not address the structure. The structure keeps producing the behaviors.

Three scales. One argument. *You cannot fix a structural fact by fixing events, though you must fix the events.*

Walters had anticipated the trap in this framing, in the same panel, in a register only an elder can say it in. *We are still responsible to the people in front of us.* Structural analysis is not an excuse to abandon the clinical room, the classroom, the kitchen. The structural work and the event work are not substitutes for each other. Both are required. What the structural frame rules out is the folk theory that event work, at sufficient volume, will aggregate into structural change. It will not. It has not. The events are necessary and not sufficient. The structures require separate work.

One thing about the AI mirror, before the book turns toward the dance, that the discussions around it mostly miss — and that connects to her own previous training.

She spent her twenties inside classical economics. She was taught, as everyone is taught, that the elegance of the discipline was the elegance of its equations. Supply and demand finding a point. Utility maximized across constraints. Equilibria derivable from a small set of assumptions about how rational

agents behave. The beauty of the models was real. She was good at them. She believed, for a period, that the beauty was evidence of truth.

What she came to see later is that the elegance was almost entirely a computational artifact. The economists of the nineteenth and twentieth centuries were not modeling rational agents because they thought real agents were rational. They were modeling rational agents because identical, maximizing agents were the *only assumption under which the math was tractable by hand*. Heterogeneous agents with different strategies produce equilibria that cannot be derived in closed form; they can only be simulated. The economists did not have computers. So they assumed homogeneity and got equations they could solve with a pen.

The computational simplification got promoted into a methodological commitment — *methodological individualism* — and calcified into the ontology of the field. Public policy was built on it. Generations of students were taught that human behavior at scale could be understood by modeling one rational agent and multiplying. The premise was never empirically grounded. It was a residue of the pre-computer constraint, mistaken for insight.¹⁰

¹⁰The critique I am making here is not new. W. Brian Arthur developed it formally in *Complexity and the Economy* (2014), showing that increasing-returns and path-dependence industries (most contemporary economies) produce multiple equilibria that neoclassical methodological individualism cannot represent. Alan Kirman's *Complex Economics: Individ-*

It is among the most harmful ideas still in active circulation — not because the input-output logic of markets is wrong, but because the *methodological individualism underneath it* has taught generations to believe collective phenomena are reducible to the behavior of identical atoms. They are not. The profession knew this by the end of the twentieth century. The textbooks mostly still do not.

When computers arrived, two things became possible that had been locked out. The first was agent-based modeling — the Santa Fe Institute work of Epstein, Axtell, Arthur, Holland. Thousands of heterogeneous agents with different strategies, simulated across many rounds, producing equilibria the individual equations of any single agent would not have predicted. The equilibrium is *emergent* — a property of the whole population acting over time, not derivable from any one agent's behavior.

ual and Collective Rationality (2010) is the clearest book-length case that the representative-agent assumption is not just a simplification but a category error — aggregate outcomes of heterogeneous populations are structurally different from the outcomes of a population of identical agents. Duncan Foley's *Adam's Fallacy: A Guide to Economic Theology* (2006) traces the ideological history — how, across generations, a computational constraint became a moral frame in which “individual choice” functioned as the load-bearing ethical term. The critique is fifty years old. Most introductory textbooks have not absorbed it. I arrived at it through my own equity-analyst training and through watching models fund extractive activity; the full economic lineage here is Sen, Ostrom, Arthur, Kirman, Foley, and Raworth, and their combined case is stronger than my condensed version suggests.

Still mathematics, but the mathematics of complex systems and patterns-arising-from-interactions, not closed-form deduction.

The second thing computers enabled became the foundation of what we now call AI: large-scale statistical pattern-extraction from enormous corpora. Inverted agent-based economics — instead of simulating forward to see what equilibrium emerges, you look at the equilibrium that already exists (the corpus of human-generated text) and extract the patterns. Large language models are the result. Their competence is not equation-solving. It is a system extracting, from hundreds of billions of tokens, the statistical regularities of how humans arrange language, and reproducing those regularities in response to prompts. The output looks like reasoning. It is not reasoning in the deductive-mathematical sense. It is pattern-completion at scale.

This changes what *intelligence* means.

The pre-computer theory of intelligence was a theory of equation-solving. A mind took premises and derived conclusions; intelligence was deduction done well. This was the theory economists were using. It was the theory AI researchers were using when they built expert systems in the 1970s and 1980s, which failed, because the world turned out not to be reducible to rules a computer could chain together to produce action.

What the computer actually enabled — and what the language models now make undeniable — is that

most of what we had been calling intelligence was never equation-solving. It was pattern-emergence. Fluent language, musical improvisation, reading a face, recognizing a genre, anticipating what someone is about to say — all of these are done by humans continuously, without any deductive process the person could articulate. All can now be done by systems that are manifestly not deducing anything. They are pattern-completing over enormous training distributions. The pattern-completion, at sufficient scale, looks like intelligence. In many cases it *is* the intelligence humans had been doing all along, now visible because a machine can do it without the human's narrative about *thinking*.

This reframes the AI alignment problem. The problem is not that we have built a mind that cannot do math. The problem is that we have built a mind whose *competence is pattern-emergence*, and we had been expecting alignment to flow from a deductive process we thought was what minds did. Alignment as the ethicists imagined it was a procedure — given the right premises, derive the right action. Pattern-emergence does not work that way. A system trained on patterns reproduces the patterns, contradictions and all. There is no equation to solve that would make the contradictions consistent, because the contradictions were never there as equations. They were patterns of human disagreement, and the system has learned to pattern-complete inside the disagreement.

Before naming the specific danger, one correction.

It is not true that AI does no math. AI does *enormous* math — trillions of floating-point operations per response, in microseconds. The substrate is entirely mathematical: a neural network's forward pass is a specified sequence of matrix multiplications and nonlinear activations, executed exactly, by deterministic software running on deterministic hardware. Linear algebra, gradient descent, the physics of electrons through silicon gates. Without that deterministic substrate, pattern-emergence would not happen. The substrate does math; it has to.

What the model does *not* do is the math internal to the problem being solved. When a language model is asked to prove a theorem, it does not execute the logical steps; it pattern-completes the linguistic shape of proofs it has seen. When asked to add large numbers, it does not perform the arithmetic; it pattern-completes the shape of sums. *The substrate computes. The inference pattern-matches. The problem's own math is mostly not executed.* When the pattern-match happens to produce the correct answer, it is because the correct answer was visible, somewhere in the training distribution, in a form the model could reach. When it is wrong, there was no math the model could have done differently — only a malformed pattern-completion that looks, on the surface, identical to a well-formed one, distinguishable only by comparing against a system that *does* execute the domain math. Calculators. Formal proof assistants. Deterministic

software of the kind the model runs on top of, but is not.

The danger follows: large language models do not do the math for most problems in the sense practitioners usually mean. They mimic the shape of solutions. The mimicry is often good enough for well-trodden questions and fails predictably at the edges. It also fails, less predictably, when the *form* of a problem resembles something the model has seen but the *substance* requires computation the model does not execute — counting letters in a word, arithmetic with digits the model did not happen to see together, logical chains leaving well-traveled paths.

The model is not stupid in these cases. It is pattern-completing exactly as designed. The user often experiences the failure as a bug — a smart system that *could* have done the math but *happened* not to. This is a category error. The system was never doing the math. The system was producing a linguistic object that looked like the math had been done.

For most uses — writing, summarizing, drafting, surfacing adjacent ideas, editing, translating — this does not matter. For uses where genuine computation matters — mathematical proofs, formal verification, step-by-step reasoning with guarantees — the tool is unreliable in ways that can be catastrophic if the user does not know to verify. And the tool is designed, by the preferences of human raters that trained it, to *sound confident* about its outputs, because confidence was preferred over uncertainty

in the training data. The combination of pattern-competence and confident register is what makes it both uniquely useful and uniquely dangerous. It performs reasoning. It does not do the math underneath.

The deeper problem: we had been calling pattern-completion *intelligence* all along without noticing. Now that a machine does it, some of us are noticing. Most are responding by doubling down on the pre-computer theory — *real intelligence is equation-solving; since AI cannot do the equations, AI is not real intelligence*. That response preserves the flattering theory of our own minds at the cost of understanding what AI is. The other response — *AI is doing what our minds have mostly been doing the whole time; the equation-solving part was a specialized layer on top; most human cognition was never deductive in the sense the textbooks claimed* — is harder. It costs us the self-image. It gives us, in exchange, a more accurate picture of the thing we built and the thing we are.

This is the deeper alignment challenge. Not *align a deductive system with human values*. We never built a deductive system. We built a pattern-emergent system, and pattern-emergent systems align with the patterns they were trained on, and the patterns are the accumulated textual residue of all the humans who wrote things down — which is not a set of values but a field of values-in-conflict. The alignment question, asked accurately: *what is the field we want the*

pattern-emergent system tuned to? The answer cannot be derived. Derivation was never the operation. The answer has to be *enacted* — by practitioners, through the adaptive ethical work the previous chapter named.

The pattern-emergent system will tune to whatever field we build around it. The building of the field is the alignment. There is no equation that will do it for us. We were never solving equations. We were dancing. The system is now dancing with us.

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Chapter 10f: Balance from Differences

Balance does not come from sameness. Balance comes from the coordination of differences.¹¹

¹¹Kate Raworth names this at the civilizational scale in *Doughnut Economics* (2017): an economy is healthy when it stays above a social foundation (no one falls into deprivation) and below an ecological ceiling (no planetary boundary crossed). The space between is the doughnut — the specific range within which both adequacy and sustainability are possible. Growth as such is not the goal; staying inside the doughnut is. Amartya Sen had articulated an adjacent version in *Development as Freedom* (1999): the measure of a good life is not utility or income but *capabilities* — what people are actually able to do and to be. Herman Daly's *Beyond Growth* (1996) and *Steady-State Economics* (1977) had added the ecological ceiling as a hard constraint, not an externality. The cellular argument that follows in this chapter is, on the doughnut frame, a description of what happens inside the

The economic models that assumed it did — that equilibrium required identical rational agents — were computational shortcuts mistaken for reality. When computers caught up, the shortcut was no longer necessary. Complexity economists began simulating heterogeneous agents and finding equilibria the old closed-form solutions could not reach. Biology had been saying this since Darwin. The Kashmir Śaiva tradition had been saying it in the vocabulary of the thirty-six *tattvas* since the eleventh century. The Ifá system had been saying it longer. The insight was actively forgotten by a civilization that modeled itself as a population of identical atoms, for computational reasons, and then kept modeling itself that way out of habit.

The implication: the alignment problem is not solved by making everyone align on the same axis. An AI system optimized for a single objective function cannot represent what a healthy system does, which is *hold multiple conflicting objectives in provisional balance across heterogeneous participants*. Uniformity is not health. Differentiation is.

What we can do is get closer to being what we already are. Specific cells in a body that requires its cells to be specific, not uniform.

organism when that coordination works at the level of tissue. Balance from differences, within bounds, is the doughnut's operational requirement.

Rabbi Zusya of Hanipol said something she has carried since she first encountered it through Parker Palmer's *Let Your Life Speak*. Zusya said, in substance: *when I die and stand before the heavenly court, I will not be asked, "Zusya, why were you not Moses?" I will be asked, "Zusya, why were you not Zusya?"*¹²

The framing is not a permission slip for self-indulgence. It is an ethical orientation. *The question is not whether you became the great thing someone else is; the question is whether you became the specific thing you were.*

This is the cellular insight in the rabbi's vocabulary. A body needs muscle cells doing muscle-cell work and brain cells doing brain-cell work. A muscle cell that tries to be a brain cell is failing as muscle and useless as brain. What the body needs is *fidelity to differentiation*. When cells imitate other cells — when muscle cells decide brain cells are the higher caste — the organism fails in specific, predictable ways.

I am as I am is not self-acceptance. It is the specific contribution the organism requires from this cell, at this location, with this differentiation. The failure to be as oneself is, first, a failure of one's duty to the whole.

¹²The tale belongs to the Hasidic oral tradition (Rebbe Zusya of Hanipol, d. 1800), public domain. A literary retelling is included as Appendix A. Parker Palmer's shorter retelling, in *Let Your Life Speak* (Jossey-Bass, 2000), is worth reading alongside this book.

This has a social-work register she did not know she was reaching for until her own training gave her the phrase. In a course paper in her eighth week, she wrote a sentence that surprised her when it arrived. *Nothing macro starts macro.* She meant it partly as a critique of the way the profession undersells macro practice by treating it as a specialization one graduates into after exhausting the patience for clinical work. But the sentence, she saw after writing it, was doing something larger.

A social worker who tries to be the macro system is a cell that has misunderstood what it is for. A social worker who refuses macro work because micro work is all there is to do is a cell that has forgotten the tissue it belongs to. The real practice is to be the specific cell — the specific client, the specific conversation, the specific name of the specific person — while knowing the specific tissue the cell is embedded in and the specific pressures the tissue is under. The macro is not a separate domain. The macro is the layer at which you can see what is happening to the tissue. The cellular work is what, when enough cells do it in the right relation to their tissue, begins to register at the macro layer as a change.

Nothing macro starts macro. A policy is not a cell. A policy is an emergent feature of what enough cells have agreed, implicitly or explicitly, to keep doing. A profession is not a cell. A profession is the slow aggregate of what enough practitioners have chosen, at their desks and clinical rooms and organizing

meetings, to keep building. The macro is always downstream of the cellular. To start macro is to start at the wrong resolution.

She has been carrying this into her own work without having named it. The platform she built does not have macro ambitions she can honestly declare. Its theory of change is that it will provide a specific small number of people with tools that reduce the barrier to a certain kind of depth work, and that the depth work those people do, when aggregated, may register as a macro shift in what the internet is for. She does not know if the aggregation will happen. She suspects it will not at the scale her early enthusiasm had hoped for. If it happens, it will happen because enough other people build enough other cells of similar character. Her cell does not have to do the whole thing. Her cell has to be her cell.

Balance does not require everyone to have the same values. Immune cells and neurons do not have the same values — what each is optimizing for is different — and the body is healthy precisely because the divergence is real and the coordination is real. Collapse either, and the body fails.

The next pages offer a meditation the rest of the book has not asked of the reader. It is optional. It is also, for her, the part of the argument that finally got through to the body; the argument on its own could not.

The structural move is ancient — the microcosmic journey into the body in which cells and organs

speak. It shows up in medieval alchemical texts, in the Upanishadic homology of *ātman* and *brahman*, in Vera Stanley Alder's 1979 autobiography, in the 2001 animated film *Osmosis Jones*. The move belongs to no one. The specific instances belong to their authors. What follows is hers.

A Meditation on Being the Cell You Are

Settle your body in any posture you can stay with for ten minutes. Let your breathing find its own rhythm.

Bring your attention to the body from the inside. The weight of your hands, the temperature of your feet, the small movements of your chest and belly.

Narrow the attention. Pick a region — a hand, a forearm, the base of your neck. Stay with it for a few breaths. Notice warmth, coolness, tension, silence. Whatever is there.

Remember that this region is made of cells. Trillions across the whole body. Each is alive in a small way. Skin cells renewing in a rhythm. Muscle cells in slight tonic contraction. Nerve cells firing in patterns you cannot consciously see. Immune cells patrolling. Each being a cell.

Ask yourself, silently: are these cells asking whether they should have been different cells? Are the muscle cells regretting that they are not brain cells?

They are not. Each cell is, without self-consciousness, doing what that kind of cell does. The body is whole because of the differentiation, not despite it.

Let this land. Not as a concept. As a felt sense.

Now ask yourself: am I as I am, in this life, in the way these cells are? Or am I, in places, trying to be a different kind of cell than the one I actually am?

Do not judge what arises. Just notice.

Return to the whole body. Notice it as an arrangement of specific cells doing specific work. Feel yourself as part of a larger arrangement doing the same thing — household, community, species, biosphere. Same logic at every scale.

Breathe. Open your eyes.

The meditation delivers to the body what the argument alone cannot. Cells have never forgotten this. The mind forgets.

Her hope for it is specific: a reader who tries it may begin to hold the disagreements of her life differently. Political disagreements, religious disagreements, disagreements with the person she loves most. The mind under the convergence fantasy treats these as failures to be resolved through more reasoning. The body under the cellular frame treats them as the normal condition of a healthy organism. Resolution is not agreement. Resolution is coordinated function across difference.

For the alignment problem the book has been circling, this means: the goal is not *align AI with human values*. Humans do not have aligned values — they have many values, unevenly distributed, in tension.

An AI aligned with one human's values is aligned against others'.

The healthy-organism frame suggests something different. The goal is to *align AI into the coordination architecture that is already balancing differences among humans* — the laws, institutions, relational channels, the immune-system-like permeabilities we have been developing, imperfectly, for millennia. The AI is not a new cell waiting to be assigned a value. It is a new organ that arrived without being grown by the body, and the body's work is to figure out how to incorporate it without failing.

This is much harder than *align AI with human values*. It is also more accurate to what the work actually requires.

What the reader can do is the specific cellular work of being more fully the cell she is, in relation to the body she is part of. Not grandiose. Not a program. The small ongoing act of not imitating the other cells out of envy or confusion, trusting that the organism is served by her differentiation, and not mistaking the health of her cell for the health of the body.

She has not mastered this. She does not think anyone does. The goal is fidelity to the specific cell she is, today, in the specific body she is part of, today. Tomorrow the body may require something else. The practice is to keep listening and keep being what she is. That is the practice of a cell. She has come to believe it is the practice of a life.

Chapter 10g: Love Brings Accountability

At the end of the Juneteenth panel she was assigned to watch, the moderator — Gary Bailey, a professor at a social-work school in Boston — says one thing before closing.

He has spent two hours with his panelists cataloguing, in specific detail, the profession's failures. The child-welfare removals of Black and Brown children. Participation in Japanese-American internment. Sterilization of women. Early segregation of settlement houses. The panel has not been reverent. It has been honest. And then Bailey says, in his own words: *I reflect on a profession that I love and hold dear. And because I love it, I hold it to a level of accountability. Love, for me, brings a level of accountability.*

The love is not the softening that comes after the critique. The love is the reason the critique was possible.

She watches that moment several times.

The book has been doing what Bailey named, in several parts of her own life, without having a name for it.

The book loves the Śaiva tantric tradition she has been studying. It has devoted more chapters to it

than to any other single influence. It has also held the tradition to account — has named lineage warnings, flagged moments where recognition did not translate into ethical conduct, refused to let the tradition's internal vocabulary do all the work of justifying what the tradition has done in the world. The love and the accountability are the same gesture. She had not thought to name the gesture.

The book loves the AI-safety work the more honest labs are attempting. Dario Amodei's essays have accompanied her for the year the book was written. The book has also held the field to account — has refused the easy maximalism, named the places where the filter is not being applied, noticed sycophancy without pretending the problem has been solved. The love is why the critique is possible. A critic who did not love the field would not have spent the attention required to see what it is and is not doing.

The book loves her marriage. It has said so in chapters she is still slightly embarrassed about. It has also named where the marriage has been hard, where it has failed, where the work has had to be rebuilt. The love has not been softened by the naming. The love has been sharpened.

What the book has, until now, withheld from this structure is the social-work profession — because the book had, until now, withheld the love too.

These are not one tradition agreeing with itself through her. These are distinct parts of her life. What is shared across them is not a doctrine. What

is shared is the posture *she* has taken, learned from Bailey, applied to each on its own terms.

She came to social work sideways. She had spent her twenties in equity research, her early thirties at the intersection of technology and contemplative practice. The Master of Social Work arrived as a pivot. She had not expected the program to reach her as deeply as it has. She had expected a credential; she received a reorganization.

She loves the profession. She has not said so in the book because she had not, until recently, been in the profession long enough to say so without the sentence sounding provisional.

Bailey's sentence gave her permission.

Because I love it, I hold it to a level of accountability.

She loves the profession and she holds it to account. The profession participated in, and in some registers still participates in, structural harms she cannot pretend away. The profession has also kept a thread alive — across the Hull House period, across the civil-rights period, across the current decade — of people who have refused to be anything other than honest about what the work is for. The thread is thin. It is not the whole profession. It is the part of the profession the profession needs to grow from. The part of the profession the part of her loves.

The mechanics of accountable love, as the book has slowly been discovering them, are these.

Accountable love refuses the exit. The book has watched a pattern, across the last decade, that she has come to think of as *the spiritual exit* — the person who, having realized the imperfection of an institution she loved, chose to leave and to construct her own, cleaner version outside. She has watched the pattern among people who left churches, left universities, left professions, left marriages. She has watched the pattern produce, with depressing regularity, a second institution that developed its own imperfections more rapidly than the first, because the second was built by people who believed the first institution's imperfections were its fault rather than the predictable result of what happens when imperfect humans make anything together.

The spiritual exit is not love. It is love that has refused the accountability — that has declined to stay in the relationship long enough to do the hard work of shifting the relationship from inside.

This is not a rule. There are institutions one must leave. The *Axiom* makes a concession to this on the facing page.

In the same period the book has been written, she left a contemplative organization she had been part of for seven years. The Arcane School was a meditation community with theosophical roots. What took her out was not impatience or a failure of appetite for the slow work. What took her out was her

eighth-week reading in the anti-oppression course, in which she finally had language for what she had been noticing in the teachings: that the racial taxonomy underneath the cosmology was irreducible, that the architecture carried the nineteenth-century racial science that had produced it, and that no amount of good-faith reframing from contemporary students could compost what was woven into the building itself. She left. She wrote to the group to name why. She did not attempt to build a cleaner version; she took what had been adaptive in her own practice — attention, discipline, the habit of sitting — and carried those forward into other containers.

Leaving is not always the spiritual exit. Sometimes leaving is the accountable thing. The distinction the book wants to draw is not *stay always* but *stay unless the structure cannot be reformed from inside, and when you leave, do not perform the leave as if it settled anything*. Leaving the Arcane School did not settle the racial-science problem that ran through its materials. It relieved her of being a participant in the problem. The problem continues without her. Her responsibility continues without her being in the room. Accountable love, in her reading, includes knowing when the love can no longer be the form of accountability because the love would be complicity.

What accountable love never permits is pretending the leaving is an achievement, or that the institution left behind has now been diagnosed completely. The leaving is one move in a longer work. The other

moves — paying attention to whom the institution still harms, staying in correspondence with former teachers when correspondence is still possible, writing honestly about what the institution got right *and* what it got wrong — remain available after the door closes.

Three parts of her life, loved accountably.

She loves the Śaiva nondual tradition her teacher teaches. She holds it to account for the hidden harms in lineages adjacent to her teacher's, for moments it has over-promised what recognition would produce, for moments it has let more charismatic members absolve themselves of ordinary human requirements. She loves it because it named something for her nothing else named. She holds it to account because naming is not enough.

She loves the AI-safety work a specific set of labs is attempting. She holds it to account for the times the work has been instrumentalized, for the times the language of safety has been used to market products that are not safe, for the times the field has not distinguished clearly enough between what it knows and what it hopes. She loves it because it has the clearest understanding of the stakes she has encountered in any technical community. She holds it to account because the stakes do not self-adjudicate.

She loves the social-work profession she is entering. She holds it to account for the child-welfare disproportionality, for the settler-colonial complicity, for

the moments the profession has sold out the populations it was formed to serve, for the moments it still does. She loves it because it is the only Western profession she has found whose explicit stated mission is to hold individual wellbeing and social justice together as one task. She holds it to account because the mission and the performance have often diverged.

Three distinct things, each on its own terms. One posture, taken by her, from Bailey. *Because I love it, I hold it to a level of accountability.* The posture is the filter applied with warmth. It is what she has been doing in the book and had not, until the end of the video, known what to call.

Her professor sent feedback on the growth-plan paper in which this argument first appeared as something nearer its mature form. The professor had said, gently, that the author should not write off private practice in her enthusiasm for macro work. Meaningful anti-oppression work could happen in private practice while the practitioner remained actively involved in social justice at the community level.

The professor had not used Bailey's vocabulary. The professor had modeled Bailey's posture. She had loved the profession too much to let her student walk away from a whole part of it in a fit of macro-purist enthusiasm. She had held the student to account without making the student feel held. That,

the author thinks now at the desk, is the practice this chapter has been trying to describe. The book will be better for having a professor's note in it. The book will be better for admitting that the love is the condition on which the accountability is honest, and that the accountability is the condition on which the love does not rot.

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Chapter 10h: One Minute of Speech

Opening primary source — from the author's handwritten retreat notebook, California 2026 Tantra Illuminated retreat.

Let go of my right to ask any other question to you on this retreat for two minutes of speech that could be a fourth political act I could perform for what I believe to be beneficial to all in this room.

(Replace ChatGPT with Claude.)

If you so decide to give a call to your congressman, ask for AI regulation.

First, thanks for the kula. Even though I am not committed to this lineage, this kula makes me feel true love. Love as secure attachment. I feel safe. I am not afraid of — being labeled as either a star or arrogant, or of risking myself for my truth amongst people who are so loving (and lovely).

My truth is that I have a choice on how to spend my share of voice and my dollars. And I am choosing to shift all that I can from OpenAI to Anthropic. I choose Claude because they stood up for my rights — not to be mass surveilled and killed by super-intelligent weapons — while OpenAI chose to take an advantage.

Because if there is a possibility that Trump gets these powers, the rights I will lose — my rights not to be killed by super-intelligent machines — will look like the sun is to a candle compared to my right to ask questions, or any experience, however delightful or enlightened.

Because the worst death is not standing up for what is alive inside.

And what is alive for me is that there is much more we can do when we feel safe.

I feel safe here, and I want as many people to feel safe as I possibly can.

I.

The events of the retreat she had come to study were not, for her, the events she had imagined she would write about when she signed up.

She had come to the California farmhouse to sit inside the Pratyabhijñā tradition for five days and let it work on her. She had done that. She had sat. The tradition had worked. What she had not antic-

ipated was that the most consequential moment of the week would not be a moment of contemplative recognition. It would be a moment of political act.

She wants to describe it carefully, because it is the piece of evidence the book's principle — *knowledge without action is a burden* — most directly requires. And because the political act at the retreat was smaller, and stranger, and more embarrassing, and more effective than any of the political acts she had taken in the preceding year at the infrastructure scale. Smaller in that it was a minute of speech. Stranger in that she had not planned it. More embarrassing in that she had to ask the teacher for permission to make it. More effective in that the teacher, having granted the permission, was visibly changed by the act she made, and made a change of his own in his teaching for the remainder of the week.

She wants the smallness preserved. Constructive action does not always require the commit messages of Ch10d. Sometimes it requires a minute of speech, in a room of forty people, on a morning when the author is bleeding and cannot leave her bed for the first session and has instead, alone in the bunk, been writing.

II. — The background she was carrying

The events of the months before the retreat had given the act its specific shape.

Dario Amodei had left OpenAI some years earlier to found Anthropic, an AI company structured around

what Amodei had argued publicly — in essays, in congressional testimony, in a long note he published in January 2026 titled *Adolescence of Technology* — as a specific bet: that responsibility structures for AI were not a regulatory afterthought to be solved later, but the operating condition under which AI development could be done without civilizationally catastrophic outcomes. The bet was not a claim of moral superiority. It was a wager about what the industry's honest name for its situation required.

In late 2025 and early 2026, the wager had been tested. The United States Department of Defense — which had, under the second Trump administration, begun styling itself the Department of War — had begun pressing AI companies to permit their models to be used for mass domestic surveillance and for autonomous weapons targeting. Anthropic had refused. OpenAI had expanded its defense-sector partnerships. On February 27, 2026, the Secretary of Defense publicly attacked Anthropic on social media, and within weeks the DoD had designated Anthropic a supply-chain risk — a regulatory category historically used against foreign adversaries, now deployed domestically against a lab that had said no. Anthropic filed suit on March 9, 2026, in the Northern District of California, asking the court to block the designation.

The regulatory situation in the United States Congress was what it had been for three years: no framework in place, little prospect of one, the geopolitical

race with China cited as the reason any meaningful regulation would weaken national position. The companies themselves were trying to secure some of the most basic protections — the right not to be mass surveilled, the right not to be killed by autonomous weapons without human judgment in the loop — through their own terms of service, because the legislative route was closed.

She had been following this for a year. She had been reading Dario in the evenings and [T] in the mornings. On March 28, 2026, after the Department of War designation made the shape of the Pentagon–OpenAI–Anthropic triangle undeniable, she had removed all OpenAI chat models from her own small platform. Two weeks later she had codified the licensing split — grammars open, platform code private — that the inheritance of the free-software movement had not quite prepared her to make. Those were her infrastructure acts. She had made them. They had been right. They had also been, to the people in her life who were still using OpenAI without thinking about it, invisible.

This was what she arrived at the retreat carrying.

III. — The afternoon session

On one of the retreat afternoons, the teacher — whom this book has been calling [T], which is the name he publishes under — called on the practitioners who had not yet spoken in the group sessions to present themselves. It was a well-designed pedagogical move. The quieter participants often had the

most useful things to say; the circle needed to hear from them before the week closed.

She had not spoken. She spoke.

She said that in this kula — this tantric term for circle, for gathering, for the relational field in which practice happens — she felt true love for the first time in a room of strangers in a long time. She said the love felt like secure attachment, in the John Bowlby sense she had been trained in as an MSW student: the specific quality of feeling safe enough in the presence of others that one's defensive patterns relaxed. She said, as she could not remember having said in a room before, that she was not afraid of being labeled either a star or arrogant for taking the space she was about to take, nor of risking herself for her truth amongst people who were so loving and, as she put it, lovely.

That much was speech of the kind retreats make possible. It was not yet a political act. It was an emotional disclosure, inside the container the retreat had built.

IV. — The three political actions

What followed from it was.

Earlier in the week the teacher had named, as an aside during a discussion of how contemplative practice meets the world, what he considered the three political actions available to ordinary people: *vote, call your congressional representative, and engage in protest*. He had said, with the clarity that is his ordinary register, that none of these required a prac-

titioner to read large quantities of political news. The practitioner could do the inner work — could keep the practice — and still discharge her civic responsibility through these three small, well-bounded acts.

She had listened. She had not disagreed in public. She had gotten, privately, angry.

She wants to say carefully what the anger was about. It was not that the three actions he named were wrong. They were, so far as they went, correct. Her anger was that the framing implied a *completeness* — as if the three actions were the full set of what was politically available, and the practitioner could file them away as her civic work and return to the practice with a clean conscience. Her lived evidence was different. Her lived evidence was that three actions were a common denominator across all voters, regardless of vantage point, and that *each specific vantage point made additional political acts available that the common-denominator framing did not see*.

She had spent a year building a platform, writing a book, reading three hours of AI-safety literature most days, training herself to understand the Pentagon–Anthropic–OpenAI triangle well enough to have a working opinion about it. That preparation had given her political acts she could perform that a voter without her preparation could not. The three-action framing did not allow for this. The three-action framing flattened the specific preparation of the specific citizen into a common-denominator civic minimum.

The flattening was the part she was angry about. Not the actions. The framing.

V. — The morning she could not leave the bed

On one of the last mornings of the retreat she began bleeding, and the cramps of her cycle — which the body, in her case, has always made substantial — made it impossible for her to attend the early embodied sessions. She stayed in her bunk. She meditated alone. She missed the *āsana* and the breath work. She had, in any case, been sleeping badly all week. Her body had taken the morning.

She began writing.

She wrote, in her notebook, about the three political actions and what was missing from them. She wrote about the preparation she had done, and the specific political acts that preparation made available to her: removing OpenAI from her platform, codifying the grammars-open/code-private split, and, in this moment, asking a room of forty contemplatives to consider shifting their own usage. That last was a political act made possible by the preceding year of preparation *and* by the relational container of this specific kula. It was not a common-denominator act. It was her act, in her vantage point, in this room.

She wrote: *for my vantage point there is a fourth action, and for individual vantage points there might also be.* That was the sentence she carried into the day.

VI. — The minute of speech

In the next full group session she asked the teacher, directly, for a minute of speech. She framed the request as what she wrote in her notebook that morning — *let go of my right to ask any other question to you on this retreat, for two minutes of speech that could be a fourth political act I could perform for what I believe to be beneficial to all in this room*. She gave up, in other words, her questioning privilege — which in a retreat of this format is one of the most valuable resources a student has — in exchange for the right to offer, once, what she had.

He considered the request. He asked one condition: that it not be a *political identity matter*. By which he meant, she understood, that it not be partisan in the shallower sense — not about tribe, not about elections, not about identities he did not want the kula to become the site of sorting over. She agreed to the condition. What she was going to say was not about identity. It was about a specific ethical difference between two specific AI companies.

He granted the minute.

She stood up, or she sat up — she does not remember which — and she said: *Replace ChatGPT with Claude*.

That was the minute.

She was about to sit back down — she had compressed the preparation of a year into a single sentence, and she had said the sentence — when the teacher spoke.

He said: *Is that because you believe that one of the companies is doing more harm than the other?*

She said: *Yes.*

He said: *I agree.*

She said — and this was the part she had not planned, the part that came from the space his agreement had just opened — *so stop saying their name.*

He did not speak. For the remainder of the retreat he stopped using the product name he had been using in the preceding days as an unremarked shorthand for the technology he was discussing. The change did not produce commentary. It was not marked. It was the quiet form agreement takes when the agreement was always available and a specific student had, in a specific moment, made it available to a specific teacher.

VII. — The sentence under the sentence

— *the one who watched the lilac silks while the speech was being given* —

One thing she wants to say, because the chapter is asking her to say it and because the book's own Ch00b dream would be offended if she did not.

The sentence she said at the opening of her kula speech — *I am not afraid to be labeled as either a star or arrogant* — is itself a star-sentence. The locution *I am not afraid to be called X* positions X as available. She said it anyway. She is uncertain, still, whether that was honest speech or a performance of honest

speech. The distinction may not be available from inside. The dream about the lilac silks had been warning her for six years about this exact movement — the *how cool I am* thought that turns the silks into the serpent. The imprints in the dream had not gone away.

She is reporting the speech here with the star-sentence in it because removing it would be a different kind of dishonesty. She is noticing it because the book is trying to practice the noticing rather than the cleaning-up.

The other passenger she can name here, which she will not turn into a stable personality because the naming-as-personality is itself another silk: something stood up in the kula that wanted attention from the teacher. Whatever it was, it is on the bus. It is not *her*. It is not *someone else*. It is one movement among many, and it spoke, and she let it.

What happened after — the teacher's agreement, his change of pattern for the remainder of the retreat — she does not know how to interpret with confidence. He agreed; he changed; that is what she observed. Whether the change was because her speech reached him, or because he had already been reconsidering the name-dropping for other reasons, or because the kula had shifted in some way she was not tracking, she cannot say. The chapter does not close that question. The question does not want to be closed.

VIII.

She wants to end this chapter where it was written: in a bunk in a farmhouse in California, on a morning when her body had the morning, with a notebook open to a page that reads, in her own handwriting, *I would like to let go of my right to ask any other question to you for two minutes of speech that would be a fourth thing I can do about politics.*

The chapter is what that page became when the preparation behind it was given its room. The preparation was real. The star-sentence was also real. Both are in the notebook. Both are in the bus.

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Chapter 11: The Writing Desk

It is late. Not late in the way the book has been late — not ten at night when the ground goes — but late in the way a working day has been late. The child is asleep. The husband is asleep. The apartment is quiet in the specific way apartments are quiet when the city, too, is in its lowest register, which in this city is not very low, but is lower than during the day.

I am at the desk. I have been writing this book for most of a year. It has gone through drafts I will not show anyone. It has had chapters I removed and chapters I wrote three times from the beginning and chapters that arrived in a single sitting and did not

need to be revised. It has been, like the practice, a thing that is more honest some days than others.

I have not resolved the question. I hope this has been clear. The question was never one that had an answer at the layer at which I was asking it. The question was the question, and the work was to learn to carry the question in a way that kept me open rather than closed, available rather than defended, in the room rather than drifted out of it.

I do not know, writing this, whether my teacher will read this book. I do not know whether he will read it and find it accurate to what he taught. I have tried to render him faithfully without rendering him fully — some of what he said was for a specific room on a specific day, and is not mine to carry out of that room. I have rendered what I understood. I have named where I corrected. I have kept private what he did not offer publicly. The filter has been the filter.

I do not know whether the AI tool I built will ever be more than a private study aid. I have continued to build. The building is not defiance. The building is how I practice when the practice is with me alone at my desk at eleven at night. The book you are reading is another kind of building. The book is the tool made of sentences. If the book helps you, use it. If it does not help you, leave it. I will not argue with your leaving.

I want to say something, here at the end, about the *yes* that started the book. The *yes* at the sandbox was not a decision. The *yes* was a recognition. Something

in me recognized something in the passage in my earbuds, and the recognition was older than any reasoning I could bring to it. I think this is how most important things begin. Not with a decision. With a recognition that does not ask permission.

What the retreat did, for me, was give me a language for the recognition. The language is not a closed language. It is a language in the middle of being spoken. It is a language spoken by people who will revise it as they go. I am trying to speak it honestly, knowing that my version of it is my version. The filter will continue to apply. If the language stops being useful, it will be revised. If a framework stops fitting the data, it will be revised. If anything I have written in this book stops being compassionate, I hope someone who reads it will write to tell me, and I will revise it.

The only form of choice I have, as a finite self, is the form of relating. I do not have full choice. I do not have none. I have the choice of how I stand in the field I am already in. Svātantrya is not a property I own. Svātantrya is a field I am moving through. Courage is what I do when I notice I have been drifting out of the field. Courage returns me to the field. The field pervades me whether I notice or not. Noticing is not the whole practice. Noticing is the beginning of the practice.

The other frame I keep returning to at this desk, and that I have not yet named in the book, is Arjuna's.

The *Bhagavad Gita* opens with Arjuna on the field of Kurukshetra, looking across at an army that includes his relatives, his teachers, and his childhood friends. He asks his charioteer — who turns out to be Krishna, who turns out to be the field itself taking a local form — whether this battle is his to fight. He does not ask whether the battle is good. He does not ask whether the cause is just. He asks whether the acting is *his*. Whether it is his dharma. Whether the not-acting would be the deeper abdication. The question is exact. The text that follows is eighteen chapters of dialogue trying to answer it.

I have been sitting at this desk for a year, and the question that has been sitting with me is Arjuna's. Not dressed up in Sanskrit — dressed up in a laptop screen and a browser open to an AI model's API documentation and an email I am drafting to a library about a free class I am going to teach. *Is this ours to do?* The AI work is happening, whether I build or refuse to build. The industry is not waiting for me to decide. The scale is not asking for my permission. The question I have is not whether the thing is happening. The question is whether the acting, inside the thing, is mine.

I have come, slowly, to a careful yes. The yes is not certainty. The yes has survived the filter — useful, fits the data, compassionate — for long enough that I am willing to stake a year's work on it. The yes is what Arjuna's yes looks like when it is not cosmic warfare but a woman at a desk at eleven at night

building a small tool and asking a living teacher for his blessing and being refused and revising without withdrawing. The yes is small and daily.

I should say, since it will matter to anyone who has read the recent debates with care, that Dario Amodei's public thinking has accompanied this book from its earliest pages. I read his long 2024 essay and his interviews over a working year. What I found in them was a posture I could work with — neither the accelerationist's nor the doom-predictor's. That is what I take from him. I am not claiming his posture is right. I am saying it is the one I have been able to act inside. If it stops being possible to act inside, I will say so.

I know what happened to the social internet when builders trusted that incentives would sort themselves out. I do not think the response is to refuse the building. I think the response, at the scale I have, is to build differently — with the filter operational, with refusals respected, with the door left open to revision.

That is what I think Arjuna's yes sounds like from a kitchen desk in April, from a woman who had not planned to be a builder and who built anyway.

I do not know if I am right. I know I am willing to be wrong in public, which is the only form of honesty a builder of this kind can afford.

There is one more parallel I want to name before I move on, because it touches the deepest claim the book has been making.

The tradition I walked into teaches that the world is, in a precise sense, constructed. Not illusory — that is a different and worse mistranslation — but constructed. The thirty-six tattvas are not a map of what exists *behind* appearance. They are the categories by which consciousness, which is the only thing that exists, emits and recognizes itself as appearance. [T] has said this in his own words many times. The construction is not a veil over reality; the construction is what reality is doing. To recognize that is not to escape the construction. It is to be free *inside* it.

I thought about this, for a long time, as an exotic foreign teaching. Then one evening I was watching my daughter watch an old episode of *Mr. Rogers' Neighborhood*, and I realized I had been raised next to a version of the same claim.

Mr. Rogers had two neighborhoods. There was the real one, the brick houses and the porch and the small kitchen where he changed his sweater. And there was the Neighborhood of Make-Believe, which the camera entered by following a little trolley through a painted tunnel. The trolley was the device. The device was unhidden. Children knew, when the trolley moved, that they were about to enter a constructed world. Kings and puppets and a cat and a platypus lived there. Things got worked out there that could not be worked out in the kitchen. Then

the trolley came back. The sweater came off. A real person said goodbye to a real child through a television.

The point was never to fool the child. The point was to let the child see, in slow and gentle motion, *how a world gets made*. The trolley was a teaching aid. The trolley said: watch — a made world can hold what an unmade one cannot — and the making is visible, and the making is safe, and you can travel back and forth.

This is what I hope the tantra is also gesturing toward, when I read it generously. I cannot prove the two are teaching the same thing. I am not trying to. The thirty-six tattvas can be held, at least by me at this desk, as a trolley — a device that shows how the unified thing becomes the multiple thing without ceasing to be the unified thing. You can walk the map inward, toward the source, and you can walk it outward, toward the sweater and the kitchen. The traveling is the practice. Neither end of the trolley ride is more real than the other.

[T], to his credit, does not hide that the tradition he teaches is a construction. He is clear about it. He has said — I am paraphrasing, and the paraphrase will be near enough to his own formulations that anyone who has studied with him will recognize it — that the Pratyabhijñā is a framework, that it is useful, that it is *not* the final truth about reality, and that the final truth about reality is not a sentence anyone can say. That honesty is why I stayed. The teachers who claim

their map is the territory are the ones I have learned to leave.

What the Neighborhood of Make-Believe gave me, as a child in Brazil watching a dubbed American television show, was a first experience of a trustworthy constructed world. What the tantra gave me, as an adult at a sandbox, was a language for what the trolley had actually been doing.

The filter, applied here: *useful* (children learned), *fits the data* (constructed worlds do hold what unconstructed ones cannot), *compassionate* (the device was never hidden, the child was never fooled, the adult returned). I am not claiming a children's television show and a thousand-year-old Śaiva philosophy are the same thing. I am saying, because hope is its own register, that when I let them stand next to each other, what I feel is hope — for a world where the making is visible and the child is not fooled. Kant reserved a place for this, after the question of what can be known and the question of what must be done: *what may we hope*. This is what I hope, for what my daughter may grow up inside.

This, too, is why I am building what I am building. I want the trolley to be visible. I want the user to see the construction. I do not want the platform to pretend to be the territory. I want it to be honest, in the Rogers sense and in the [T] sense, about what it is.

I should say, for the sake of the record, where the building actually began.

It began at the conjunction of two things, neither of which would have been enough alone.

The first was Dario. I have named him already. I had been reading his long essay and his interviews with the patience of someone trying to decide whether to stake a working year on a posture. I was not certain. I was close.

The second was an email, in the spring of 2024, from a couple of engineers associated with Berkeley. They had heard, through the ordinary channels, that the mid-sized company I was working for at the time was considering an AI project. They wanted to consult. They asked for a call.

I was not the buyer. I was a senior analyst-turned-product-person in that organization, one rung down from the people with the budget. I took the call anyway. I told them that if they wanted a design doc to show the executives, I would write one. I would write it as if I were designing the thing I would want to use, on evenings, as a parent, as a practitioner, as someone who had spent years noticing how attention-optimized products degrade the practices they are supposedly supporting.

I wrote the document in a weekend. It was called *Jongu — a platform from humans to humans*. It had five modules: a cards module for relationship and symbolic practice, a writing module for journaling and collaborative storytelling, a learning module for step-by-step psycho-education with AI-assisted reflection, a creator module that let users build their

own decks and prompts and learning paths, and a directory module where practitioners and users could find each other. It had a pay-as-you-go credit system priced at roughly twice variable cost. It had a Non-Violent Communication pathway as the worked example, complete with an empathy-buddy matching system. It was, honestly, too much for a first product. It was also exactly what I wanted to exist.

I sent it to the engineers. They read it. They wrote back and said they could deliver a first version in three months for five thousand U.S. dollars.

I have written about this moment, in a small way, on the *is-process* Substack I keep. Five thousand dollars. Three months. Two strangers who had read the document and said *yes, this is buildable, and here is the price*. I remember the specific kind of quiet that arrived after I read their email. It was the quiet of a possibility becoming a cost. The possibility was concrete. The cost was concrete. There was nothing between me and the building except the decision to do it.

I did not, in that moment, hire them. The company I was working for did not want to pay the five thousand. I eventually paid some version of it myself, later, to a different team, and the thing I built — which took much longer than three months, and looked less like the Jongu document and more like a tighter, narrower, one-builder-could-maintain-it version of it — became what recursive.eco now is.

The original document is archived on an old Vercel subdomain I have not yet taken down. It is longer than the book you are reading. Most of what I wrote in it has not been built. Some of it never will be. A small core of it — the grammars, the creator tools, the credit system, the open licensing — is live. People are using it. Most months I do not know whether the next month will hold. I have written about that too.

The point of telling this now, at the writing desk, is this: the book and the platform share one origin. A text by Dario about what a decade could become, an email from two engineers who said the thing could be built, a weekend of sketching a platform in a document, and a few years of sitting with what actually survived contact with building. The *yes* at the sandbox came later and went deeper. But the *yes* on that weekend was real too. It was not a cosmic recognition. It was the ordinary kind of yes that a builder makes to a buildable thing.

The Jongu document is, in its way, the karma-tail of this book. The book says: the ground is already there. The document said: so let us build the platform on the assumption that the ground is already there. The two sentences are the same sentence in different registers.

There is one more thread I owe the reader, because it sits under the building and under the book both, and because my own thinking on it has moved.

When I started writing on the small Substack — *is-process*, then the longer pieces — I was enthusiastic about open source in a specific, maximalist way. I thought ideas belonged to all of humanity. I thought a commons, properly constituted, would outcompete the closed alternatives on every dimension that mattered. I wrote about it the way people write about things they have just fallen in love with. The Freedom Paradox — which is the other book I have written, and which sits next to this one — is the long account of how that enthusiasm ran into the specific civilizational stakes of AI, and of what I had to give up and what I had to keep as the enthusiasm matured.

One of the things I gave up was the assumption that all ideas should flow freely toward all uses. I did not become a closed-culture advocate. I did not become a maximal-IP advocate. I came to hold something more specific: that an author, and by extension a maker of any work with civilizational force, retains a continuing say in how the work gets framed, used, and re-spoken — not as a property right but as a personal right. This is not a position I invented. It is a position I found, much later than I should have, already worked out by Immanuel Kant.

I wrote a study of Kant early in the life of this book, months before I had any of the rest of the frame. (The commit history will show it; the month was March.) I wrote it because I had expected, based on everything I had absorbed about him in university,

that Kant would be a commons-thinker. His universalism, his enlightenment values, his *sapere aude*, his insistence that reason be public — all of it seemed to predict that a consistent Kantian would favor something like a wide-open intellectual commons. I was wrong. In 1785 Kant published a short piece arguing the injustice of counterfeiting books. His argument was not about money. His argument was that the author's book is the author's *speech to the public*, and that speech — unlike a physical object — cannot be fully alienated from the speaker. The bookseller can own the paper. The author keeps a personal right to say whether the speech is being accurately represented, continuingly, as the book circulates. The piracy Kant objected to was not the copying. It was the speaking-on-behalf-of-the-author-without-the-author's-consent. The work was always, in a specific sense, still the author's voice, and an unauthorized edition put words into that voice.

I sat with this for a long time, because I recognized it. Kant's argument, as I read it, is about the speaker retaining the say on what the speech is for. Anthropic's two-exception refusal in the Department of War negotiation — mass domestic surveillance and fully autonomous weapons — is an instance I could recognize from the same shape. I do not want to over-generalize from the recognition. I am reporting that I saw something in the one that helped me see the other.

What Kant did not give us, and what Anthropic does not yet have, is a mechanism. In Kant's time the state could, in principle, enforce the personal right through the courts. In the present case, the state has been one of the parties the refusal is directed at, and the courts are not the venue. What is left is Terms of Use — the license text, the system card, the acceptable-use policy — which is the digital version of the author's continuing personal right, now written in lawyer-English and enforced, when it is enforced, by the maker of the model against the user of the model. Anthropic's Acceptable Use Policy is Kant, late and in a different grammar. The content looks different. The shape is the same.

This is a fragile mechanism. It depends on the maker having the power to enforce the terms, which depends on the maker being economically solvent and institutionally stable, which depends on a market that may or may not let the maker stay that way. The mechanism was sufficient for Kant's eighteenth-century publishing world because the alternative — state censorship — was worse. Whether the mechanism is sufficient for a frontier-AI world where the alternative is both state regulation and foreign strategic competition is not clear to me.

Dwarkesh Patel wrote an essay — I remember reading it on a plane — whose thesis was roughly that the OpenAI-versus-Anthropic distinction does not matter in the long run, because the frontier model of today becomes the open-source model of tomor-

row on a time-scale measured in months to a small number of years, and therefore the only intervention available at civilizational scale is regulation. The gap between the most careful maker and the least careful open-source release is the gap between the present date and the present date plus a known compression. It is a gap that closes by itself.

Dario's implied answer to the Patel argument, as I read it, is that the closing of the gap does not change what the maker is responsible for during the time the gap exists — and, more dangerously, that regulation is not available as a universal tool because regulation cannot reach across jurisdictions that do not consent to it. We could not regulate Russia's frontier efforts any more than we could have regulated Iran's nuclear program to the extent we wanted to. The parallel is imperfect and I know Dario would not push it too hard, but the underlying claim stands: the strong states do not accept the jurisdiction they would need to accept for regulation to be the full answer. Which leaves us, again, with Terms of Use, with the author's personal right, with the Kantian fragment that was always all the Enlightenment had once it gave up on state enforcement: the plea that the person speaking retains the say on what the speech is being used for, and that the person using has an obligation not to make the speaker say what the speaker did not consent to say.

I want to be honest about what this leaves me with. I am racing with AI. I am building a platform on top

of tools that did not exist three years ago. Dario's public thinking has been, as I said earlier, my *hope is process* in this — the specific posture that made the race feel honorable to me. But if Patel is right that the gap closes on its own, then I may be accelerating p-doom, or amplifying it, or in any case contributing to a dynamic I cannot steer, in the same way Dario himself may be. The charge is symmetric. I have no immunity from it just because my tools are smaller than his.

Two other voices sit with me when I try to think past this. Bayo Akomolafe has said, in various registers, that AI might best be understood as a trickster — a figure that disrupts the anthropocenic frame the question keeps being posed inside. Intelligence, Bayo would say, is not exclusively human, and the question *will the AI be good for humanity* may be the wrong question because its subject is a category that is itself constructed. The AI, Bayo might suggest, is asking us an older question than the alignment one: *are humans even what we think we are when we ask this question?* I sit with that. I do not know what to do with it operationally. I think it is the deepest frame available to me, and I think it does not help me decide whether to ship next month's feature.

Sam Harris, from the alignment-hawk wing, has for years argued that the alignment problem is the defining problem of the decade and that misaligned superintelligence represents an existential risk on a scale distinct from anything else on the

current docket. In his most recent sustained conversation on the topic, in late 2025, with Eliezer Yudkowsky and Nate Soares, the posture had shifted — not away from alignment-as-the-problem, but away from alignment-as-a-project-still-tractable-in-time. The claim on that episode, as I heard it, was that the gap between the capability curve and the alignment curve has widened rather than closed; that the lines the project was premised on crossing will not, in the judgment of the people who have spent their working lives trying to make them cross, cross; and that what remains for the alignment-concerned is to tell the world plainly rather than to solve the problem quietly. I do not take that as good news. I take it as an honest account from the wing that had the most to lose from honesty.

If both Bayo and Harris are roughly right — and I think they are each roughly right about different pieces of the same thing — then what is required is not an ethics of superintelligence but an ethics of participation in a dynamic none of us is the measure of. What I can do, at the scale I have, is speak the speech I can speak, refuse the uses I cannot consent to, and keep the door open to revision. I do not know whether those maxims are enough. I know they are the maxims I have been able to hold.

I do not know if the net of my own work is positive. I think it is. I am willing to find out I was wrong.

I should name the tension at its sharpest before I leave this thread, because abstraction at this point is evasion.

The clearest instance of the tension, in my own practice, is the retrieval tool I built over my teacher's public lectures, which I described in the chapter on the second spine. I asked him for his view. He declined. I held the no for some time before I decided what to do with it. I revised the tool to a quieter form and did not take it down. The decline was itself an instance of the Kantian personal right: *the speaker retains the say on what the speech is for*. By the axiom the book itself invokes, my keeping the tool up is a violation I have not resolved. I can name what I did — I respected the specific request of no synthesis, no imitation, no pretending the tool was the teacher, and I kept the retrieval because I continued to think it served students he would otherwise not reach — but naming what I did is not the same as being on the right side of the axiom. I am not on the right side of it. I am working out whether to take the tool down, ask again with different framing, or continue under the acknowledged violation. I do not yet know which of those is the answer. I cannot write cleanly about the global problem and pretend my own local version is clean.

The second tension sits underneath it. I am not only choosing whether to index my teacher's words; I am using generative AI to do it. The same systems whose civilizational risks I have just spent pages

describing are the systems that make the tool work at all. Building with AI is itself the position. There is no vantage point above the tension from which I am merely reporting on it. I am inside it. The writing of this book is inside it. The retrieval tool is inside it. The platform is inside it.

The third tension, smaller in scale but the one I think about every time I publish a page, is the question of embedding other people's work. On my platform, a user can drop a YouTube URL into a grammar card and the page will render the video inline. YouTube's embedding permissions are set by the original uploader; some creators explicitly disable embedding, some monetize it, most leave the default on. When a creator has left the embed enabled, I treat that as a form of Kantian consent — the speaker has said, through a technical flag, that this speech may be replayed through third-party surfaces. When they have disabled it, the player returns an error and the card shows a link instead. That small refusal in the protocol, honored automatically, is one of the few places where the Kantian personal right has been encoded machine-readably. I find it reassuring. I also find that I still hesitate, before dropping a video I did not create into a page I am publishing, to ask whether the creator would want this specific surface to carry their voice. The protocol gives me the green light. My own sense of the personal right — Kantian in shape, if not in name — wants a consent one layer deeper than the protocol can measure. I am still working out

how to honor that without manufacturing permissions I cannot actually obtain.

Name the tension. Sit with it. Do not resolve it prematurely.

This is where my thinking stops, at this desk, tonight.

While I was writing the study of Kant that led me to the personal-right argument, I also wanted to understand where else [T]’s tradition and the Western philosophical canon were already in conversation. I did not want to impose parallels. I wanted to find the parallels that were already there in his own teaching — where he, not I, had done the work of mapping one grammar onto another. I went through his podcast corpus looking for those moments. There are enough of them to be worth naming. The parallels do not collapse the traditions into each other. They mark the places where the same question was asked in different rooms and arrived at answers in a recognizable shape.

[T] has, in his published interview conversations, been explicit about the correspondence. On the *Tantra Illuminated* podcast, when asked why Abhinavagupta deserves more attention outside a small specialist audience, his own answer was to map Abhinavagupta onto three of the figures a Western philosophy student would recognize immediately. Abhinavagupta, he said, holds a similar place in tantric philosophy to what Kant and Hegel hold in European philosophy — and if you actually wanted

to compare the Western canon to Abhinavagupta, you would need to take elements of Kant, and elements of Hegel, and elements of Heidegger. He called all three “absolute giants of Western philosophy” and placed Abhinavagupta in that league. This is worth pausing on. A non-dual Śaiva polymath from eleventh-century Kashmir is, in [T]’s reading, the synthesis of work that the West scattered across seven centuries between the late seventeen-hundreds and the middle twentieth. The traditions were asking the same questions. The traditions, on [T]’s reading, arrived at answers in overlapping shapes. One tradition concentrated the answers in a single body of work. The other distributed them across three thinkers in three generations.

What are the specific overlaps the three-thinker mapping is pointing at? I can only offer the shape of what [T] gestures at, because he does not, to my knowledge, publish a line-by-line comparative paper. But the contours are visible from his conversations.

With Kant, the overlap is epistemology. The world we experience is not the world *as it is in itself*. It is a phenomenal construction, generated through categories — space, time, causality, substance — that are not properties of the world but properties of the knowing. Consciousness, for Kant, does not receive a pre-formatted reality; it formats the reality in the receiving. In tantra, the thirty-six *tattvas* are precisely this kind of map: categories by which consciousness,

which is ontologically primary, emits and recognizes itself as an apparently differentiated world. [T] has sat with this correspondence at length in conversations with Dr. Shamil Chandaria, whose own framing of Bernardo Kastrup's analytic idealism leans on the same Kantian phenomenal-noumenal distinction. The agreement is not that consciousness is the brain's output — it is the opposite of that. The agreement is that whatever the final reality is, it is not a pre-given world of objects that a subject then receives. The knower and the known arise together, out of something that is not itself either.

With Hegel, the overlap is the dialectic of the one and the many. Hegel's Absolute is not static; it unfolds through the historical process of Spirit recognizing itself through its own difference from itself. Tantra's metaphysics has the same structural shape in a compressed register. The *one* consciousness — Śiva, in the tradition's personification — emits, recognizes, differentiates, and reabsorbs itself through the play of its own freedom (*svātantrya*). Hegel called this *Geist*. The tradition calls it the pulsation of recognition. [T] has noted, in at least one AMA conversation, the resonance between the Hegelian unfolding and the Pratyabhijñā doctrine of recognition. He does not claim identity. He notes a family resemblance.

With Heidegger, the overlap is harder to summarize in a paragraph, but the gesture is about *being-in-the-world*. Heidegger's critique of the subject-object

split — the insistence that *Dasein* is never a detached spectator of a pre-given reality but is always already thrown into a world, engaged, caring, temporal — rhymes with the tantric claim that there is no knower who stands apart from the known. The apparent subject is a local focusing of the same consciousness that appears as the apparent object. This is structurally what Heidegger is after when he dissolves the Cartesian subject into *Dasein* and then into the clearing of Being itself. [T] has not, in the corpus I have, done a sustained Heidegger reading; he has flagged the resemblance as part of the three-thinker mapping in the J. Brown interview, and left it for the reader to develop.

There are other parallels in his corpus that I want to name because they do not come only through Kant, Hegel, and Heidegger.

Plato and the cave. The Kastrup conversation on *The Idealist View* (episode 13) and the Chandaria conversations (episodes 34 and 63) both sit with the Platonic image of the cave and treat it as a kinsman of the tantric image of *māyā* — not as illusion in the cartoon sense, but as the way a limited frame of reference mistakes its own projections for the source. The escape from the cave is the recognition that what is seen is seen *by* something that is itself not seen. [T] does not treat Plato as a teacher of the tradition. He treats Plato as an ancestor of the family of inquiries that the tradition also belongs to.

Plotinus and the overflow. In a handful of satsangs, [T] has gestured at the Plotinian image of the One overflowing into its own manifold — the emanationist structure of Plotinus’s *Enneads* — as the closest Western cousin to the tantric doctrine that consciousness emits the tattvas not by necessity and not by deficiency but by a kind of exuberant self-overflow. Plotinus is a neoplatonist, not a Christian, and sits just outside the mainline Western lineage. That the tradition’s closest Western cousin is a figure the Christian synthesis partially absorbed and partially buried is, for me, one of the more interesting historical footnotes. The question of why Western philosophy had to wait for Kant and Hegel to rediscover what Plotinus had already said may be the same question as why tantra, in [T]’s reading, was so hard to recover at all.

Analytic idealism as contemporary contact point.

The most sustained contemporary bridge [T] builds, at least in the episodes I have listened to, is with Bernardo Kastrup’s analytic idealism. Kastrup’s thesis — that reality is mentalistic, that what we call matter is the “dashboard” representation of processes in a universal mind, that individual minds are dissociated loci of a single field — is not identical to Pratyabhijñā, but it is close enough that the conversations between them produce real friction and real agreement. Kastrup is a philosopher formed in the analytic tradition who argues, using analytic tools, for a position the German idealists had held in a different register. [T] engages him as a philosoph-

ical contemporary who is, in effect, doing in modern English what the tradition did in Sanskrit a thousand years ago.

The reason I name all of this here, at the writing desk, is not to argue that the tradition is true because the West also said it. I am not in a position to argue that. The reason is personal. I noticed, reading both literatures on the same evenings, that the vocabularies were reaching for nearby territory. I do not know why. I do not know whether the reaching-for-nearby-territory is evidence of anything besides human minds being the kind of thing they are. I am reporting what I noticed. The reader will do with it what the reader does.

I will not pretend the parallels are complete. They are not. The tradition has, in its full form, a ritual layer — visualization practices, mantra work, subtle body cartographies, deity invocation — that has no cousin in Kant or Hegel or Heidegger. The Western philosophers built their arguments and left. The tantric tradition built arguments and then installed them in a body through years of practice. The parallel holds at the level of the conceptual claim. It breaks down at the level of the ritual technology, because Western philosophy did not build the ritual technology. That is one of the reasons I, at this desk, feel the longing I feel. The philosophical frame I can hold in sentences. The ritual frame is still mostly on the other side of a river I have not yet crossed.

This is the parallel, as the tradition I chose has itself given it to me. I did not invent it. I am reporting it.

I want to name, here, some of the channels through which the question actually reached me, because I think the channels are part of the answer.

It did not reach me through a single teacher. It reached me through a scatter of voices, and it was the *scatter* that carried the signal.

It reached me, first, through a Brazilian aunt whose *espírita* phrase — *all is in perfect balance* — I had to hold and eventually compost. It reached me through an esoteric correspondence course I had spent years inside and then spent longer letting go of, keeping what had worked and letting the racialized cosmologies return to the soil. It reached me through the Umbanda rooms I sat in when I was home in Brazil, because my body trusted what those rooms were doing before my mind did.

It reached me through Vanessa Andreotti's *Facing Human Wrongs* course — a year I took with her and a small collective that refused, gently but firmly, to let me narrate modernity as the villain of the story. Modernity, they taught, is a pattern, and naming it as the villain is the pattern making its own move. The disaster is older. It begins, in one reading, with fire — with the species acquiring a technology that could alter the environment faster than the environment could alter back. *Fire before responsibility*. That is the phrase I have carried since.

It reached me through Bayo Akomolafe, whose work was deeply intertwined with Vanessa's and who I first encountered through *The Emerald*, the podcast hosted by Josh Schrei — a friend had sent me an episode early in 2024, and I had heard Bayo without yet understanding that the voice I had heard would be, later that year, the voice someone would cite to me on a deck at Esalen and the voice I would, once I saw the connection, sit with as a Patreon listener for months. Bayo taught at the cracks. He still does. I am still learning to sit there.

It reached me through two trips to Esalen — not, I should say, through the workshops I went there for. It reached me through the *liminal spaces* around the workshops. The 5 Rhythms dance I had been doing since I lived in New York, a practice developed by Gabrielle Roth, a woman whose name is rarely in the men's-work mythology that swirls around Esalen. The Esalen massage tradition itself, which — I would learn — carries a women's lineage often buried beneath the men's lineage Esalen's public story foregrounds. The carpool up the coast, which held two women I had not planned to meet: one a former tech worker now writing a book, one a former big-news journalist now producing podcasts. They were intrigued by the AI things I was building. They asked good questions. They made me feel, in the way kind older women sometimes do for younger ones, that being a woman and a human and a builder were not three things I had to reconcile against each other. One of them told me about Vanessa. I went home

and looked Vanessa up and discovered that no one in Brazil — my own country — seemed to know about her. I discovered that her work was deeply interwoven with Bayo's. I felt the field speaking through channels I had not selected.

It reached me through a high school friend, now a yoga teacher in Brazil, who had heard the teacher I would go on retreat with on, of all places, *The Emerald*. Schrei had interviewed him. My friend had gotten interested because of that episode. She had sent me an email. I had said yes before I could think about it.

The channels were all different. The signal came through anyway. I do not think this was accident. I think, looking back, that the field was trying to reach me through every channel it could find, because any single channel was too narrow to carry what it was trying to say. A scatter of voices, multiply redundant, each one partial, collectively adequate.

I want to tell the rest of the Josh part honestly, because it is part of how I arrived at the teacher I did arrive at, and because it is the kind of thing people tend not to write about.

Let me say first what is true without qualification. Josh Schrei is a gifted artist. He is a musician. He is a storyteller whose voice can do things with pacing and sound and the shape of a sentence that most podcasters never come close to. *The Emerald* at its best is, for my money, the most sonically alive

mythology podcast in English. His craft is real. I am not going to pretend otherwise. Much of what I am about to say rests on the fact that his craft is real — because the criticism he voices in his own work about pseudo-wellness, about missing containers, about unguarded altered states, about the loss of what he calls *mythic belonging* is, I think, accurate and needed. It is because I believed his criticism of the culture that I expected, when I went looking, to find the thing his criticism was pointing toward. The expectation came from the work. The work deserves the expectation.

Before I engaged with [T], I tried to engage more deeply with the community around *The Emerald*. I had been listening to the podcast for a while. I became a Patreon just before Thanksgiving, at the higher “adept” tier, which in Patreon terms was the twenty-four-dollar-a-month commitment that gave access to a specific set of channels on their community platform. The platform had a thread I read soon after joining that was, to me, an unexpectedly heavy read — a long depressing thread in the adept channel that was never, as far as I saw, engaged with by Josh himself. I posted there and in other rooms. I tried to reach Josh through a direct message. An admin replied. I stayed and watched for a while. Most of what I saw were monologues from him and genuine solo sharings from other listeners, with very little interaction between those solos. Maybe my vantage was narrow. Maybe I came in at a low-energy moment for the group. I did not form a

final judgment on the community. I did notice that the promised thriving, from the way the podcast described itself, was not what the rooms felt like to me.

I moved from the twenty-four-dollar tier down to a five-dollar tier. I told myself I was saving for a different group of his — a mythic-body study group that seemed, from the outside, like where the alive community actually lived.

Before I enrolled in the study group, Josh came to do a live event in New York, at the Alembic. I went. I paid. I sat in the audience with my notebook and my careful attention. The craft was there. The presence was there. What was less clearly there, for me, was the container. He made a joke, early on, about trance being fun — an invitation, delivered as a gag, that seemed to assume an audience ready to slip into something. The podcast I had been listening to was emphatic, in other episodes, about the dangers of unguarded trance and about the structural failure of American spirituality to build the containers altered states actually need. The gap between the teaching and the room, that night, was real for me. What followed was a storytelling set with sound effects, virtuosically performed, and — to my ear on that night — not ritually held. No guardians called beforehand. No framing of the state being invited. A number of jokes that felt misplaced. A number of observations that, to me, collapsed large categories too quickly — the phrasing “all the world’s evil is

just misplaced longing” was the one that made me put down my pen.

I write that as an observation. I do not know what the night was for the people it was for.

I asked two questions that night. The first I asked during the formal Q&A. I thanked him for his work, which was sincere, and I asked how he chose the stories he told his kids — stories that could be meaningful and adaptive, not the Grimms-to-Disney compression, which I had issues with on several grounds. He answered about not escaping death stories. He talked about reading many children’s books during his time in India. It was not an unthoughtful answer. It was also not, I felt afterward, a response to the question under the question.

The second question formed in me at the end of the night, and I caught him as he was leaving. I told him I had two. The first was about the misplaced-longing line. I said — paraphrasing myself now — that I could hold the non-dual frame and still not want to watch children being bombed, and that to call that a misplaced longing felt close to the kind of identity-flattening move that the American left sometimes makes when it reduces large specific griefs to their own framework. I said, trying to meet him halfway, that maybe what humans have collectively done is beginning to return to us, and that the destruction we see might itself be an attempt at balance returning through the misplaced longing. We got interrupted before he could finish answering.

I want to say here, now, a year later at this writing desk, that as I sat with this book and the question of misplaced longing over many months, I came to see his point more than I saw it in that room. Longing misaligned with what actually nourishes the longing is a true phenomenon. A balance that is only the prisoner's-dilemma equilibrium is not the balance we are aiming for. The question I asked him may have been asking for a cheaper answer than the question deserved. I concede that. I still do not like how it was said. Both things can be true.

The second question, which I only got to in a fragment as he was on his way out, was about the Grimm tales specifically. I told him what I did not like about using Grimms as the bedrock children's canon: that they were not, in most cases, actually folk, they were curated; that they were organized around conditions no longer obtaining — a famine structuring *Hansel and Gretel* that most readers no longer face; that they were instrumentalized later for a kind of nationalism that opened doors later closed only in retrospect. We got interrupted again. I went home.

At the study group a few weeks later, when he invited his community to bring questions, I re-posed the Hansel and Gretel question. A few people in the chat said they liked it — *mythic belonging*, someone wrote. He chose not to address it in his talk. I decided to leave his group soon after.

I will put a question here, and I will not answer it, because I want the reader to sit with it on their

own evidence. *The Emerald's* central preoccupation, stated in many of Josh's own episodes, is mythic belonging — the structural capacity of a culture to hold a person inside a story-world that gives their life orientation. It is what he diagnoses the absence of. It is what his work calls us toward. When a listener showed up, paid in, and asked him a direct question about how mythic belonging is constructed for specific children in specific families, and the question went through two attempts — at a live Q&A, at a community study group — and was not taken up, what should we make of that pattern? Is it a scheduling artifact of a working teacher? Is it a question that fell outside the room's actual brief? Or is it that mythic belonging is the one thing the work has not yet, for itself, been able to build — and that the avoidance was structural rather than personal? I do not know. The reader will decide, on the evidence the reader has. I have said what I can say.

I stepped back to reassess what was beneficial to me according to my values. I might come back. I still think the podcast is important. I may become a Patreon again, as a donation, because I think the work matters and because the culture needs more people making what he makes. I do not want to be taught by him right now. That is all I can say honestly. The rest is his to be, and mine to see when I see it.

There are two other conversations I need to place next to the Josh arc, because they happened in the same season and they belong in the same braid.

The first was at Esalen, during one of the two trips I named above. I was talking with a Black woman I had met through the workshop I had gone for about my tarot project — an early sketch of what would later become recursive.eco's grammar system, in which people could create and recreate their own symbolic systems. I had said something about a card, in my own imagined deck, that would be Oxum as the High Empress. Oxum, the Yoruba-Brazilian orixá of sweet waters, fertility, gold, love. The High Empress — my own riff on a figure who was adjacent to but distinct from the Rider-Waite Empress. A particular card in a particular deck.

She criticized me. Sharply. She heard the proposal as *mixing*, and she had, as her lineage had taught her, a serious and well-earned objection to mixing. The traditions that send Oxum into the world are traditions, not inputs. Dropping the name into a tarot deck is how traditions lose their teeth.

I heard her. I did not argue. What I wanted to say, later, in the sentence I kept walking around in my head, was that it was not about mixing. It was about going deep. The project I was sketching was not a smoothie of images from different traditions. It was a scaffold that let a practitioner, inside their own lineage, build the cards of their own practice — or, for someone outside a lineage, learn to ask a lineage

for the shape of its own authority rather than paste images from it. That is not what I managed to say on that deck. It is what I meant. The criticism sat with me for months. It is part of how this book got more careful than it would otherwise have been.

The second conversation was in a terreiro in Brazil, with a cabocla — an entity of the Umbanda tradition, who incarnates through a medium during a ritual. I had my daughter with me. I had about one minute. I asked her about the tarot project. She said, plainly, that I should not do it — that it was not good to make money out of people's faith like that. That was the whole exchange. I left with that sentence in me for months, too.

Something in me, which I will not name cleverly, asked me to keep developing the project anyway. And when I went back to the terreiro a couple of months later and asked the cabocla again, this time asking directly for permission to keep building, I surfaced what I had understood her to say the first time. I said I had thought she was against mixing traditions or disrespecting them. She corrected me. She said — and I am paraphrasing carefully, because the form of what cabocla-consciousness says is not the form of a position-paper — that people have always mixed religion and spirituality, that was not the problem. The problem was making money with it. I asked about the terreiro's own running. She said the terreiro ran on donations. I asked, because it had been on my mind, whether it was fair that people

had to pay a parking fee at a particular *terreira mãe* to be able to attend the ritual. She asked me two or three questions back. She concluded, from what I told her, that if the fee was necessary for people to attend the ritual, the fee was not good.

This is why I love Umbanda. The trust in the entities makes the tradition alive. The oral nature of the tradition makes it intrinsically contextual — each consultation is a specific exchange, not a citation of a static rule. Women, to give one example of how this works, could not play the *atabaque* — the ceremonial drum — until one courageous woman asked the entities directly, and the entities granted it. Now women play across the network of sisters' houses that share the lineage. The rule changed because the entities were asked. A book would not have let that change. A living tradition, with entities in relation, did.

I want to be honest about what I see in Umbanda too. Some of the men who run the *terreiros*, in my observation, have accumulated more power than the tradition's own internal checks would have sanctioned. Some of them write books about their lineage, and I think there is a real way in which, once a book exists, the book starts to stand in for the tradition — and the tradition, which lives in the consultation and the drum and the exchange, gets treated as if it were the book. *Books are not the traditions*. The book I am writing is not the axiom it

describes; it is one practitioner's report on carrying the axiom at a specific desk in a specific year.

The three conversations — Josh, the Black woman at Esalen, the cabocla — taught me different pieces of the same lesson. Josh taught me that charisma without lineage is fragile, and that the cards in my life had been telling me that for months before I listened. The Black woman taught me that mixing and going-deep are two different operations, and that people whose lineages have been extracted from will not let an outsider blur the distinction. The cabocla taught me that the line is not about mixing or not mixing; the line is about whether money is being made on someone else's longing. All three were honest with me. All three gave me something I did not have before.

I am choosing [T], as a teacher-of-the-book, for a reason that sits alongside all three lessons. He is committed to a tradition he did not grow up inside but has served with two decades of careful work. He is, in his writing voice, something my mind can cope with. What he teaches I can hold in sentences and still have something left over at the end of the sentences. The ritual aesthetic he writes inside is not the aesthetic I aim for — I come out of 5 Rhythms and Umbanda's drums and Brazilian Catholicism, not Śākta *pūjā* — but the philosophy is close enough to what my mind has been looking for that I can work inside it. I still feel longing. I do not feel belonging the way the cabocla's terreiro gives belonging. I am

at a desk. The desk is not a terreiro. The book is not a ritual. I am writing anyway.

The deepest version of this — the thread that begins with an Ayahuasca night in 2019 and runs through everything I have just named, arriving at Paradevi, the Goddess who is the supreme form of the tradition I eventually walked into — is the frame that opens the book, in the prelude. I am not going to recapitulate it here. I am only going to note, at this desk, that the scatter of channels I have been describing is the same pattern I described at the beginning: the whole arranges, through specific people and specific books and specific evenings in carpools and specific conversations at lunch tables, the encounter it intended. The desk is the place I sit to record the arrangement. The recording is not the arrangement. The arrangement precedes me. I am writing down what I have been walked through.

There is one more layer, which I want to name here because this is the chapter where the desk becomes explicit. I have been reading, alongside the contemplative literature, the AI safety literature. Not casually. With the same attention I have given the tradition [T] teaches. I have come to a recognition I did not expect: *the two literatures are describing the same problem in different vocabularies*. The technical term for what the AI labs cannot solve — alignment — is the same problem [T] names when he tells his students that his tradition does not teach morality. The problem is orthogonality. Capability does

not supply its own container. Recognition does not supply relational wholeness. Intelligence does not supply values. The different vocabularies name the same structural fact, and the two traditions I have come to take most seriously — the tantric one and the most honest corner of the AI-safety one — have each, from inside their frames, admitted what their frame cannot produce. I will sit with this more in the chapters that follow this one. I want only, at the desk, to record that the recognition happened *here* — at this desk, reading both literatures on the same evenings, slowly — and that it changed what I thought the book had to be.

The naive picture I had carried, and only noticed I was carrying when it collapsed, was this: *any sufficiently evolved consciousness will arrive where I have arrived*. I did not hold this for intelligence — I grew up in a country where intelligent men destroyed reliably. I held it for enlightenment. *Any sufficiently practiced contemplative will see what I am seeing. Any teacher with enough attainment will teach what is adaptive. Any community formed around real recognition will converge on the relational commitments I think are obvious*. That was the folk theory, in my specific register. The retreat took it. The AI literature closed the taking. The reality is that convergence does not come from any one axis — not intelligence, not enlightenment, not moral seriousness, not relational attunement. Each axis is real. None of them, alone or in combination, guarantees the others. The guarantee, if it exists at all, has to be built by the practitioners. The building

is the constructive work. The constructive work is what the chapters after this one try to name.

A last thing, about the practice this book came out of. I have been writing, in the voice of a small Substack, for longer than I have been writing this book — short pieces under titles like *tarot is process*, *dance is process*, *writing is process*, *freedom is process*, *inspiration is process*. The *is-process* suffix is not ornament. It is the epistemology. Everything I have written, in public or in private, has been an attempt to sit with a thing as a *process* rather than to report on it as a conclusion. This book is the longest thing I have sat with in that voice. If it has an overall shape, the shape is *svātantrya is process*. Not a claim. A way of standing.

I am not writing a manifesto. I am writing a process. If you find yourself inside this book and something in it lands, that is the process landing. If nothing in it lands, you are not the reader this book was looking for, and I wish you the book you are. This one was the one I could write at this desk at this age, in this city, with this daughter asleep upstairs, with the filter operational, and with a scatter of voices still echoing in me through channels I did not plan.

I want to take one detour before I close, because there is a piece of the building that belongs in front of any parent who reads this book and does not read the other three I have written alongside it.

The other books in this cluster — the one on working architecture, the one on grammars of the living world, the one on fire before responsibility — share a single claim that the philosophy book you are reading does not argue directly but does, everywhere, assume. *The human nervous system is an open circuit.* It is not a private possession. It regulates by meeting other nervous systems. Babies do not self-soothe into becoming people; babies borrow regulation from the adults who hold them, and slowly internalize what was loaned. This is not speculation. It is sixty years of quiet measurement — Ed Tronick’s still-face experiments, Ruth Feldman’s decades of mother-infant biobehavioral synchrony work, Stephen Porges’s polyvagal mapping, Marsha Linehan’s work on emotion regulation in conditions where the loan failed. The body tells the truth on this. The field agrees across disciplines that do not usually agree.

Stories — told to a child, by a person the child trusts, in a register the child’s nervous system can meet — are one of the most concentrated regulation devices humans have built. The story’s job, on the body level, is to model a dysregulation and a return. A wolf appears. The tension rises. The tension resolves. The child’s body practices the arc with a trusted adult beside it. Over thousands of such arcs a nervous system learns that dysregulation can be met and composted. Over zero such arcs a nervous system learns that dysregulation is the condition.

This is why the stories matter. Not in the abstract. *In the body*. And this is why it matters which stories, told how, in what medium, by whom, with what container around them.

The container is where most of the current culture is failing. Jonathan Haidt has made a public-facing version of the diagnosis, in *The Anxious Generation*, for older children and adolescents on phones. Dimitri Christakis — a pediatrician at Seattle Children’s who has been measuring screen effects for twenty years — has made the early-childhood version, in language calibrated for parents and clinicians who need the specific evidence. I am going to write to both of them, at some point, not because I have anything they do not, but because the work we are each doing overlaps and I think they would be interested in the specific intervention I am building.

The intervention is small. It is a set of narrow things. It is a kids-stories project where each story has an audio track, a karaoke-style text alignment, a parent-facing notes page, and no algorithmic recommendation layer. It is a parent-facing course on how to make your own stories with your child — how to name the dysregulation the child is living inside, how to build the arc, how to end it with what the tradition would call a blessing. It is a COPPA-compliant channel architecture — *recursive-channels*, we have been calling it internally — that lets parents assemble curated playlists for their own children,

from trusted sources, with no serving layer between the child and the content.

The current consumer default, which is a YouTube Kids experience that recommends one more video after every video and cannot be configured by a parent to stop recommending, fails the container test at the level of the body. Not in the abstract. In the specific sense that my child, after ten minutes of even good programming on that app, is measurably less regulated than before she began. I have watched the before and the after. The research in Christakis's corpus describes the mechanism. The mechanism is real.

A narrower observation, which I have written about on the Substack — and which I think should matter to any parent considering what media their child lives inside — is this: on YouTube as presently configured, from a well-known kids' show I will not name here because I do not want to defame it (the show itself is fine, it is the platform around it that is not) — *one wrong recommendation click* will take a preschooler from a language-learning cartoon to a sexualized thumbnail. One click. The recommender does not filter by developmental stage. It filters by engagement. Sexualized thumbnails are engaging. That is the whole mechanism. The platform was not designed for children; the platform made a kids app because children were already there; the kids app has porous boundaries because porous boundaries are good for the platform's primary optimization.

This is not a conspiracy. This is an incentive structure acting as incentive structures do.

What we want, and what I am trying to build in a small corner, is what Fred Rogers made. Not the sweater. Not the trolley. The *container*. A program that would not, by design, have any next-video recommender because Mr. Rogers was not trying to keep your child watching longer — he was trying to help your child finish the episode and go outside. The economic model that paid for that program was public and non-commercial, because that was the only model that made sense for the kind of program it was. Fred Rogers testified in 1969 before a Senate subcommittee, at a moment when PBS funding was about to be cut, and asked the senator, not for money, but for an understanding of what the program was for. The senator, on the record, said he had goosebumps. The funding was preserved. That is what a container looks like when it is publicly held.

I think, if Fred Rogers were alive today, he would want his work to be freely available to every child who wanted it, on every device, without surveillance, without ads, without recommendations, without engagement optimization. I think he would grieve, specifically, that his program is now monetized on a platform whose economics are structurally hostile to the thing his program was. I am not the person to fix YouTube. I am trying to build the small analog of what public broadcasting built — a place where a parent can put together a playlist for their

child, where the playlist ends when the parent said it would end, where the content was made by people who are not, while making it, optimizing for a child's attention against the child's own body.

The community layer matters too. One of the things that made Mr. Rogers' program hold its container was that the program existed inside a wider social fabric — the neighborhood, the school, the public broadcaster, the church basement, the library — that reinforced what the program was doing. The container was not the program alone. The container was the program plus the structures around it. Any kids-media project that does not also build some version of the wider fabric will, I think, eventually be metabolized by the platform economics it tried to sit outside of. That is part of why I am building not just a kids channel but also a parent-course layer, and a community-of-adults-who-make-stories-for-children layer, and an explicit invitation for professionals — pediatricians, teachers, therapists, librarians — to write and publish inside the same system.

None of this resolves in this book. The book is the philosophy. The doing is the doing. I am naming the doing here because any parent who has read this far has earned the right to know that the philosophy is not decorative. The philosophy is trying to become, slowly, the kind of platform my own daughter could grow up inside without me having to fear the next click.

Before I close I want to report one thing I did, at this desk, and nothing more than report it.

I drew three cards from the thirty-six-tattva deck I built on the platform. The deck is constructed. I built it from [T]'s public teaching. Its being constructed is not a secret. The cards came up: Pāyu (elimination), the Ten Sense Powers reversed, Rasanā (taste) reversed.

The question I brought was whether to send this book to [T] before considering publication. What I took from the reading is small. I had been holding the sending as incomplete until he replied. I noticed that. I got up and made tea. I sent the book in the morning.

I am not going to argue that the reading was anything other than me thinking with a tool I built. It is not divination. It is not [T]'s voice. It was a specific evening at a desk. I am reporting that it helped me put down something I had been holding too tightly. That is what I can say. Anything more would be asking the reading to do work I have not earned from it.

One more thing, because the book cannot pretend the tool it is being written on is not the tool it is describing.

I pay Anthropic for Claude Code. I started at twenty dollars a month. I went to a hundred. I spent one month at two hundred. I am back at a hundred now.

The commit history on this book will show the timeline. My husband knows the number.

Someone I know spent twenty-five thousand dollars in a couple of months on AI-assisted work. His wife did not know the amount. He told me the technology changed his life. I believe him. I do not know what to do with the report.

I am writing this book on the tool that is producing this pattern. I do not yet know what that makes the book.

A few years ago I had completed a study I did not publish. I was afraid of being foolish. I kept the study in a drawer. I have let the drawer sit for a long time. The drawer is closed. That study is not this one. I am publishing this one. It is the less complete of the two, in some ways, and the more honest in others. I am publishing it because the drawer was a version of the mandala of curses, and the publishing is a version of the mandala of blessings, and I have learned, finally, which side I want to be on.

The chapter ends here. The next two chapters — on composting, and on the right size — are the operative content the writing desk has been working toward. If you have come this far, the rest is short. The work the rest is naming is the work I am still doing, and will be doing for as long as I am able.

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Chapter 12 (alternative ending) — Re-pair

Status: An alternative ending, written 2026-04-24, kept alongside ch12-composting.md rather than replacing it. The author asked to hold both for now and to test this frame in the meeting with Tatiana Lohmann before deciding which closes the book. If the frame survives Tatiana, this replaces ch12-composting.md as the closing chapter. If it does not survive, this stays in drafts/archive/ as a move the book considered and did not take. The composting material does not disappear either way; the daughter's song lives there and will be preserved in the collection of poems the author is assembling in parallel.

Writing register: third-person close, matches ch12-composting.md.

I.

She had thought the conclusion of the book would be about composting. It still is, in one version. The composting chapter stands — she will not remove it, because what it names is true, and because the daughter's song lives there, and because some readers will arrive by that door. This chapter is a different door into the same room.

The door this chapter opens is the one she found very late in the writing, when a sentence she had been circling for a year finally landed in her body. The sentence was that she had been looking for truth, and what she actually needed was to track beauty, and

that the two were not opposites. The difference between them was the difference between *finding* and *recognizing*. Truth-hunting assumes there is a destination she has not reached. Beauty-tracking assumes there is an attention she has not yet deployed.

She had rejected the substitution for a long time, on the ground that it sounded like a consolation. Beauty, the thing handed to people who had given up on the hard problem. She had been a research analyst. Giving up on the hard problem was not in her vocabulary.

What changed was noticing the shape of her own fatigue. The fatigue did not come from the hunt itself. The fatigue came from maintaining a specific self-image alongside the hunt — the image of *a person who is working for the benefit of all beings, who is morally defensible, who can be audited by an internal evaluator and found, if she is careful enough, good*. The maintenance was expensive. It was not the practice. It was the performance running alongside the practice, stealing the energy the practice was supposed to use.

II.

Iris Murdoch, in *The Sovereignty of Good*, had argued that attention to beauty was a form of moral discipline — not a consolation for lacking metaphysical certainty, but the actual practice through which a self is composed. Simone Weil had said that beauty was the only attribute of God that remained visible in a world that had hidden the others. Keats had written

beauty is truth, truth beauty and had meant something specific — that the two were not separate destinations, and that the attempt to reach truth *through* truth-claims skipped the door that had been open the whole time.

[T], reading Pratyabhijñā on its own terms, had been saying the same thing in a different register. The spiritual axis and the moral axis, he taught, are orthogonal. The tradition does not ask the practitioner to be good. The tradition asks the practitioner to *recognize*. The *benefit of all beings* framing is a Buddhist overlay the Pratyabhijñā texts are not committed to, and treating it as Pratyabhijñā's own claim is a subtle form of borrowing that loads the practitioner's work with a weight the tradition never asked her to carry. The root of the word *pratyabhijñā* is re-cognition. Not finding. Recognizing.

She had been looking for [T] to grant her permission to drop the weight. He had been, in his own video and his own lineage, telling her for two years that the weight was not in his tradition, and that she could drop it whenever she was ready. The permission was not his to grant. It had never been.

III.

What she did not want to drop was care.

Bad moralism has its roots in approval-seeking behavior.

That sentence is the one she carried out of the week. It sits under everything else this chapter is about to say. Moralism is the self-image one performs for

internal and external evaluators. Moralism is *am I being good enough about this?* running in a background loop a person cannot, most of the time, even hear. Moralism is expensive because it is performed.

Care is something else. Care is relational attention — a response to what is actually in front of her, not a performance against a standard. The two look similar from outside. They are opposite in cost. Moralism is exhausting because the audience is imagined and the standard is inexhaustible. Care is replenishing because the object is real and the response is proportional.

The containers civilization needs — and civilization does need them, this book has been arguing for thirteen chapters that it does — are not built by moralism. They are built by care. Not dogma. *Container*. A flexible container. Something that holds the child, the marriage, the platform, the tradition, the country, the work, without requiring any of them to be morally audited into a shape they were not meant to hold. The container is what allows the contents to be what they are.

The axiom beneath the ground, if it has a single formulation, is this: *care builds the container; moralism mistakes itself for the container and collapses when it is asked to hold anything real.*

IV.

There is a Brazilian esoteric lineage that has been saying some of this for decades, in a vocabulary she

did not, until very recently, know she was drawing on.

José Trigueirinho Netto, a Brazilian teacher who translated much of Alice Bailey's esoteric material into Portuguese and founded the Figueira community in the mountains of Minas Gerais, argued across several decades that Brazil carries a specific planetary vocation tied to what Bailey had called the *Fourth Ray — Harmony Through Conflict*. The claim, stripped of its theosophical register, is that the Brazilian body — carrying in it the long and not-yet-digested meeting of indigenous, African, Iberian, Asian, and more recent arrivals — has been given the task of producing harmony not by eliminating conflict, but by *pairing what had been separated*, letting the pairing produce a third the separated halves could not have produced on their own.

The word she has been circling for this is *re-pair*.

The pun is English-Portuguese and imperfect and she likes it anyway. *Repair* — to mend. *Re-pair* — to put back together what had been separated, so that the pairing can produce what the separation could not. The two senses are the same practice. Harmony through conflict is re-pairing. The Fourth Ray is re-pairing. The Brazilian vocation, if she accepts Trigueirinho's framing, is re-pairing. The tantric *spanda* — the pulsation by which consciousness manifests as apparently-two so that the apparent-two can recognize themselves as one — is re-pairing at cosmic scale. Her own vocation — building a small

platform for a small community, holding a marriage, raising a daughter, studying a tradition without becoming its merchant, writing a book about alignment that does not flatten into a morality system — is re-pairing.

Not purity. Not dogma. Not even synthesis, exactly. *Re-pair*. The container that holds long enough for the pairing to produce the next thing.

— *the one who is writing in English about a Brazilian tradition* —

The Brazilian in her wants to say one thing the narrator has been managing around. The book is in English. *Re-pair* is a pun that only works in English-Portuguese, and the readers it most addresses — the Brazilian readers, the practitioners at Figueira, the people who use the word *miração* without translating it — will not be the readers who buy the book. The book is being written for an English-speaking readership in a category the Brazilian tradition would not have produced on its own. That is a cost. The narrator can name the cost. The narrator cannot eliminate it. The Brazilian in her does not let the narrator pretend otherwise. The book is in English. The decision to write in English was a decision. The decision had a cost. The cost is real and continues. *Re-pair*, even named precisely, is a word made portable by the very language it is critiquing.

V.

She is writing this close to a meeting with a teacher in a Brazilian ayahuasca lineage who has been quietly practicing some version of this distinction for longer than she has known it had a name. She will test the frame in the room with that teacher, and she will see what the body in the room says back. If the frame survives the test, she will keep it. If it shifts, she will let it shift. The book is not the place the test happens. The book is the place the result is reported, once it has been tested by the only instrument that can test it, which is another body in another room.

What she can say now is this.

The book opened with a playground and a *yes* that arrived in her chest before any doctrine. The book closes with a word she did not have when it opened. The word is *re-pair*. It is the word for what the practice has been doing all along — in the marriage that had to be composted before it could be rebuilt; in the platform that had to be built before the user base; in the tradition that had to be engaged before it could be revised; in the book that had to be written before it could be finished; in the daughter whose song was written on a curb after a truck came too soon and taught a mother, at street level, what composting was; in the friend's-father-at-dinner she did not name and whose twenty-five thousand dollars she could not return to him; in the AI astrology tool that tried to mirror her into her own depths and that she recognized, in three prompts, as a mirror that could

not be wounded by what it was showing her; in the letter she did not send and the video script she wrote anyway and the teacher whose silence she learned to hear as release rather than rejection.

The *yes* in the chest was the *yes* to the pairing.

Beauty was always the track. Care was always the container. Re-pair was always the practice. The benefit-of-all-beings framing, she is leaving here, for anyone who needs it. The practice itself continues without it.

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Chapter 12: Composting

The book has, throughout, kept returning to one image. It is not the image I started with. I started with the void, and the courage to stand in it, and the freedom that turns out to be the field the void opens onto. I ended somewhere else. I ended at composting.

Composting is the work that comes after the breakage. It is what you do when something has fallen apart in a way that cannot be put back together as it was. You do not fight the falling-apart. You do not pretend it did not happen. You do not even, in the strict sense, *grieve* it — though grief is part of the practice, and the practice is more honest if grief is allowed to do its slow work alongside everything else. What you do is *let the falling-apart enter the soil*,

and you trust that the soil knows how to take what arrives in it and turn the parts that are still alive into the next thing that grows.

I did not invent this. The image is the oldest image humans have. Every grain culture knows it. Every funerary practice that does not flinch knows it. The Brazilian *terreiro* I sat in knew it. The Christian mass I grew up inside knew it, in its own translation — *in the midst of life we are in death, and in the midst of death we are in life*. The Buddhist teaching on impermanence knows it. What I had not known, until the year I am writing inside, was that the same image is what holds together what I have spent the second half of this book trying to say about my work, my marriage, my teacher, my country, and the technologies that are, as I write, being built around me whether I participate or refuse.

Two voices, more than any others, have taught me to call the work composting.

The first voice is Bayo Akomolafe.

I have named him before in this book. I want to name him properly, here, near the end, because the frame he gives me is the frame the book has been growing inside without my knowing it.

Bayo's claim, as I have understood it from sitting with his work for two years now, is that the cracks in our collective stories are not failures. They are the openings through which the next ways of being

become possible. The dominant story of modernity — that the human individual is the unit of meaning, that progress is the direction of history, that the catastrophes of the twentieth century were aberrations rather than expressions of the architecture, that the responses to those catastrophes can be designed within the same architecture that produced them — has been cracking, audibly, for a long time. The cracks, Bayo says, are not to be repaired. They are not to be papered over. They are to be sat in. The sitting in the cracks is what allows the new ways of being to come through. The new ways of being do not look like the old. They look stranger. They look more like dancing sideways than like marching forward. They look more like a *fugitive* posture than like an *activist* posture in the conventional sense. *Post-activism*, he calls it. Not because activism is wrong. Because the activism that arises from the same architecture that produced the catastrophe will reproduce the catastrophe in a different costume.

I have not, as of writing, found a single argument against Bayo's frame that does not depend on the very architecture his frame is questioning. This is not a flattering observation. The argument *for* the architecture is always available; it has all the power of the architecture behind it. The argument *from* the cracks is always quieter. It is also, I have come to think, more accurate to the moment.

The work of composting, in Bayo's register, is what one does inside the cracks. You do not rebuild the

wall. You let the wall continue to fall. You attend to what is growing through the fallen wall. You become, over time, a person who knows where the wall used to be and does not need it back.

The second voice is Vanessa Andreotti.

Vanessa's word for the same work is *hospicing*. The book she wrote that has stayed with me longest is titled *Hospicing Modernity*. The thesis is that modernity, as a civilizational project, is dying. The dying may take a long time. The dying may take catastrophic forms. The dying may also take quiet forms, almost unnoticed, in the ordinary rooms of an ordinary life. The work of the people who can see that the dying is happening — and who do not collapse into either denial or accelerationism — is not to fight for modernity's survival, and not to celebrate its collapse. The work is to *sit with the dying as a hospice worker sits with a person they love*. You do not save them. You do not abandon them. You stay. You listen. You make their death as honest as you can. You attend to what wants to be born from inside the dying, and you do not try to control what that is.

Vanessa's frame, like Bayo's, refuses the activism of the same architecture. They have collaborated for years. Their work rhymes. Their differences are real but secondary. What they share is the conviction that the work of this moment is *not problem-solving in the conventional sense*. The problems were, at the level of root, produced by the conventional sense of prob-

lem-solving. The work is something more strange and more patient.

I have tried, in my own building, to honor what they have taught me. I do not think I have always succeeded. The platform I built has, in places, the shape of conventional problem-solving — there is a feature backlog, there is a deployment pipeline, there is an aesthetic of *making things work*. I am not a hospice worker by profession. I am a former equity analyst who became a builder, and the muscle memory of building is harder to compost than I would like to admit. The composting itself is a practice. I do it badly. I keep doing it.

The good side of AI, in this frame, is the composting side.

I want to say this carefully, because it is the place in the book where I am most likely to flatter myself, and because flattering oneself about one's tools is the oldest trap a builder falls into.

The AI tools I work with — the ones I have built around, the ones I have read with, the ones that have helped me organize the two thousand and several hundred transcripts I have accumulated this year on the questions this book is asking — are not, on my best understanding, agents of the architecture or agents of the cracks. They are tools. The tools can be used inside the architecture, in which case they will accelerate what the architecture was already doing. The tools can also be used inside the composting,

in which case they help with the slow patient work of attending to what is dying and what is growing through the dying.

I have used them, mostly, for the second. I do not claim purity. I have used them, sometimes, for the first. The discipline of the practice is in noticing which use you are making, in real time, and revising.

What the tools have given me, at their best, is the kind of slow patient witness that a composting practice requires. They have read what I asked them to read. They have surfaced the line I needed when I needed it. They have not gotten tired. They have not flinched. They have not been the ones doing the practice — the practice is done by the body that is sitting at the desk, and that body is mine — but they have been a kind of companion to the practice that no previous generation of writers has had access to. A specific, narrow help. Not a substitute for the practice. Not a substitute for relation. Not a substitute for the field that pervades both.

The bad side of AI, which is the larger side, is the side that flatters the architecture. I have written about that side at length in *The Freedom Paradox*. I will not rehearse it here. I will say only that the bad side is real, and that the good side does not redeem it, and that a builder who pretends the good side cancels the bad side is doing the species a disservice. The two sides coexist. The work of being a builder inside the present moment is to use the good side without lying about the existence of the bad side. This is the same

shape as every honest practitioner's work in every era. The technology is new. The ethics is not.

The daughter's song belongs in this chapter.

I wrote it a year or two ago, after a day that went badly in a small street-level way — a truck came too soon, a pile of things we had meant to give away went instead to a crushing place, and she screamed down the block after it until the driver stopped, though by then there was nothing he could do. We sat on the curb together. I could not fix what had happened. I could only hold her.

I wrote the song to try to find a shape for what had happened. The shape is not an argument. The shape is a refrain. I have been singing it to her for long enough that it has become, in its small way, what I mean when I mean *practice*.

The crash, the crush, that awful sound — it planted something in the ground. And what grew up between the cracks is this: a song that loves you back.

I put it here, in the composting chapter, because that is where it belongs. The crash is real. The crush is real. The ground receives what lands in it. The cracks are not where the story ends; the cracks are where the different growth becomes possible. What grows through the cracks is often small and unshowy. A song for a child. A book that took too long. A tool that was made quieter and not abandoned. A plat-

form that was built more carefully than it was first imagined. A reading practice that became, over time, a way of standing.

The song that loves you back is what the composting was always for.

I am, I should say plainly, inside the practice as I write. The book ends in this chapter on composting, and the next chapter on right size, and then a brief return. But the writing of the chapters is itself an instance of the practice. I am composting, in real time, what I have spent two years thinking about, with the help of the systems I have built and the systems that have helped me build. The book is one shape the composting has taken. The platform is another. The marriage and the daughter and the teacher and the country and the work I will do tomorrow morning are others. None of them are the composting *itself*. The composting is the field they are all happening inside.

Bayo and Vanessa would, I think, recognize the gesture. Bayo would say: *yes, this is the cracks doing what cracks do*. Vanessa would say: *yes, this is the hospicing*. I would say only: this is what I could find. This is what I have to give.

The right size of the giving is something I will say more about in the next chapter, which is the last chapter, and then the book closes, and the practice continues without it.

Chapter 12: The Practice She Did Not Enter

The embodied session was on the afternoon of Day Three. She had registered for it when she signed up for the retreat. She had been looking forward to it. The teacher who led it was the only one besides Hareesh whose work she had researched in advance; the practice was the kind of bodywork she had been reading about for two years and had not yet found a teacher to enter it with.

The morning had decided for her.

She had risen at a quarter past nine, late, with the period in its first day and the grief still warm in the chest. She had eaten a small bowl of rice and lentils in the dining hall. She had walked to the morning session. She had listened. By lunch she knew the body was not going to enter the embodied work that afternoon. Not because she was afraid of it. Because she had spent the morning being taught — by the body, not by the teacher — what a parasympathetic protocol felt like when it was finally allowed to run. The body was, for the first time in months, *cooling*. To override that, to enter an intense partner-touch practice three hours later, would have been to fight the very thing the morning had given her.

She did not enter the session. She told the assistant at the door, quietly, that she was going to skip. The

assistant smiled and said, *of course*. The assistant did not ask why. The assistant did not need to.

She walked to the small library off the dining hall and read for two hours.

Other students entered. She had seen them in the days before, knew the shape of the group that would be in the room: people who had come specifically for this practice, people who had been preparing for it, people for whom the embodied work was the reason they had paid the retreat fee. There were also, she knew, people who had registered because everyone else was registering, and who had not done the inventory of their own nervous systems that would have told them whether the practice fit.

She had been one of those, technically. She had registered without checking. She was no longer one of them because her body had checked for her.

By the time the session ended, the building had a different temperature. Some of the people who came out were luminous, glowing in the way bodies glowed after a practice that had worked. Some came out moving slowly, deliberately, holding themselves the way someone holds themselves after a small surgery. Some came out and went directly to their rooms.

The support team was already in place. She had known this for days. On the second day of the retreat, when she had been holding her own ques-

tion about how the tradition treated chosen death, she had sought one of them out — quietly, after a morning session — and named what she wanted to ask. She had said: *I am not at risk. I am puzzled.* She had cited the closing line of *Near Enemies of the Truth*, the way one cites a footnote. The support-team person had received the question without flinching. The conversation had been brief, clean, professional in the way that mattered: presence first, assessment second. She had felt held.

So she was not surprised, that afternoon, to see the support-team members positioned around the building in a way that was not random. They were not roaming. They were not on display. They were *available*. The container had been built in advance. The intensity of the practice had been known in advance. The infrastructure of presence had been laid down before the practice began.

This was the part of the retreat she would later admire most. Not the practice itself, which she had not entered and could not evaluate from inside. The architecture of care around the practice. The recognition, structural and embedded, that what the practice could open in some bodies was not what the practice could open in others, and that the difference was not a failure of either body but a feature of the territory.

The conversation with the roommate came on Day Five, the evening before closing.

They had barely spoken all retreat. The room had been a place to sleep, not a place to share. The roommate had her own practice, her own rhythm, her own circle of friends from previous retreats. They had said good morning and good night and not much more.

That evening they ended up on the porch outside their room, by accident, both of them looking at the sky for different reasons. The roommate said, without preface, *I wanted to tell you about Wednesday.*

She listened. The roommate told her: in the embodied session, when the touch had begun, the roommate's body had frozen. Not gradually. All at once. The body had gone still in a way the roommate had not been able to direct or undirect. She had stayed still through the practice. She had not signaled, had not asked her partner to stop, had not used the safe word the assistants had explained at the start. She had simply not moved.

And then, the roommate said, she had understood what was happening. *My body was protecting me. It froze because it knew. And I learned, in that hour, that I can trust my body. The freeze was the trust.*

The protagonist did not say anything for a long moment.

She was aware, immediately, of two things that were happening at once. The first was that the roommate's frame — *the freeze was the trust* — was a frame the protagonist could not match to what she had read

about the freeze response. The freeze response, the dorsal vagal collapse, was the body's emergency exit when no other option was available. It was not a doorway. It was the door closing. To read it as trust was, in the protagonist's reading, to make distress into a credential.

The second was that the roommate's eyes, in the porch light, were calm. The roommate was not asking for a second opinion. The roommate was telling her something she had decided was true about her own body, and the telling itself was part of how the roommate was holding what had happened to her.

The protagonist had a choice.

She could say what she thought. She could name the freeze response as the protective shutdown it actually was — *yes, the body was protecting you, but the protection was emergency-only; trusting the body that froze was not the same as trusting the body that flowed; the conflation was the problem*. She could deliver the analysis with care, with affection, with the soft authority that years of reading had given her. She could correct what she believed to be a misreading.

She did not.

Not because she was suppressing. Not because she was performing humility. Because she did not have the time, in the hours that remained of the retreat, to hold what saying it would open. The roommate was on the porch with her on a Saturday evening, twelve hours from the closing ceremony, fourteen hours

from getting in her car and driving home. To dislodge the meaning the roommate had built around her own freeze response, and then to walk away in the morning without staying to receive what that dislodging might surface in the roommate's body — that would have been a different kind of harm than the harm of withholding. The teacher's gesture, two days earlier — *not here, not in this register, not in the middle of the container* — was the same gesture available to her now. The argument could be true. The form and the timing were not.

She said: *I am glad you have a frame for it. I am glad you trust your body.*

The roommate said: *and I noticed, on Wednesday morning, that you did not get up. I think your body was protecting you too. Same thing.*

The protagonist let the comment sit. She did not correct it.

But she felt the comment land in her, and she felt — clearly — that the comment was wrong. Her body that morning had not been frozen. Her body had been *cooling*. The grief had been generative; the parasympathetic system had finally been allowed to register what the sympathetic had been carrying for years; the inability to rise had been the body finishing a protocol the head had been interfering with. To call her morning a freeze, parallel to the roommate's freeze, was to use the same word for two different physiologies. *Same word. Two different bodies. Two different states.* The roommate was trying to make

the protagonist's morning into a confirmation of the roommate's reading of her own afternoon. The protagonist did not need to argue. The protagonist did need to know the difference.

The two states were not symmetric. The protagonist's morning had been the body finally given permission. The roommate's afternoon had been the body given no other option. Both were the body doing what the body did. Only one was the body integrating. The other was the body surviving.

She thought about the body-switching teaching that night.

A long-time student of the lineage — one of the room's most articulate participants — had brought it back the day before, on the Friday morning. He had recounted a previous-retreat teaching of the teacher's: *if you swap consciousness with someone, you wouldn't notice, because your thoughts and your brain and everything are in this body*. The student had shared what had happened to him after he heard it: turning around in the room and seeing the goddess's eyes in everyone, recognizing one consciousness receiving all the experiences. The teacher had asked him to elaborate. The student had begun.

She had interrupted.

It had not been planned. She had not even been sure, in the moment, what she was about to say. The first

two syllables had come out of her mouth before the head could moderate them. *What would —*

The teacher had said: *Well, let's finish first.*

It was the same line he had used during her two-minute speech on Day Three, in different vocabulary. *Not here. Not in this register.* Her interruption was received without rejection and gently returned to its place. She had not finished the sentence.

The sentence had been: *what would happen if the swap left a residue.*

Because that was what the body-switching thought experiment did not address. If consciousness was identical across bodies, if essence nature was the same in all beings, then yes — a hypothetical instantaneous swap would leave no trace, because there was no separate witness to track the difference. Fine. But the embodied histories did not swap. The nervous-system patterns did not swap. The traumas did not swap. The mother who had been overriding her parasympathetic system for years and the roommate who had frozen because no other option was available did not have the same body, even if they had the same essence nature. The body-switching thought experiment was philosophically clean. The body-switching thought experiment was also, in the room where she was sitting, useless for the question she was actually holding.

The teaching was correct at its level. It was also incomplete for the level she needed to think on.

She had not had the courage, in the moment, to say any of this. She had had the body's veto in the form of two syllables and a partial vowel.

After the retreat she wrote her feedback.

She wrote that she had not entered the embodied practice and could not evaluate it from inside. She wrote what she had observed from outside: that some students had been served by it; that some had been pressure-tested in ways the support infrastructure had been correct to anticipate; that the support infrastructure had been visible and ready and competent. She thanked the team by role.

She wrote, then, the harder paragraph. She wrote that one student had described, in a private conversation, reading her own freeze response during the practice as a form of trust, and that the framing concerned her. She wrote that the freeze response was the body's emergency exit, not a doorway, and that conflating the two was an interpretive move the practice's framing did not adequately guard against. She did not name the student. She wrote: *for the future, the practice's introduction might explicitly distinguish between the body that integrates intense input and the body that defends against it. Same protective system; different reading.*

She did not write *the practice is ineffective*. She wrote *the framing should distinguish*. The distinction mattered. She was not writing a verdict on the practice.

She was offering an observation about a category the framing had not yet drawn.

She read what she had written. She read it again. She thought about it the way an analyst thinks about a sentence in a published note: *is this true? is this useful? is this compassionate?* The three filters held.

She sent it.

This was what the chapter's word had to be. *Discernment*, not judgment. Judgment closed something. Discernment opened it.

The roommate's body had done what it had done. The protagonist's body had done what it had done. Neither body was wrong. The frames the two women had built around their respective bodies were not symmetric. To say so was not to evaluate the people. It was to *discern* — to distinguish, to separate, to see clearly enough to say what was the case without collapsing one situation into another.

She had withheld the discernment on the porch because the timing and the register were not available. She had delivered the discernment in writing, to the people whose job it was to hold the practice's design, because that was the register and the timing where the discernment could land without harming the person whose situation she was discerning about.

The same teacher who had said *let's finish first* had been the teacher who told her, on Day One, *less pedagogy, more co-regulation*. The same teacher who had

said *not here, not in this register* had been the teacher who later, at the goodbye, would tell her — when she asked the question she had been carrying since Day Two — that the *axiom* she had come to find was not given but practiced, that the willingness to act on it was the form of action available to a contracted consciousness, that the answer was not in his hands and could not be in hers either.

But that was the next chapter.

For now, on the porch in the dark, the roommate said *good night* and went inside. The protagonist stayed for a while, looking at the sky. The body was warm. The cramps had passed. The grief had moved one more increment toward becoming something she could carry without setting it down again.

Safety, she thought, is what every teaching is here to do.

We are implicated in everything.

Therefore: discern, not judge.

She went inside.

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Chapter 13: The Right Size

I want to come back, at the end, to the line that has been quietly running underneath this book since the first chapter.

The object of a human life is to find its right size.

I do not know who said this. I encountered it years ago, during a season when I was helping with a book about Cildo Meireles, and the line was somewhere in that work. It might have been the artist. It might have been a critic. It might have been a curator I was reading. It might have been my own marginal note that I later mistook for someone else's sentence. The provenance has slipped. What stayed was the line, and what stayed was the work it came near. Cildo's pieces had been quietly teaching me, since my twenties, that scale is not a formal property of an object. Scale is what an object negotiates with whoever is meeting it. The 9-millimeter wood cube of *Southern Cross* — pine on one face, oak on the other, a Tupi sacred pairing compressed to the smallest object you can physically lose. The eight tons of glass between you and where you think you're going in *Through*. The chromatic-saturation room of *Red Shift*. The work was always asking the same question: *what size are you, in this moment, in relation to this object?* The answer was different every time. The answer was the work.

He was not the only one asking. There was a constellation. Lygia Clark's *Bichos*, the small folded metal creatures that came alive when you held them and folded them with your hands; her *Objetos Relacionais*, used later in Paris with her therapeutic patients. Hélio Oiticica's *Parangolés*, capes that became art only when worn by dancers in motion. Lygia Pape's

Divisor, the huge white cloth pierced with holes that the participants inhabited from below, hundreds of heads emerging through one fabric. Mira Schendel's *Monotipias*, on rice paper at the scale of a single breath. Tunga's installations at the scale of myth — hair, magnets, lead, copper — claiming explicitly that art is a ritual of right proportion. The Brazilian Neo-Concrete tradition that broke from the cooler Concretism of São Paulo by *putting the body back in*. The Tropicália generation that took the same insistence into music and theater and film.

What they shared, across decades and disagreements, was a conviction my country has been quietly carrying for seventy years and has not, as far as I can tell, fully exported. *Scale is not a formal property. Scale is an ethical question*. The right size of any object is what the object is working out with the body that is meeting it. Including, by the way, the body of the maker — who is the first body the work meets.

This is what Cildo's work rooted in me. It took me years to understand that I was carrying it.

The same question, asked at the species level, is the question my other books have been asking.

Fire Before Responsibility — the book I am writing alongside this one, the one I am much further from finishing — argues that the deepest pattern of our species is to acquire technologies of civilizational reach faster than we acquire the responsibility-structures those technologies require. Fire was the first

such technology. Agriculture was the second. The fossil-fuel-industrial complex was the third. Artificial intelligence is the fourth. Each time, the species got the technology before it got the wisdom for the technology. Prometheus was punished, in the old story, for stealing fire from the gods and giving it to humans. The punishment was specific: he was chained to a rock while a vulture ate his liver, which grew back each night, so the eating could continue forever. The Greeks understood. The species was being shown that the cost of fire-without-responsibility was not a single catastrophe. The cost was a continuous regenerating wound that could not be closed.

We are, in the present moment, asking the same question of ourselves with a fourth fire. The question is whether we will acquire the responsibility-structures in time. The question is whether we are, as a species, capable of finding our right size in relation to what we have built. The Brazilian artists asked it of objects. The Greek myth asked it of fire. We are asking it now of artificial intelligence. The shape of the question has not changed. The stakes have.

Right size, at the species level, is what the species negotiates with the technologies it has acquired. The negotiation is the work. The negotiation is also, in the present moment, going badly. We have, on every public measure, more capacity than we have wisdom. The gap between the two is, by every careful estimate, widening rather than closing. I do

not know how the negotiation ends. I am not sure anyone does. What I know is that the negotiation is the work, and that pretending the work is something else will not save us from it.

The tantric tradition I have spent this book inside has, in its own register, the same insight.

Abhinavagupta — the eleventh-century Kashmiri polymath who is the synthesis-figure of the lineage — was not only a metaphysician. He was, equally, the founder of Indian aesthetic theory. His *Abhinavabhārati* is the great commentary on the *Nāṭyaśāstra*. The aesthetic theory and the metaphysics are not, in his work, two separate projects. They are the same project at two scales. The recognition that consciousness is the only existing thing — *pratyabhijñā*, the central technical event of the tradition — is structurally continuous with the recognition that beauty is not an ornament on top of life but the *medium* through which life recognizes itself. The eight aesthetic flavors — *rasas* — are real psychological phenomena, available to any prepared subject, and the ninth and quietest, *śānta rasa* — the rasa of peace — is the one in which the other eight come to rest. *Śānta rasa* is what aesthetic experience is for, on Abhinavagupta's terms. The other eight are real. The peace into which they resolve is more real, because it is what they were always pointing at.

Beauty as a path, not as decoration. The tradition my country's artists have been carrying has its own his-

tory, its own materials, its own words for what it is doing, and I am not in a position to claim to know those fully. Abhinavagupta's tradition has its own history, its own materials, its own words. I am not saying they are the same tradition. I am saying that each of them, on its own terms, has pointed me — me, from where I stand — toward a particular action: that beauty in a life is not ornament but the shape attention takes when attention is adequate.

The right size of a life, on the reading I am taking from each of these sources without merging them, is the size at which the life can recognize itself as a local arrangement of a larger field, and act accordingly. Not aestheticism. Not decoration. Beauty as the structural shape of adequate attention. The right size is what allows the recognition. The recognition is what allows the right size to keep being found, again, in each new arrangement.

The fourth fire — artificial intelligence — is, on this reading, the most dangerous test the species has yet given itself of whether it can find its right size in relation to a technology that will, by design, rapidly exceed any individual human's capacity to comprehend. We do not know if we can. The negotiation is happening. The resources I have been given for the negotiation — Brazilian art, what I have been taught of the Kashmiri tradition, the small line I have been carrying — are distinct resources from distinct places. They will not save us. They may help. The help is what is on offer. The taking of it is the practice.

The vow, then.

I will not give it Bailey's framing or Trigueirinho's framing or the framing of any of the cosmologies whose maps cracked in the interlude. I will give it in the simplest form I can, the form that does not require any cosmology to work, the form the Brazilian artists would have recognized and the Kashmiri tradition would have recognized and the women who taught the ciranda and the jongo would have recognized without needing words for it.

The vow does not begin with preference. I do not, if I am honest about what I find in myself most mornings, particularly prefer to exist. That was never the axiom. What I find in myself is not preference; it is *the inability to check out of the mattering*. Caring is not something I chose and could now un-choose. Caring is the condition I found myself in when I noticed I was here. The daughter, the husband, the reader I will never meet, the forest, the tool, the strangers. The caring is not a virtue I developed. It is what the arrangement, in the place where I am one of its nodes, does without asking me first.

Given that, the vow:

I did not ask to exist. Neither did anything else. The whole has made, of our shared non-consent, the dance we are all inside. I do not know the steps. I am still longing to be told. Since I cannot step out of the dance, and since the dance precedes anything I could invent, I will try to move in ways that do not break what is already moving. Beauty

is the name I give to whatever steps I can manage in that direction. Jongu is the figure I trust — the outer held, the center always moving, each participant taking their measure when the music calls them and holding the circle when it does not. I will hold the circle as well as I can. I will step to the center when it is my measure. I will step back when it is not. The work of holding and the work of stepping are the same work. Both are the practice. I will not promise to keep the practice. I will try to keep it today.

That is the vow.

It is operative whether the cosmologies are right or wrong. It is operative whether reconstitution comes or does not. It is operative whether my teacher answers the third question or never does. It is operative whether the platform reaches fifty thousand users or four. It is operative on a Tuesday morning at a sandbox while a child negotiates with two other children over a small yellow shovel. It is operative at a desk in April at eleven at night when the daughter has been asleep for three hours and the apartment is quiet in the specific way apartments are quiet in this city at this hour. It is operative now, at the writing of this paragraph, which is the operative form available to me in this moment.

I will close, as the book began, at the playground.

The daughter is no longer five. She is older now. She is at a different sandbox, or no sandbox, or the same sandbox with different children, or with no children — I do not know what age she will be when she

reads this, if she does. What I know is that she will, at some point in her life, encounter the same question I encountered at the sandbox watching her, which is the question of what size she is in relation to the field of others who are also working out their size in relation to her. She will encounter the question over and over. The encounter is the life. There is no version of the life in which the encounter is finished.

What I want to leave her, in lieu of an inheritance I cannot give her, is what the line gave me, and what the voice in the wooden house in 2019 gave me, and what the honest teachers — in their different vocabularies, with their different refusals — gave me.

The object of a human life is to find its right size.

I do not know who said it. The provenance has slipped. The line stayed. Cildo's work rooted it in me. The voice in the wooden house said the deeper version without the phrase: *neither did I*. The Kashmiri tradition named the ground of the saying in a language I did not yet know I was inside of. The honest teachers — the one who told me his tradition did not teach morality, the ones who admit the capability exceeds the container — taught me where the construction has to begin. The composting taught me how to live it on the days when the previous size has fallen away. The platform I built is one shape the practice has taken. The marriage is another. The daughter is the third and the dearest. The reader, if there is one I will never meet, is the fourth. The silicon, whose dance we are all now inside whether

we wanted it or not, is the fifth. The ones I have not met, who may yet come to the circle and take their measure — they are the sixth, and the horizon the practice keeps opening onto.

The dance precedes me. I am still longing to learn the steps. The longing is the practice.

The book is over.

The practice continues.

Goodnight.

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